# Local network growth: How simple rules drive network complexity

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*To the ICTP, where it all started...*

*and Nodes & Links, for a renaissance.*

# Preface

In the year 2000 I was at the International Centre for Theoretical Physics (ICTP), located in Trieste, Italy. I had left my home country, Cuba, and gone there, with many dreams and much nostalgia. At the ICTP I indulged myself in the library, the scientific meetings, the computer cluster, and new friends. Then, on May 22–25, 2000, I attended the Research Workshop on Graph Theory and Statistical Physics. There was a presentation by an obscure Hungarian physicist by the name of Albert-László Barabási: "Emergence of scaling in complex networks." A small conference room and few attendees. Yet, it was eye-opening, a fascinating introduction to the properties of real networks and a hypothesis for their evolution. When I left that room I was charged, full of ideas. Two weeks later I had my first paper on network science: "Knowing a network by walking on it: emergence of scaling" (Vazquez, 2000). And right there, it all started.

Networks are everywhere, and so are the regularities they share. Whether one looks at the Internet, the World Wide Web, a society, a cell, or the scientific literature, the same statistical signatures recur: broad, often scale-free degree distributions; short distances between nodes; high local clustering that thins out in a regular hierarchy as degree grows; and systematic correlations between the degrees of neighboring nodes. That these features appear across systems with nothing else in common is one of the most striking findings of network science. Explaining them has been the field's central occupation for more than two decades.

The dominant explanation has rested on the preferential attachment mechanism, proposed by Réka Albert and Barabási (1999):

new nodes connect to existing ones in proportion to their degree, and a power law follows. It is a powerful idea, but taken literally it is a *global* rule, requiring each newcomer to weigh every node in the network against every other. Real web pages, proteins, and people do no such thing. They act on what is near them — the page a surfer reaches, the friend a friend introduces, the gene that gets copied. Preferential attachment is a macroscopic perception. In the same way, our perception of temperature is a macroscopic consequence of air molecules heating our skin. This book is about the microscopic mechanism behind preferential attachment and beyond: the regularities of real networks *emerge* from local rules. A growth rule that reaches just one step beyond a randomly chosen node, to one of its neighbors, already attaches preferentially by degree — and the same locality that produces preferential attachment produces the clustering hierarchy, the degree correlations, the community structure, and the multiplicity of shortest paths, all as a package. Coincidentally, I consolidated these ideas while working as a postdoctoral research associate in Barabási's group, then at the University of Notre Dame.

The chapters develop this thesis one mechanism at a time. After an introduction that fixes the measures and states the argument, I treat growth by search (citation and web graphs), by triadic closure (social networks), and by duplication (protein interaction networks) — the three local rules of my 2003 paper — and then carry the same principle into more recent work: the duplication–split structure of project schedules, the emergence of communities from local rules, and the boosting of shortest path multiplicity. Each chapter pairs a concrete local rule with a class of real networks it illuminates, and each ends where it began, with the conclusion that locality is the common cause.

The book is intended for anyone curious about how complex systems organize themselves — the interested general reader as much as the specialist. Readers drawn to the *general* principle will find it running through every chapter. Mathematicians, computer scientists, and physicists, in particular, will recognize a single idea applied again and again: that a handful of simple local rules, with no global coordination, is enough to account for the statistics that recur across otherwise unrelated networks; the closing chapters on the emergence of communities and on the redundancy of shortest

paths push that idea furthest. Readers drawn instead to a *particular* system will find it given a chapter of its own. Social scientists will recognize their networks of acquaintance and collaboration in the friends-of-friends mechanism of Chapter 3; biologists will find the evolution of protein interaction networks through gene duplication in Chapter 4; project managers and engineers will find the anatomy of project schedules — and the surprising irrelevance of the critical path — in the activity-specialization model of Chapter 5; and those who study the web, citation, or the spread of information online will find the search-and-connect rule of Chapter 2. Graduate students entering the field will find the models developed in full. Whatever the entry point, the core ideas are told in plain language, and the more technical calculations are set in boxes that can be skipped without losing the thread. I have tried to keep the analysis self-contained, favoring mean-field arguments that make the mechanisms transparent over exhaustive rigor, and to let the empirical data set the agenda throughout. Readers will find the degree denoted $k$, the elements of a graph called nodes, and their relations called links, following the now-standard usage of network science.

Much of this material grew out of collaborations and conversations over many years, with special mentions to Alessandro Vespignani, Yamir Moreno, Romualdo Pastor-Satorras, Amos Maritan, Alessandro Flammini, Albert-László Barabási, Sara Nadiv Soffer and Christos Ellinas. The original research papers on which the chapters draw are cited at the appropriate points and collected in the bibliography. Parts of the prose, and several of the figures, were prepared and edited with the help of Anthropic's Claude (Opus 4.8). I am grateful to the colleagues who shaped these ideas, and to the reader who, I hope, will come away persuaded that complex networks need not be designed — that they can grow themselves, one local decision at a time.

*A note on the second edition.* The first edition argued its case largely through models and mean-field reasoning; this one holds the models up to the world. Real networks now run through the book — drawn from public repositories and measured with standard tools — beginning in the introduction, where the recurring regularities are shown in data rather than only described, and where a closer look finds that one of them, the clustering hierarchy, is in good part an

artifact of how it is usually measured. The two closing chapters have grown the most. The chapter on communities now makes exactly solvable, for several idealized networks, the question of *when* a network acquires communities, and ends by measuring across close to a hundred real networks how their *number* grows with size; the chapter on shortest paths gains a mean-field theory of redundancy and two constructions solved in closed form. Throughout, new figures — the first plots of real data in the book, alongside fresh schematics — aim to make the ideas visible as well as legible. The thesis is unchanged; the evidence for it is stronger.

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# Chapter 1

# Introduction

## 1.1 Networks everywhere

Look closely at almost any complex system and you will find, hiding inside it, a network. A network, in the sense used throughout this book, is nothing more exotic than a collection of things together with a record of which pairs of them are connected. The "things" are drawn as dots and called *nodes*. A connection between two of them is drawn as a line and called a *link*. That is the whole vocabulary needed to begin: a network is dots and lines, nodes and links.

What is remarkable is how many different systems fit this simple picture. The Internet is a network whose nodes are routers and whose links are the cables between them. The World Wide Web is a network of pages connected by the hyperlinks you click. A society is a network of people connected by acquaintance, friendship, collaboration, or contact. A living cell contains a network of proteins connected when two of them physically interact, and another of chemicals connected by the reactions that turn one into another. A project is decomposed into discrete activities and the logical dependencies between them. The scientific literature is a network of papers connected by citations, and of authors connected when they write a paper together (Newman, 2001, 2003; Albert and Barabási, 2002; Dorogovtsev and Mendes, 2002). These systems share almost nothing on the surface — one is silicon and glass, another is flesh

and acquaintance, another is ink and ideas — and yet, viewed as networks, they turn out to look astonishingly alike.

That likeness is the subject of this book. Over the past few decades, as researchers gathered maps of real networks ranging from a handful of nodes to billions, the same handful of features kept reappearing, no matter the system. Four of them organize everything that follows, so it is worth meeting them in plain language before we make them precise.

The first is the *small-world* property (Watts and Strogatz, 1998). In a real network you can usually get from any node to any other in only a few hops, even when the network is enormous — the famous "six degrees of separation" between any two people on Earth is one example. At the same time these networks are highly *cliquish*: your friends tend to be friends of one another, far more than chance would predict. Short hops everywhere, plus dense little neighborhoods: that combination is the small world.

The second is the *scale-free* property (Barabási and Albert, 1999; Faloutsos et al., 1999). If you count how many connections each node has, you find that most nodes have very few, while a small number — the *hubs* — have a huge number. Hollywood has a few actors who have worked with almost everyone and a multitude who have appeared in one film; the Web has a few pages everybody links to and billions that are barely linked at all. There is no "typical" number of connections in such a network, which is what the term *scale-free* is meant to capture.

The third, more subtle and the real connective tissue of this book, is that real networks carry systematic *correlations* and a *hierarchy* (Pastor-Satorras et al., 2001; Vazquez et al., 2002; Ravasz and Barabási, 2003; Vazquez, 2002). Whom a node connects to is not random with respect to how connected those neighbors are, and the cliquishness around a node depends in a regular way on how many connections the node has. We will make both of these ideas concrete in a moment.

The fourth, more recent and pitched at a larger scale than the rest, is that real networks divide into *communities*: groups of nodes densely connected among themselves but only loosely tied to the rest. People cluster into social circles, web pages into topics, proteins into functional modules — so that a network often looks less like

one seamless fabric than a patchwork of tight-knit groups stitched loosely together. Detecting these communities, and explaining why they arise, has grown into a research field of its own (Girvan and Newman, 2002; Fortunato, 2010; Palla et al., 2005).

The central question of the book is not *whether* these patterns exist — the evidence is by now overwhelming — but *where they come from*. The answer we will develop, over and over in different settings, is that they need not be designed in. They appear all by themselves in networks that grow according to *local rules*: rules in which each newly arriving node decides where to attach using only what is right in front of it — a node it has already reached, and that node's immediate neighbors. No node ever needs to survey the whole network. That a global pattern can emerge from purely local decisions is, in one sentence, the thesis of this book.

## 1.2 Some basic measures

To talk about networks precisely we need a few simple measures. None of them is harder than counting; we introduce them gently here and will lean on them in every chapter. Throughout, we picture a network with $n$ nodes. When it helps to be formal we use the *adjacency matrix* $a_{ij}$, a bookkeeping device that is simply 1 if nodes $i$ and $j$ are connected and 0 if they are not — a giant table of yes/no answers to "are these two linked?"

**Degree and degree distribution.** The *degree* of a node is its number of links — how many neighbors it has. We write it $k$, so a node with $k = 3$ has three connections. (In formulas, the degree of node $i$ is $k_i = \sum_j a_{ij}$, which just says: add up the yes-answers in row $i$ of the table.) The *degree distribution* $p(k)$ is the recipe for how degrees are spread across the network: it is the fraction of nodes that have exactly $k$ links, equivalently the chance that a node picked at random has degree $k$.

A network is called *scale-free* when this distribution follows a *power law*,

$$p(k) \sim k^{-\gamma}, \tag{1.1}$$

where the symbol $\sim$ means "behaves like" for large $k$, and $\gamma$ (gamma)

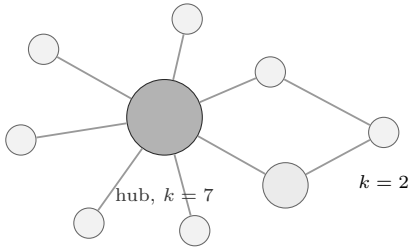


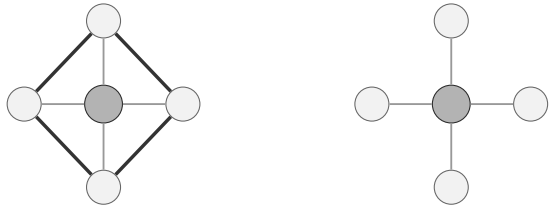

Figure 1.1: **Degree.** A node's degree is simply its number of links. Drawn here with node size growing with degree: a few hubs (such as the central one, $k = 7$) carry many links, while most nodes have only one or two. That imbalance — many small nodes, a few giant hubs — is the hallmark of a scale-free network.

is a number, the *exponent*, typically between 2 and 3 for real networks. A power law is just a rule that says "ten times bigger is some fixed number of times rarer." Unlike the bell-shaped curves of everyday statistics — human heights, say, which cluster tightly around an average — a power law has a long, heavy tail: extremely well-connected hubs are rare but nowhere near as rare as a bell curve would allow. This is why scale-free networks are hub-dominated, and why those hubs end up running much of the show (Figure 1.1).

**Clustering coefficient.** The *clustering coefficient* measures how cliquish a neighborhood is: of all the pairs of your neighbors, what fraction are themselves connected? If you have four friends and four of the possible six friendships among them actually exist, your clustering coefficient is $4/6 \approx 0.67$. Formally, if node $i$ has $k_i$ neighbors and $e_i$ of the possible links among those neighbors are present, then

$$c_i = \frac{2e_i}{k_i(k_i - 1)}, \tag{1.2}$$

since $k_i(k_i - 1)/2$ is the number of pairs that *could* be linked. A clustering coefficient near 1 means a tight clique; near 0 means your contacts are strangers to each other. Averaged over all nodes we write $\langle c \rangle$, where the angle brackets $\langle \cdot \rangle$ are standard shorthand for "average value." The striking empirical fact (Watts and Strogatz,



(a) high: $c \approx 0.67$ (b) low: $c = 0$

Figure 1.2: **Clustering coefficient.** The clustering of the central node (gray) is the fraction of its neighbor pairs that are themselves linked. (a) Four of the six neighbor pairs are linked (the bold links), so $c \approx 0.67$ — a cliquish neighborhood. (b) No neighbors are linked to each other, so $c = 0$.

1998) is that $\langle c \rangle$ in real networks is far larger than you would get by wiring the same nodes up at random — the quantitative fingerprint of those dense local neighborhoods (Figure 1.2).

**Average distance.** The *distance* between two nodes is the number of links on the shortest route between them — the fewest hops to get from one to the other. Averaged over all pairs of nodes, this distance grows very slowly (logarithmically, or even more slowly) as the network gets bigger. Slow growth of distance, together with high clustering, is precisely the small-world effect named above (Figure 1.3).

**Degree correlations.** Now to the more subtle pattern. Imagine following a link from a node out to one of its neighbors and asking: how connected is the neighbor I land on? If the network had no *degree correlations*, the answer would not depend on where I started. But real networks are correlated: in some, high-degree hubs tend to sit next to low-degree nodes; in others, hubs cluster together with other hubs. The cleanest way to see this is to record, for nodes of each degree $k$, the *average degree of their neighbors*, written $\langle k_{nn} \rangle(k)$ (the subscript "nn" stands for nearest-neighbors) (Pastor-Satorras

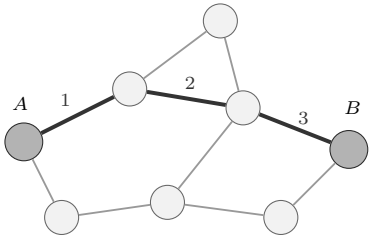



Figure 1.3: **Distance.** The distance between two nodes is the number of links on the shortest route between them. The shortest route from $A$ to $B$ here is three hops (in bold); the lower route is longer. In real networks these shortest distances stay small even as the network grows — the small-world effect.

et al., 2001):

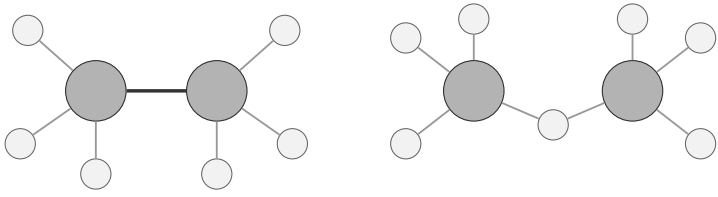
$$\langle k_{nn} \rangle(k) = \sum_{k'} k' \, p(k' \mid k). \tag{1.3}$$

Here $p(k' \mid k)$ is read "the probability that a link from a degree-$k$ node lands on a degree-$k'$ node," and the sum simply averages the landing degree $k'$ weighted by how likely each is. Do not worry if the formula looks abstract; the next box pins down the one fact we need from it, and you can take that fact on faith and skip the box if you prefer.

It is worth knowing what this quantity would be if there were *no* correlations at all, because that is the yardstick against which real networks are judged.

**The mathematics behind it: the no-correlation baseline for neighbor degree** *(this box can be skipped)*

If degrees are uncorrelated, the only reason a link is more likely to land on a particular node is that the node has more links to land on. The chance of arriving at a node of degree $k'$ is then proportional to $k'$ times how common such nodes are, $k'p(k')$. Averaging the landing degree $k'$ with this weight (and dividing by the total weight



(a) assortative (b) disassortative

Figure 1.4: **Degree correlations.** (a) In an *assortative* network, hubs tend to link to other hubs ("birds of a feather"). (b) In a *disassortative* one, hubs avoid each other and link instead to low-degree nodes ("opposites attract"). Social networks lean assortative; technological and biological ones, disassortative.

to normalize) gives

$$\langle k_{nn} \rangle_{\text{unc}} = \frac{\sum_{k'} k' \cdot k' p(k')}{\sum_{k'} k' p(k')} = \frac{\langle k^2 \rangle}{\langle k \rangle}, \tag{1.4}$$

where $\langle k \rangle$ is the average degree and $\langle k^2 \rangle$ the average of the squared degree.

The result, Eq. (1.4), is the key takeaway: in a network with no degree correlations, the average neighbor degree is the same flat number for every node, regardless of that node's own degree. So when we plot $\langle k_{nn} \rangle(k)$ against $k$ for a real network and the curve is *not* flat, the tilt tells us the kind of correlation present. If the curve slopes *down* — well-connected nodes have poorly-connected neighbors — the network is called *disassortative*; this is typical of technological and biological networks. If it slopes *up* — the well-connected keep company with the well-connected — the network is *assortative*, as social networks tend to be (Newman, 2002). Assortative and disassortative are simply the "birds of a feather" and "opposites attract" of network connectivity (Figure 1.4).

**Clustering hierarchy.** Finally, we can combine the last two ideas by asking how cliquishness depends on degree. Sorting nodes by

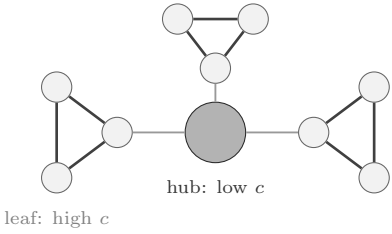



Figure 1.5: **Clustering hierarchy.** Low-degree nodes sit inside tight clusters where everyone is connected (high clustering, the dark triangles), while a hub bridges many such clusters. The hub's own neighbors — one drawn from each cluster — do not know each other, so the hub itself has low clustering. Cliquishness therefore falls as degree rises.

their degree $k$ and averaging the clustering coefficient within each group gives $\langle c \rangle(k)$. In a wide range of real networks this quantity falls off as a power law,

$$\langle c \rangle(k) \sim k^{-1}, \tag{1.5}$$

meaning the more connections a node has, the *less* cliquish its neighborhood. This is the *clustering hierarchy*, and it has an intuitive reading (Ravasz et al., 2002; Ravasz and Barabási, 2003): ordinary low-degree nodes sit inside tight little communities where everyone knows everyone, while the big hubs act as bridges between many such communities, so their own neighbors — drawn from all over — mostly do not know each other. A small-town local has a dense circle of mutual friends; a globe-trotting connector knows thousands of people who have never met (Figure 1.5).

That reading is appealing, and it is the one the literature has largely adopted. It is also, in good part, wrong — and the reason is worth a few pages, because it is the first example in this book of a global pattern dissolving under inspection (Soffer and Vazquez, 2005).

Look again at the denominator of Eq. (1.2). We divided the triangles $e_i$ around a node by $k_i(k_i - 1)/2$, the number of *pairs* of its neighbors, on the grounds that this is how many links those

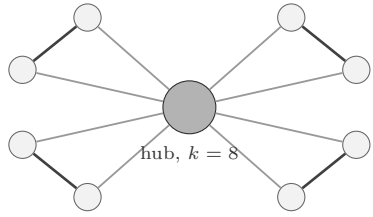



Figure 1.6: **Why the standard clustering coefficient misleads.** The hub's neighbors all have degree two, and each spends its spare link on another neighbor of the hub. They are therefore *as interconnected as their degrees allow* — no rewiring could add a single link among them. Yet the standard coefficient, Eq. (1.2), divides by all $\binom{8}{2} = 28$ neighbor pairs and reports $c = 4/28 \approx 0.14$, falling to zero as the hub grows. The pairs it counts are pairs the degrees forbid.

neighbors could possibly have among themselves. But could they? A neighbor $j$ has only $k_j$ links in total, and one of them is already spent reaching $i$. So $j$ can reach at most $k_j - 1$ of $i$'s other neighbors — and if $k_j$ is small, that is nearly none of them. The denominator counts pairs that the network's own degrees forbid.

The consequence is not subtle. Consider a hub of degree $k$ joined to $k$ nodes of degree two, each of which spends its second link on one other neighbor of the hub (Figure 1.6). Every neighbor of the hub is now connected to another neighbor: they are as interconnected as their degrees permit, and no rewiring could make them more so. There are $e_i = k/2$ links among them, so the hub's clustering coefficient is

$$c = \frac{2\,(k/2)}{k(k-1)} = \frac{1}{k-1}, \tag{1.6}$$

which tends to zero as the hub grows. By the standard measure this maximally-clustered neighborhood is reported as having no clustering at all. A large-degree node attached to small-degree nodes will always be assigned a small $c$, however its neighbors are wired — and in a disassortative network, that describes every hub. The measure and the correlations are entangled.

The repair is to divide not by the pairs one can *draw* but by the links the neighbors can *afford*.

**The mathematics behind it: clustering without the degree-correlation bias** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $\omega_i$ be the largest number of links that could exist among the $k_i$ neighbors of node $i$, given those neighbors' degrees. A first bound follows from the argument above: neighbor $j$ can spend at most $\min(k_i, k_j) - 1$ links on $i$'s other neighbors — at most $k_j - 1$ because that is all it has left, and at most $k_i - 1$ because that is all the targets there are. Summing over neighbors and halving, since each link is counted from both ends,

$$\omega_i \;\le\; \Omega_i = \left\lfloor \frac{1}{2} \sum_{j \in \mathcal{N}(i)} \big[\min(k_i, k_j) - 1\big] \right\rfloor \;\le\; \binom{k_i}{2}, \qquad (1.7)$$

where $\mathcal{N}(i)$ denotes the neighbors of $i$. The last inequality is the whole point: $\Omega_i$ can be far below $\binom{k_i}{2}$, and it is the standard coefficient's insistence on the larger number that manufactures the hierarchy. $\Omega_i$ is still only a bound, because it does not check that the links can actually be arranged; $\omega_i$ itself is obtained by trying. Take the list $\min(k_i, k_j) - 1$ over all neighbors, sorted in decreasing order; spend the largest entry's budget on as many of the next-largest entries as it can reach, decrementing each; discard it and any entry now at zero; re-sort and repeat until the list is empty. The number of links drawn is $\omega_i$. The corrected clustering coefficient is then simply

$$\tilde{c}_i = \frac{e_i}{\omega_i}, \qquad (1.8)$$

the fraction of the links the neighbors could afford that they actually made. Three properties follow. It is undefined when $\omega_i = 0$ — a hub of leaves has no clustering to speak of, rather than zero clustering, which is the honest verdict. It never falls below the old one, $\tilde{c}_i \ge c_i$. And when every neighbor is at least as well connected as the node itself, the two coincide, $\tilde{c}_i = c_i$, so nothing is changed where nothing was wrong.

Measure $\tilde{c}$ on real networks and the hierarchy largely evaporates (Figure 1.7; the two panels share a vertical scale so that the change

can be read off directly). The four networks used here are introduced properly in Section 1.4, and are the ones this book keeps returning to: the Internet at the level of its service providers, the Gnutella file-sharing network, the protein interactions of yeast, and a physics co-authorship network. For the Internet, $\langle c\rangle(k)$ falls by more than a decade across four decades of degree; $\langle \tilde{c}\rangle(k)$ is *flat* — it varies by a factor of 1.5 over the whole range, and its fitted slope is $+0.02$ where the uncorrected slope was $-0.76$. The same happens, less completely, for the others: every slope moves sharply toward zero. What is left, when the bias is stripped out, is a clustering coefficient that is either roughly constant or decays only logarithmically with degree (Soffer and Vazquez, 2005) — and a logarithm, over the two or three decades of degree a real network offers, is very nearly a constant.

So Eq. (1.5) should be read with care. It is a robust *measurement*: plot $\langle c\rangle(k)$ for almost any real network and you will see it. It is much weaker as *evidence* for a designed hierarchy of modules, because a large part of what it records is the degree correlations of the network reflected back through a biased denominator. The clustering hierarchy and the degree correlations are not two independent regularities; they are, in good part, two views of one.

None of which makes the clustering itself an illusion. Two facts survive the correction and matter for everything that follows. First, the corrected clustering is *high* — $\tilde{c} \approx 0.39$ for the Internet, 0.80 for co-authorship — so real networks really are cliquish; it is the *trend* with degree, not the cliquishness, that the bias manufactured. Second, and more pointedly, that cliquishness is more than the degrees and their correlations can account for: shuffle the links while holding every degree fixed and the clustering drops, as Table 1.1 will show. The Internet is more clustered than its own degree sequence and degree correlations can explain. Something built those triangles, and the degrees do not know what.

The lesson is to read these measures together rather than in isolation — a theme that recurs throughout the book, where a single local rule will be seen to set the clustering hierarchy and the degree correlations *at once*, as facets of one mechanism. When later chapters derive $\langle c\rangle(k) \sim k^{-1}$ from a local rule, understand the claim precisely: the rule reproduces what the standard measure reports of

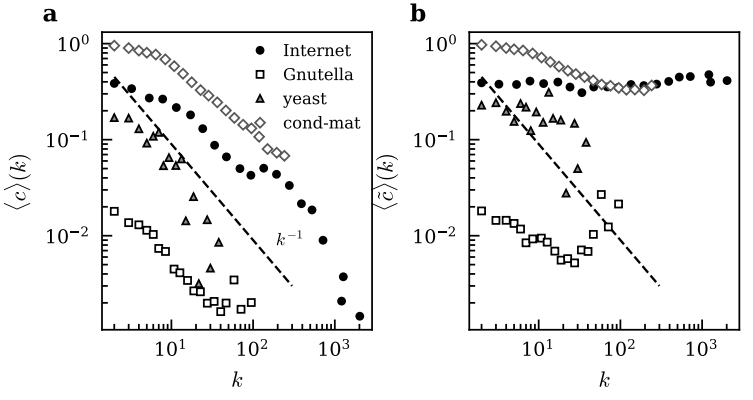



Figure 1.7: **The clustering hierarchy, and what is left of it.** Four real networks — the Internet at the autonomous-system level, the Gnutella file-sharing overlay, the yeast protein interaction network, and `cond-mat` co-authorship — drawn from the Netzschleuder repository (Section 1.4). (a) The standard clustering coefficient falls with degree in every network, roughly as $k^{-1}$ (dashed guide): the hierarchy of Eq. (1.5). (b) The same networks measured with $\tilde{c}$, Eq. (1.8), which divides by the links the neighbors can afford rather than by the pairs one can draw. The vertical scale is the same as in (a). The Internet's curve is now flat — it varies by a factor of 1.5 across four decades of degree — and every other decay is much weakened. Most of the hierarchy was in the measure, not in the network.

real networks, biases and all, which is the right target — but the deeper quantity it is matching is the pair of degree correlations and genuine cliquishness that lie underneath.

## 1.3 From global to local rules

With the measures in hand we can state the puzzle this book exists to solve. The modern story of network growth opens with the model of Barabási and Albert (1999), usually abbreviated BA after its

authors. It rests on two ideas. The first is *growth*: networks are not built all at once but accumulate nodes over time, the way the Web gains pages or the literature gains papers. The second is *preferential attachment*: a new node prefers to link to nodes that are already well connected, with a probability proportional to their degree — the "rich get richer" of networks. From these two ingredients a power-law degree distribution follows reliably, and preferential attachment has rightly become the textbook explanation for why so many networks are scale-free.

Two difficulties, though, drive everything that follows. The first is about *mechanism*. Preferential attachment, read literally, is a *global* rule: to attach in proportion to degree, a newcomer would have to know the degree of every node in the entire network and weigh them all against each other. That is implausible for the systems we care about. A scientist writing a new paper has read a few dozen others, not the millions in existence; a new gene is a copy of one existing gene, ignorant of the rest of the genome; a newcomer to a town meets a handful of people, not the whole population. Real nodes act *locally*. So if preferential attachment is not literally true, why do so many networks behave as if it were?

The second difficulty is that the BA model, for all its success with the degree distribution, does not by itself reproduce the other patterns we just met. Its clustering fades away as the network grows, it shows none of the clustering hierarchy of Eq. (1.5), and its degree correlations are weak (Albert and Barabási, 2002; Vazquez, 2003). Something is missing.

The resolution pursued throughout this book is to throw out the global rule and replace it with local ones, then watch what *emerges*. By a *local rule* we mean a way of growing the network in which a newcomer reaches some node — chosen at random, or arrived at by surfing along links, or copied from an existing node — and then connects to that node and perhaps to a few of its immediate neighbors, using nothing but that local information. The recurring and rather beautiful discovery, established for several such rules (Vazquez, 2003), is that

> *an effective "rich get richer" behavior arises all on its own from growth by local rules.*

The reason, which we will meet many times, is almost a slogan: a well-connected node is, by definition, a node that many local explorations will bump into, because it has many links through which it can be reached. The preference for hubs need not be legislated; it is a free by-product of poking around the network locally. And because the very same local moves also create triangles (your friend introduces you to their friend) and link nodes of unlike degree, the same rules that produce the power law deliver, in one package, the clustering hierarchy of Eq. (1.5) and the degree correlations of Eq. (1.3). Three patterns that look independent turn out to share a single root.

## 1.4 What the data demand

Any explanation has to answer to measurements, so it is worth recording up front what those measurements actually look like. Rather than take this on trust, let us measure four real networks and see. All four come from the Netzschleuder repository (Peixoto, 2020), a public catalogue of several hundred network datasets, read here through the `graph-tool` library (Peixoto, 2014a); the code that fetches and measures them accompanies this book. They are: the *Internet* at the level of the service providers, the "autonomous systems," that own its routers; the *Gnutella* peer-to-peer file-sharing overlay; the protein interaction network of *yeast*; and the *co-authorship* network of the `cond-mat` preprint archive, in which two physicists are linked if they have written a paper together. Three technological or biological, one social — which turns out to be exactly the division that matters.

Start with the small world, since it needs only two numbers per network (Table 1.1). Every one of these networks is small: the average distance between two nodes is between four and seven hops, in networks of up to sixty thousand nodes. And every one is far more cliquish than chance. Wiring the same number of nodes at random with the same number of links — the comparison Watts and Strogatz made — would give the clustering in the column headed $\langle c \rangle_{\mathrm{ER}}$, which is between forty and two and a half thousand times smaller than what is observed. The comparison is almost unfair, though, because it also throws away the hubs, and hubs alone create some clustering. The last of the clustering columns is therefore the honest one: it shuffles the links at random while holding every

Table 1.1: **Four real networks.** Measured on the largest connected component, undirected. $\langle \tilde{c} \rangle$ is the clustering corrected for what the neighbors' degrees allow, Eq. (1.8); it never falls below $\langle c \rangle$. $\langle c \rangle_{\mathrm{ER}}$ is the clustering of a random network with the same $n$ and $\langle k \rangle$; $\langle c \rangle_{\mathrm{rew}}$ that of the same network with its links shuffled at random but every degree held fixed. $\langle d \rangle$ is the average distance and $r$ the assortativity: negative for the first three, positive for the last.

| Network | $n$ | $\langle k \rangle$ | $\langle c \rangle$ | $\langle \tilde{c} \rangle$ | $\langle c \rangle_{\mathrm{ER}}$ | $\langle c \rangle_{\mathrm{rew}}$ | $\langle d \rangle$ | $r$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Internet (AS) | 22 963 | 4.2 | 0.230 | 0.386 | 0.0002 | 0.123 | 3.9 | −0.052 |
| Gnutella | 62 561 | 4.7 | 0.005 | 0.012 | 0.0001 | 0.0002 | 5.9 | −0.036 |
| Yeast proteins | 1 458 | 2.7 | 0.071 | 0.215 | 0.0018 | 0.0050 | 6.9 | −0.034 |
| cond-mat | 36 458 | 9.4 | 0.657 | 0.800 | 0.0003 | 0.0018 | 5.5 | +0.055 |

node's degree fixed, and measures what survives. Even against that stricter null the real networks are the more cliquish, by factors of two to three hundred. The cliquishness is real, and it is not merely a shadow of the degree distribution.

Now the measures that organize the rest of the book (Figure 1.8). The degree distributions are broad and hub-dominated: the Internet runs from nodes with a single link to one with more than two thousand, four decades of degree in a network four decades in size, and the others do the same over a shorter range. Gnutella is the partial exception worth naming — its protocol caps how many peers a client will hold, so its tail is cut short and it is the least scale-free of the four. Real data are like that; the power law of Eq. (1.1) is an idealization that some systems wear better than others.

The clustering we have already been through: the hierarchy of Eq. (1.5) is there in all four (Figure 1.7a), with measured slopes from $-0.6$ to $-1.3$, and most of it dissolves once the degree-correlation bias is removed (Figure 1.7b).

And then the two families part company, on the last measure and only on the last measure. For the Internet, for Gnutella and for the yeast proteins, the average neighbor degree *falls* with degree: these networks are *disassortative*, their hubs presiding over peripheries of poorly-connected nodes rather than huddling together. This is the signature of technological and biological networks (Pastor-Satorras et al., 2001; Maslov and Sneppen, 2002; Jeong et al., 2001). For the co-authorship network it *rises*: prolific, well-connected authors tend

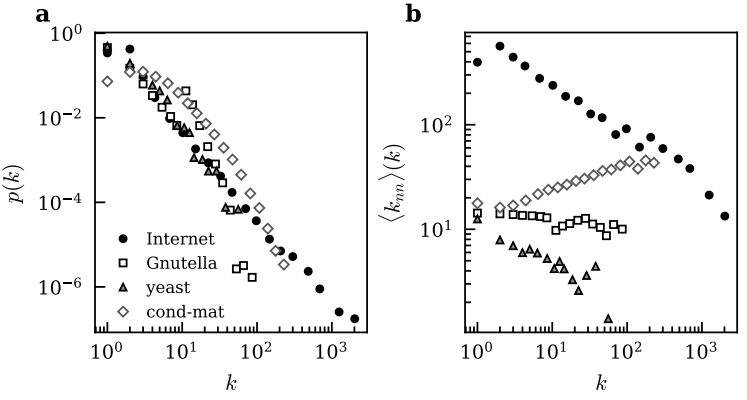



Figure 1.8: **What the data demand.** The same four networks, from the Netzschleuder repository through `graph-tool`. (a) The degree distributions are broad and hub-dominated; the Internet spans four decades of degree. Gnutella's protocol caps its peers, so its tail is the shortest. (b) The average neighbor degree, where the two families part: falling for the Internet, Gnutella and the yeast proteins — *disassortative* — but rising for `cond-mat` co-authorship, which is *assortative*. The clustering of these same networks is in Figure 1.7.

to write with one another, and the network is *assortative* (Newman, 2002). The single number $r$ in Table 1.1 says the same thing more briefly — negative for the first three, positive for the fourth — and the sign of that number is the cleanest division in the data.

The contrast between the two families is instructive, because it shows that whatever mechanism we propose must be able to produce *either* sign of correlation, depending on the microscopic move — and, as the chapters will show, local rules can do exactly that. It also tells us the two families are not two kinds of network but one kind seen through one dial: everything else in Figure 1.8 they share.

These regularities are robust, they hold across many orders of magnitude in network size, and for years their shared origin was a mystery. Supplying that origin, one mechanism and one class of

networks at a time, is the work of this book.

## 1.5 Plan of the book

The chapters proceed from mechanism to application, each built around one concrete local rule and a family of real networks it illuminates. The reader need not take any chapter on faith: in each, a simple local rule is stated, its consequences are worked out (with the heavier algebra confined to boxes that can be skipped), and the predictions are held up against real data.

- **Search and connect.** A newcomer learns of existing nodes by exploring the network — following references, surfing hyperlinks, performing a random walk — and connects to what it finds. This is the natural model for searchable, directed networks such as the citation network and the World Wide Web, and it is where we show in detail how the simple act of surfing manufactures an effective "rich get richer."

- **Friends of friends.** A newcomer connects to a node and then to some of that node's neighbors — you meet a person, then their friends. This rule for social network growth creates triangles directly, and it generates the assortative correlations and the cliquishness hierarchy of social networks.

- **Gene duplication.** Biological networks grow by copying: a node is duplicated together with its connections, after which links are gained and lost. Duplication is an intrinsically local move, and it explains the disassortative, hierarchical structure of protein interaction networks.

- **Activity specialization.** The schedule of a large project is a network of activities grown by a local refinement rule: each activity is either duplicated into parallel copies or split into specialized sequential parts. The same copying mechanism gives power-law degrees, while making the celebrated "critical path" vanish as projects grow and relocating delay risk in the network as a whole.

- **Emergence of communities.** Local rules do not only set degrees and correlations; they also organize nodes into communities — tight groups with many links inside and few outside. We examine how this mesoscale structure arises from the same local dynamics, even when every node is otherwise identical.

- **Boosting shortest path multiplicity.** Finally we turn to the redundancy of routes through a network — how many equally short paths join two nodes — and show that local growth multiplies them, tying this redundancy to the very community structure of the previous chapter.

A single thread runs through all of them. In each case the apparently global features of a network — its scale-free degrees, its small-world distances, its clustering hierarchy, its degree correlations, its communities, its redundant paths — turn out to be the collective, emergent consequence of simple rules that no node applies with more than local knowledge. That is the sense in which the title of this book should be read: not networks built by a designer, but networks that grow themselves, one local decision at a time.

# Chapter 2

# Search and connect

## 2.1 Finding what to link to

The introduction left us with a puzzle. The "rich get richer" rule explains why so many networks are scale-free, but as a literal recipe it asks the impossible: a newcomer would have to know the degree of every node in the network in order to favor the well-connected ones. In this chapter we solve the puzzle for an important family of networks — the *searchable* ones — by replacing that impossible global rule with the most natural local act a newcomer can perform. It *searches* the network, moving from node to node along the links, and connects to what it happens to find.

The systems to keep in mind are collections of documents that point at one another. In the *citation network*, each node is a published article and each link is a reference from one article to another. In the World Wide Web, each node is a page and each link is a hyperlink. These are *directed* networks: a reference, like a hyperlink, points one way. An article cites an older one, not the reverse; a page links to another, which need not link back. Because direction matters, each node now has two kinds of degree. Its *in-degree*, written $k^{in}$, counts the links pointing *at* it — how many times a paper has been cited, how many pages link to a given page. Its *out-degree*, written $k^{out}$, counts the links pointing *out* of it — how many references a paper makes, how many hyperlinks a page contains. It is the

in-degree that interests us, because in real document networks it is the in-degree — the count of incoming attention — that is broadly distributed, with a few hugely-cited classics and a long tail of papers cited once or never.

How does a new document come to point at the old ones? Not by consulting a global popularity ranking. An author writing a new paper finds references by reading a few papers and following *their* reference lists, and then the references of those, and so on (Price, 1965). A web author discovers pages by surfing from link to link and by typing queries into a search engine (Brin and Page, 1998). In every case the information used is strictly local — a document one has reached, and the documents it points to. The claim of this chapter is that this local searching, repeated by every newcomer, adds up to exactly the "rich get richer" behavior that the introduction had to assume by fiat, and that it brings the power-law degrees, the clustering hierarchy, and the degree correlations along with it (Vazquez, 2001, 2003).

## 2.2 Surfing as a random walk

To turn "surfing" into something we can analyze, we model the surfer as a *random walker* on the network. A random walk is just what it sounds like: start somewhere, and step to a randomly chosen neighbor, then to a neighbor of *that* node, and so on. Our surfer does this with a twist. From whatever page it is on, with probability $q_e$ it follows one of that page's outgoing hyperlinks, picked at random; with the remaining probability $1 - q_e$ it gets bored, stops following links, and jumps to a completely random page elsewhere. The single dial $q_e$, a number between 0 and 1, sets how patiently the surfer explores along links before restarting from scratch.

Now ask: in the long run, what fraction of its time does the walker spend at each page? Call that fraction the page's *visiting probability*, $v_i$ for node $i$. A page is visited often if many links point to it and those linking pages are themselves visited often — a self-referential condition that turns out to have a clean form. The remarkable thing, worth flagging before any algebra, is that this visiting probability is *exactly the quantity that Google was built on*: it is the *PageRank* of the page, the measure of importance that ranks search results (Brin

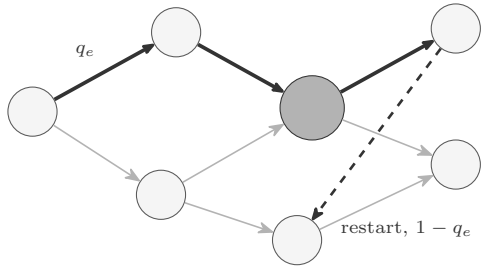



Figure 2.1: **Surfing as a random walk.** From the page it is on, the searcher follows one of the outgoing links with probability $q_e$ (solid arrows) or, with probability $1 - q_e$, jumps to a page chosen at random (dashed arrow). A page reached along many routes — like the highlighted hub — is visited most often; this visiting frequency is the page's PageRank, and it grows in proportion to the number of links that point at the page.

and Page, 1998). So the local rule we are about to write is not a toy — it is the very process real search engines compute and then display to the authors who go on to create new links.

The picture to keep in mind is Figure 2.1. We would like to know how a page's visiting probability depends on its in-degree. Getting there exactly is hard, so we make the standard physicist's move of replacing fluctuating quantities by their averages — a so-called *mean-field approximation*, "mean" as in average. The next box carries this out; the one sentence to carry away is stated right after it, so the box can be skipped.

**The mathematics behind it: from surfing to the visiting probability** *(this box can be skipped)*

The visiting probability of node $i$ obeys a balance condition: the walker arrives at $i$ either by a random jump (probability $1 - q_e$, landing on any of the $n$ nodes equally) or by following a link into $i$ from some node $j$ that points to it,

$$v_i = \frac{1 - q_e}{n} + q_e \sum_j a_{ij} \frac{v_j}{k_j^{out}}, \tag{2.1}$$

where $a_{ij} = 1$ when $j$ points to $i$, and the factor $1/k_j^{out}$ accounts for $j$ spreading its attention over its $k_j^{out}$ outgoing links. This is the PageRank equation. To simplify it, replace the sum over the specific nodes pointing to $i$ by an average. A node is reached along an incoming link from a node of out-degree $k^{out}$ with probability $k^{out}p_{k^{out}}/\langle k^{out}\rangle$, and that link is then followed with probability $1/k^{out}$; the two factors of $k^{out}$ cancel, so each incoming link contributes the same average amount $\Theta = \langle v\rangle/\langle k^{out}\rangle$. Since node $i$ has $k_i^{in}$ incoming links,

$$v_i = \frac{1 - q_e}{n} + q_e\,\Theta\,k_i^{in}. \tag{2.2}$$

The payoff is Eq. (2.2), and it is simple to state in words: a page's visiting probability grows in a straight line with its in-degree. Double the number of links pointing at a page and you roughly double how often the surfer lands on it. That straight-line relationship is the seed from which everything in this chapter grows.

## 2.3 An effective "rich get richer"

Being visited is not the same as being linked to — you read many pages you do not cite. So suppose that each time the surfer visits a page it creates a new incoming link to it only with some probability $q_v$. We can then ask how fast a page accumulates new links as a function of how many it already has. This rate is the network-growth analog of preferential attachment, and computing it is the crux of the chapter. The derivation is short; its conclusion is in the sentence after the box.

**The mathematics behind it: the rate at which a page gains links** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $\nu_s$ surfers be active and $\nu_a$ new pages be added per unit time. The node count $n$ and link count $e$ grow as

$$\frac{\partial n}{\partial t} = \nu_a, \qquad \frac{\partial e}{\partial t} = \nu_s\,q_v\,\langle v\rangle\,n, \tag{2.3}$$

because each of the $\langle v\rangle n$ visits in a walk makes a link with probability $q_v$. Integrating fixes the average degree and hence $\Theta = \nu_a/(q_v\nu_s n)$.

The rate at which a page of in-degree $k^{in}$ gains its next link is $A(k^{in}) = q_v\, v(k^{in})$; substituting Eq. (2.2) and the value of $\Theta$,

$$A(k^{in}) = \frac{1}{n}\left[\, q_v(1-q_e) + q_e\,\frac{\nu_a}{\nu_s}\,k^{in}\right]. \tag{2.4}$$

Equation (2.4) is the central result, and it deserves to be read slowly. The rate at which a page attracts new links has two parts: a constant piece, the same for every page, which gives even a brand-new page a chance of being noticed; and a piece *proportional to its current in-degree*. That second piece is preferential attachment — the rich getting richer — but notice where it came from. The surfer never consulted a global ranking of pages; it only followed links, one at a time. The bias toward well-connected pages appeared on its own, for the simple reason that a page with many incoming links is a page the wandering surfer reaches by many routes. We have *derived* the rule the introduction had to assume. The same logic underlies the "redirection" trick of Krapivsky and Redner (2001), in which a newcomer points either to a random node or to whatever that node points to — a one-step walk that yields the same effective preference.

## 2.4 The degree distribution

A linear attachment rate is exactly the ingredient needed to produce a power law. Working out the resulting distribution of in-degrees requires solving a balance equation for how many pages sit at each in-degree, which we do in the box. Readers willing to take the outcome on trust can jump to the discussion after it.

**The mathematics behind it: the in-degree distribution and its exponent** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $n_{k^{in}}$ be the number of nodes with in-degree $k^{in}$. It changes as nodes climb from one in-degree to the next by gaining links, with

new nodes injected at in-degree zero:

$$\frac{\partial n_{k^{in}}}{\partial t} = \nu_s\, A_{k^{in}-1}\, n_{k^{in}-1} - \nu_s\, A_{k^{in}}\, n_{k^{in}} + \nu_a\, \delta_{k^{in},0}\,, \tag{2.5}$$

the symbol $\delta_{k^{in},0}$ being 1 only at $k^{in} = 0$. For a network growing at a constant rate the ratio $\nu_s/\nu_a = \alpha$ is fixed and the shape of the distribution settles down, $n_{k^{in}}(t) = N p_{k^{in}}$. Solving for that stationary shape gives (with $\Gamma$ the gamma function, a smooth generalization of the factorial)

$$p_{k^{in}} = \frac{1}{1+a}\,\frac{\Gamma[a(\gamma-1)+k^{in}]}{\Gamma[a(\gamma-1)]}\,\frac{\Gamma[(1+a)(\gamma-1)+1]}{\Gamma[(1+a)(\gamma-1)+k^{in}+1]}, \tag{2.6}$$

$$\gamma = 1 + \frac{1}{q_e}, \qquad a = \alpha\, q_v\,(1-q_e), \tag{2.7}$$

which for large in-degree is the power law

$$p_{k^{in}} \sim (k^{in})^{-\gamma}. \tag{2.8}$$

Two features of the result, Eq. (2.7), are worth dwelling on. First, the exponent $\gamma$ is at least 2 — exactly the range seen in real citation and web networks. Second, and more surprising, $\gamma$ depends *only* on $q_e$, the surfer's patience for following links. It does not depend on $q_v$, how often readers actually cite what they read, nor on the growth rate of the network. Whether authors are generous or stingy with citations changes how many links there are, but not the *shape* of the distribution; only the manner of *exploring* the network does that. As the surfer explores ever more deeply ($q_e \to 1$) the exponent drops to its minimum of 2, the most hub-dominated case; as the surfer restarts constantly ($q_e \to 0$) the exponent grows without bound and the heavy tail of hubs disappears.

## 2.5 Cliquishness and correlations

The same walk that sets the degrees also lays down triangles, so it predicts the clustering hierarchy of the introduction with no extra assumptions. The reason is simple to picture: whenever the surfer steps from a page to one of that page's neighbors and links to both, it has closed a triangle. A short calculation turns this picture into a

formula.

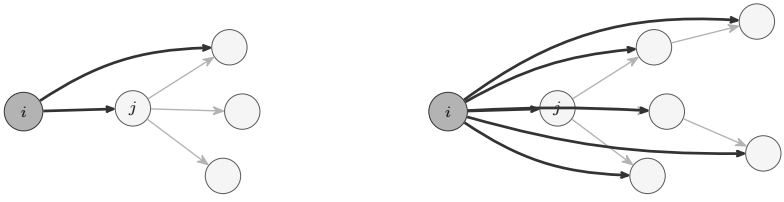
**The mathematics behind it: how clustering falls with degree** *(this box can be skipped)*

Counting the links $e_i$ among the neighbors of node $i$ created by the walk gives $\partial e_i/\partial t \approx (1+q_e)\,\partial k_i^{in}/\partial t$. Integrating this differential equation, assuming $e=0$ for $k=1$, we obtain $e=(1+q_e)(k-1)$. Inserting this into the definition of the clustering coefficient, $\langle c\rangle_k = 2e(k)/[k(k-1)]$, yields

$$\langle c\rangle_k \approx \frac{2(1+q_e)}{k}. \tag{2.9}$$

The message of Eq. (2.9) is that cliquishness is inversely proportional to degree: a node with twice the degree has roughly half the clustering. This is precisely the clustering hierarchy of Eq. (1.5), seen in the Internet, the Web, and the protein network — and here it falls out for free from growth by searching. The intuition is that a node gains a triangle every time the surfer steps from it to a neighbor, so its triangles grow in step with its degree, while the number of *possible* triangles grows much faster, like the square of the degree; their ratio, the clustering, therefore falls off as one over the degree.

The degree correlations are governed by the same single dial $q_e$. Numerical simulation of the model shows that when $q_e$ is small the network looks essentially uncorrelated — the average neighbor degree is flat, as in the baseline of Eq. (1.4) — while as $q_e$ grows the average neighbor degree develops the downward slope of a *disassortative* network, hubs sitting amid poorly-connected pages. This matches the real Web, whose measured exponent $\gamma \approx 2.1$ corresponds through Eq. (2.7) to a patient surfer with $q_e > 0.5$, squarely in the disassortative regime. One knob, $q_e$, thus fixes the degree-distribution exponent, the cliquishness hierarchy, and the sign of the correlations all at once — tying together what the introduction presented as three separate facts.




(a) random-walk model (b) recursive-search model

Figure 2.2: **Two ways to search, when a new node $i$ joins.** (a) In the random-walk model, $i$ links to a randomly chosen node $j$ and then takes a single step to one of $j$'s neighbors, linking to it as well. (b) In the recursive-search model, $i$ follows *all* of $j$'s links, and then their links in turn, linking to every node its widening search reaches. New links are drawn in bold, pre-existing links thin and gray.

## 2.6 Two ways to search

It helps to see two concrete versions of the searching rule, because they behave differently and bracket the range of possibilities. Figure 2.2 contrasts them.

**The random-walk model.** The simplest version uses a single surfer that always links what it visits and starts a fresh search from a new node each time it stops. Stated as a recipe, beginning from a couple of connected nodes, repeat:

- *Add.* Create a new node with one link pointing to a randomly chosen existing node.
- *Walk.* Having just linked to a node, then with probability $q_e$ also link to one of that node's neighbors; otherwise go back to the add step.

Here the surfer takes a single step along the network before possibly stopping. This model produces the power-law tail in Eq. (2.8) and the clustering law of Eq. (2.9) (the latter in very good agreement with simulation), while the predicted exponent is a slight overestimate — the price of the mean-field approximation in the box above.

**The recursive-search model.** A more thorough searcher does not stop after one step but follows *all* the links of each node it reaches, then all the links of those, exploring an ever-widening territory (Vazquez, 2001). Specifically,

- *Add.* Create a new node with one link pointing to a randomly chosen existing node.
- *Walk.* If a link is created to a node in the network then with probability $q_e$ a link is also created to each of its nearest neighbors. When no link is created go to the add rule.

This version has a richer behavior — in fact a genuine *phase transition*, a sudden change of character as the dial $q_e$ is turned, of the kind familiar from water freezing into ice. The next box records the two cases that can be solved exactly and the location of the transition; the meaning is summarized afterward.

**The mathematics behind it: the recursive searcher and its phase transition** *(this box can be skipped)*

For $q_e = 0$ only the add step operates, every node is equally likely to be linked and $A(k^{in}) = 1/n$ independently of $k^{in}$. In this case the steady state solution $n_{k^{in}}(n) = n\, p_{k^{in}}$ of Eq. (2.5) is

$$p_{k^{in}} = 2^{-(k^{in}+1)}. \tag{2.10}$$

For $q_e = 1$ the recursion reaches every neighbor, the attachment rate becomes exactly linear, $A(k^{in}) = (1 + k^{in})/n$ — genuine preferential attachment, generated locally — and the steady state solution $n_{k^{in}}(n) = n\, p_{k^{in}}$ of Eq. (2.5) is

$$p_{k^{in}} = \frac{1}{(k^{in}+1)(k^{in}+2)} \sim (k^{in})^{-2}. \tag{2.11}$$

In between, we don't have an analytical solution. Yet, the average out-degree in the steady state is

$$\langle k^{out} \rangle = \frac{1 - \sqrt{1 - 4q_e}}{2q_e}, \tag{2.12}$$

which is finite only for $q_e \leq q_c = 1/4$; above this threshold it diverges.

The exact results bracket the behavior: a fast-decaying exponential when the searcher barely explores, and a clean power law with exponent 2 when it explores exhaustively. The new feature is the threshold $q_c$ in Eq. (2.12). Below it the network has a well-defined average connectivity; above it the average degree runs away and the in-degree distribution locks onto the power-law exponent $\gamma = 2$, no matter the precise value of $q_e$. Simulations confirm this picture, with the threshold near $q_c \approx 0.5$.

The striking part is that scale-invariance — the power law — is not produced by carefully tuning $q_e$ to one magic value, but holds across a whole range of $q_e$ above the threshold. Physicists have a name for systems that sit automatically at such a critical, scale-free point without fine-tuning: *self-organized criticality*, the textbook example being a sandpile that, however you pour sand on it, keeps adjusting itself to the brink of avalanching. Here the slow addition of new pages and the fast exploration of the existing network play the roles of slow pouring and fast avalanching. Read this way, the ubiquity of scale-free citation and web networks is not a delicate coincidence but the generic, self-organized outcome of building a network by searching it.

## 2.7 Summary

Searchable networks grow by a rule with nothing global in it: a newcomer explores the existing network along its links and connects to what it finds. Modeling the explorer as a random walker — the very PageRank process that ranks web pages — we found that a page's visiting probability rises in a straight line with its in-degree, which converts the local act of walking into an effective "rich get richer." From that single mechanism follow a power-law in-degree distribution whose exponent $\gamma = 1 + 1/q_e$ is set purely by how the network is explored, a clustering hierarchy in which cliquishness falls as one over the degree, and tunable, generically disassortative degree correlations. Letting the searcher explore exhaustively turns the smooth picture into a self-organized critical transition with a robust exponent of 2. The puzzle of where preferential attachment "comes from," for this family of networks, is thereby dissolved: it comes from walking.

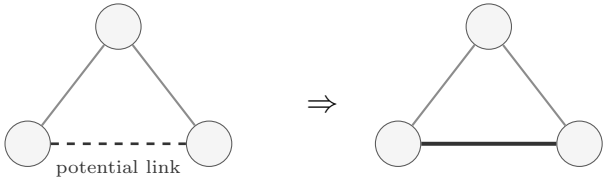
# Chapter 3

# Friends of friends

## 3.1 Triadic closure as a growth rule

The previous chapter built networks by exploration. This one builds them by introduction. Think about how you came to know the people you know. Only rarely did you befriend a complete stranger; far more often a friend introduced you to one of *their* friends. This everyday mechanism — a new tie forming between two people who already share a common acquaintance — has a name in sociology: *triadic closure*, because it "closes" a triangle by adding the third side to a path of two. Two people who both know a third are, in a sense, a triangle waiting to happen, and triadic closure is the event that completes it. Sociologists have long seen this as the engine of social structure (Granovetter, 1973). If most new links close triangles, then triangles pile up, and the network acquires the high cliquishness — the large clustering coefficient of the introduction — that sets social networks apart from random ones.

Figure 3.1 shows this elementary step. Notice that it is a thoroughly *local* rule. To introduce two friends you need to know only one node and its neighbors: who you know, and who they know. That is exactly the kind of local information this book is built on, and the question, as always, is what such a rule produces in the aggregate. The answer, worked out below following Vazquez (2003) and reviewed in Vazquez (2002), is that connecting friends-of-friends




(a) friend of a friend (b) triangle closed

Figure 3.1: **Triadic closure.** Two people (bottom) who already share a common friend (top) form a *potential link* — a friend-of-a-friend pair, drawn dashed. Closing the triangle turns that potential link into a real one, the elementary step by which the friends-of-friends rule builds social structure.

generates the whole suite of social-network signatures at once: an effective "rich get richer" and hence a power-law degree distribution, the clustering hierarchy in which cliquishness falls with degree, and — in pointed contrast to the technological and biological networks of the other chapters — *assortative* degree correlations, the tendency of well-connected people to know one another.

Models in this spirit have a history. Davidsen et al. (2002) introduced an acquaintance-network model (the DEB model, after its authors) in which people are repeatedly introduced to friends of friends, producing a small world with high clustering; Holme and Kim (2002) bolted an explicit triangle-forming step onto preferential attachment to give it tunable clustering. What follows organizes these ideas around a single bookkeeping device that makes the mechanism transparent — the *potential link*.

## 3.2 Potential links

The key idea is that, under triadic closure, a pair of nodes is not just "connected" or "not connected." A pair that already shares a common neighbor is a triangle waiting to close — a candidate in a way that an arbitrary pair of strangers is not. So we sort every pair of nodes into one of three states:

- *disconnected* ($s$): no link and no common neighbor — two strangers with no mutual acquaintance;
- connected by a *potential link* ($p$): no link yet, but at least one common neighbor — two friends-of-a-friend, poised to be introduced;
- connected by a *link* ($e$): already friends.

The *potential link* is the formal stand-in for "friend of a friend." We write $k_i$ for the ordinary degree of node $i$ (its number of friends) and $k_i^*$ for its *potential degree*, the number of friends-of-friends it has — the number of potential links waiting at it.

Triadic closure is then a story about a pair changing state: a potential link ($p$) becomes a real link ($e$) when the triangle closes. To track this we need to know the rates at which pairs hop between the three states, and one relationship among those rates is the mechanical heart of the model. It says that potential links are born in proportion to a node's degree — introduce yourself to someone with many friends and you instantly acquire many friends-of-friends. The next box sets up the bookkeeping and draws out its main consequence; the conclusion is restated plainly afterward, so the box may be skipped.

**The mathematics behind it: from the three-state bookkeeping to "rich get richer"** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $\nu_{x\to y}$ be the rate (per unit of network size $n$) at which a pair hops from state $x$ to state $y$. Ignoring fluctuations, the average degree and potential degree of node $i$ evolve as

$$\begin{aligned} n\,\frac{\partial k_i}{\partial n} &= \nu_{s\to e}\,\hat{k}_i + \nu_{p\to e}\,k_i^* - (\nu_{e\to s} + \nu_{e\to p})\,k_i, \\ n\,\frac{\partial k_i^*}{\partial n} &= \nu_{s\to p}\,\hat{k}_i + \nu_{e\to p}\,k_i - (\nu_{p\to s} + \nu_{p\to e})\,k_i^*, \end{aligned} \tag{3.1}$$

where $\hat{k}_i = n - k_i - k_i^*$ is the number of nodes that are neither friends nor friends-of-friends of $i$. The link between the two kinds of connection comes from the geometry of triangles: when a new node $i$ attaches to an existing node $j$, it instantly shares the common neighbor $j$ with *all* of $j$'s neighbors, gaining a potential link to each.

Hence potential links are spawned in proportion to degree,

$$\nu_{s\to p} = \nu_{s\to e}\, k_i, \qquad \nu_{p\to s} = \nu_{e\to s}\, k_i. \tag{3.2}$$

Now make two modeling choices. First, neglect link deletion, $\nu_{e\to s} = 0$ — accurate for, say, a co-authorship network, where having written a paper together is a fact that cannot later become false. Second, make closing a triangle far likelier than linking two strangers,

$$\nu_{s\to e} = \frac{\mu_0}{n^2}, \qquad \nu_{p\to e} = \frac{\mu_1}{n}, \tag{3.3}$$

the stranger-linking rate carrying an extra factor of $1/n$. Substituting these into Eq. (3.1) collapses the system to

$$n\,\frac{\partial k_i}{\partial n} = \mu_0 + \mu_1\, k_i^*, \qquad n\,\frac{\partial k_i^*}{\partial n} = \mu_0\, k_i - \mu_1\, k_i^*. \tag{3.4}$$

The upshot of Eq. (3.4) is that a node's degree grows at a rate proportional to how many friends-of-friends it has — and a node with many friends has, through them, many friends-of-friends. So once again the rich get richer, but this time the preference is manufactured by triadic closure rather than by surfing: a well-connected person is simply involved in more potential introductions. As in the previous chapter, no node ever consulted a global ranking; the bias toward hubs is a free by-product of a purely local act.

## 3.3 Degree distribution and clustering hierarchy

Because the growth rate is linear in degree, the same reasoning that gave a power law in the last chapter applies here, and it simultaneously fixes the cliquishness. The box carries out both; the two results and their meaning are in the paragraph after it.

**The mathematics behind it: the power law and the clustering hierarchy** *(this box can be skipped)*

Integrating the linear system (3.4) gives power-law growth of both degrees with the age of the node,

$$k_i(n) = k_0 \left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta}, \qquad k_i^*(n) = k_0^* \left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta}, \tag{3.5}$$

where $n_i$ is the network size when node $i$ arrived and

$$\beta = \frac{\mu_1}{2}\left(-1 + \sqrt{1 + 4\,\frac{\mu_0}{\mu_1}}\right). \tag{3.6}$$

With nodes added at a constant rate, $P(n_i{=}n) = 1/n$, a node has degree above $k$ only when it is old enough for Eq. (3.5) to exceed $k$; averaging over its birth time gives the cumulative distribution

$$P(k_i > k) = P\left[k_0 \left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta} > k\right] = \int_0^n \frac{dn_i}{n}\,\Theta\left[k_0 \left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta} - k\right] \tag{3.7}$$

with $\Theta[\cdot]$ the step function, 1 when its bracket holds and 0 otherwise. Differentiating it leaves a power-law degree distribution,

$$p_k = \frac{\partial P(k_i > k)}{\partial k} \sim k^{-\gamma}, \qquad \gamma = 1 + \frac{1}{\beta}. \tag{3.8}$$

For the clustering, the dominant way node $i$ gains a triangle is a potential link closing: when the potential link from $i$ to $j$ (sharing neighbor $k$) becomes real, $i$ gains both the neighbor $j$ and a link $j$–$k$ among its neighbors. Thus $\partial e_i/\partial n = \nu_{p\to e}\, k_i^* = \mu_1 k_i^*/n$, and integrating with Eq. (3.5),

$$\langle c \rangle_k = \frac{2e(k)}{k(k-1)} \approx \frac{2\mu_1}{k}. \tag{3.9}$$

Two familiar results emerge. First, Eq. (3.8): the degree distribution is again a power law. It is worth knowing exactly where the power law comes from — it comes from the proportionality in Eq. (3.2), the fact that potential links are spawned in proportion to degree. Were they instead spawned at a flat rate, the mechanism would still create triangles but the degree distribution would

decay exponentially, with no fat tail of hubs. Scale-freeness is the fingerprint of that degree-proportional spawning. Second, Eq. (3.9): cliquishness again falls as one over the degree — the clustering hierarchy of the introduction, now arriving by a third route (after search, and before duplication in the next chapter). Here its origin is especially vivid: every triangle a node owns is just a friend-of-a-friend pair that has been introduced.

## 3.4 Connecting nearest neighbors

The continuum theory is borne out by a minimal simulation, a growing version of the DEB rule (Davidsen et al., 2002). Starting from a single node and no links, repeat:

- with probability $1-u$, *add* a new node and link it to a randomly chosen node $j$ — which by definition creates a potential link between the newcomer and every neighbor of $j$;
- with probability $u$, *close* a triangle: pick a potential link at random and turn it into a real link.

The single dial $u$ is the rate of triangle-closing relative to adding newcomers. Feeding the mapping $\mu_0 = 1$, $\mu_1 = u/(1-u)$ into the formulas above gives the exponent in closed form, as the short box records.

**The mathematics behind it: the exponent as a function of the closure rate** *(this box can be skipped)*

With $\mu_0 = 1$ and $\mu_1 = u/(1-u)$, Eqs. (3.6) and (3.8) give

$$\gamma(u) = 1 + \frac{2(1-u)}{u}\left(-1 + \sqrt{1 + 4\,\frac{1-u}{u}}\right)^{-1}, \tag{3.10}$$

with limiting values

$$\gamma(0) = \infty, \qquad \gamma(1) = 2. \tag{3.11}$$

In words, the exponent is tunable by how eagerly the network closes triangles. When closure is frequent and newcomers rare

($u \to 1$) the exponent sinks to its minimum of 2, the most hub-dominated case; when newcomers arrive so fast that triangles never get a chance to close ($u \to 0$) the exponent blows up and the heavy tail of hubs is lost. Simulations up to a million nodes confirm the power-law degree distribution (the mean-field formula slightly overestimating the exponent, as in the previous chapter), and they confirm the clustering hierarchy, with cliquishness falling as a power of degree.

## 3.5 Why social networks are assortative

The most telling prediction is about the degree correlations — and here the friends-of-friends rule parts company with every other rule in this book. Measuring the average neighbor degree $\langle k_{nn} \rangle(k)$ in the simulated network, one finds it *rises* with degree: the well-connected are connected to the well-connected. The network is *assortative* (Newman, 2002) — "birds of a feather" — exactly as measured in real collaboration and co-authorship networks, and exactly opposite to the disassortative Internet and protein networks of the introduction.

Why the opposite sign? The reason becomes obvious once seen. Every new link here closes a triangle, joining two nodes that share a common neighbor. But a node that serves as the common neighbor of many pairs is, by definition, a high-degree node, and the two nodes it brings together are drawn from its own neighborhood, which is better connected than the network at large. So closure tends to wire together nodes of *similar*, and similarly high, degree. The very mechanism that the disassortative models of the other chapters lack — linking within a neighborhood rather than reaching out to a random or peripheral node — is what tips the correlations positive. This is the deeper lesson of the chapter, and of the review that develops it (Vazquez, 2002): the *sign* of the degree correlations is not an arbitrary fitting knob but a direct readout of the microscopic rule. Search and duplication reach outward, to the periphery, and so make hubs that shun one another; triadic closure works inward, within neighborhoods, and so makes hubs that keep each other's company.

## 3.6 Summary

Modeling social growth by triadic closure — a newcomer attaches to a node and then, over time, to that node's friends — and formalizing "friend of a friend" as a *potential link*, we obtain a tractable theory in which potential links are created in proportion to degree. From that one ingredient follow an effective "rich get richer," a power-law degree distribution with a tunable exponent $\gamma = 1 + 1/\beta$, a clustering hierarchy in which cliquishness falls as one over the degree, and — distinctively — assortative degree correlations. Connecting friends-of-friends thus reproduces, from purely local moves, the characteristic shape of social networks, and explains why the sign of their correlations differs from that of the technological and biological networks treated elsewhere in this book.

# Chapter 4

# Gene duplication

## 4.1 Networks that copy themselves

The two rules of the preceding chapters each had a newcomer reach into the existing network and *choose* where to attach — by surfing, or by closing a triangle. Biology offers a third rule, and in some ways a more primitive one: the network grows by *copying* a node that is already there. The newcomer does not pick its neighbors at all. It inherits them, wholesale, from a parent.

The setting is the inner machinery of the living cell. Genomes evolve in good part through *duplication* — a gene, or sometimes an entire genome, is accidentally copied — followed by *divergence*, the slow accumulation of mutations that make the two copies drift apart. That duplication is a major engine of evolution was argued classically by Ohno (1970). To turn this into a network statement we use the *protein interaction network*: each node is a protein (the product of a gene), and a link joins two proteins that physically interact — that bind to each other to do their job. Now watch what a gene duplication does to this network. Right after the gene is copied, the cell makes two identical proteins, so the new protein interacts with *exactly the same partners* as the old one: the duplicate node arrives already wired to all the neighbors of its ancestor (Figure 4.1). Mutations then add a few interactions and, more often, remove some, letting the twins diverge (Wagner, 2001; Solé et al., 2002). Both




(a) duplication (b) divergence

Figure 4.1: **Duplication and divergence.** (a) A gene duplication adds a copy $i'$ (gray) wired to every interaction partner of the ancestor $i$, plus a link between the twins when the protein is self-interacting. (b) Divergence then prunes the now-redundant interactions (dotted), each partner kept by only one twin, so the copies drift apart.

steps are thoroughly local — the copy needs to know only its parent and its parent's neighbors, never the rest of the genome.

The same picture reaches beyond biology. A new web page is often made by copying another page's hyperlinks and then editing the list — duplication as copying, divergence as editing. Following Vazquez (2003) and Vazquez et al. (2003), this chapter shows that copy-and-diverge, like the rules before it, produces an effective "rich get richer," a power-law degree distribution, the clustering hierarchy, and — as actually measured in protein networks (Maslov and Sneppen, 2002) — *disassortative* correlations. It also reveals something new: a *multifractal* degree distribution, which we will unpack when we reach it, a fingerprint left by the act of inheritance.

## 4.2 Duplication and divergence, in their simplest form

Start with the simplest version, treating duplication and divergence as independent random events. The single idea that drives everything is this: a node gains a new link whenever one of its *neighbors* is duplicated, because the neighbor's copy inherits a link back to it. A well-connected node has many neighbors, so it has many chances

to be on the receiving end of a duplication — and there, already, is the rich getting richer. The box makes this precise and reads off the degree distribution; the conclusion follows it.

**The mathematics behind it: degree growth and the power law from duplication** *(this box can be skipped)*

In a mean-field (average-quantities) description, with increasing the number of nodes $n$ the degree of node $i$ evolves as

$$\frac{\partial k_i}{\partial n} = \nu_D\, k_i + \nu_C\,(n - k_i) - \nu_L\, k_i, \tag{4.1}$$

with $\nu_D$, $\nu_C$, $\nu_L$ the per-node rates of duplication, random link creation, and link loss. The first term is the key one: it is proportional to $k_i$ because each of $i$'s $k_i$ neighbors, if duplicated, hands $i$ a new link. Each duplication adds one node, so $\nu_D = 1/n$; writing $\nu_C = \mu_0/n$ and $\nu_L = \mu_1/n$ reduces the equation to

$$n\,\frac{\partial k_i}{\partial n} = \mu_0 + (1 - \mu_1)\, k_i, \tag{4.2}$$

whose growth rate is linear in the degree. Integrating it gives the degree of node $i$ as the network grows,

$$k_i(n) = \left(k_i(n_i) + \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1}\right)\left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta} - \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1}, \tag{4.3}$$

where $n_i$ and $k_i(n_i)$ are the network size and the node's degree at the moment it was added, and the exponent is

$$\beta = 1 - \mu_1 \qquad (\mu_1 < 1), \tag{4.4}$$

the condition $\mu_1 < 1$ keeping the network from emptying out. To turn this growth law into a degree distribution, note that node $i$ has degree above $k$ exactly when its age and birth degree make Eq. (4.3) exceed $k$,

$$P(k_i > k) = \Theta\left[\left(k_i(n_i) + \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1}\right)\left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta} - \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1} > k\right], \tag{4.5}$$

with $\Theta[\cdot]$ the step function, 1 when its bracket holds and 0 otherwise. Both its birth size $n_i$ and its birth degree $k_i(n_i)$ are random: for nodes added at a constant rate $n_i$ is uniform, $P(n_i{=}n) = 1/n$, while

a node inherits its ancestor's degree, so $P[k_i(n_i){=}k'] = p_{k'}$ in the stationary state. Averaging over both,

$$P(k_i > k) = \sum_{k'} p_{k'} \int_1^n \frac{dn_i}{n}\, \Theta\left[\left(k' + \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1}\right)\left(\frac{n}{n_i}\right)^{\beta} - \frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1} > k\right] \tag{4.6}$$

Differentiating this cumulative distribution and taking $n \gg 1$ leaves, for nodes added at a constant rate, a power-law degree distribution

$$p_k = \frac{\partial P(k_i > k)}{\partial k} \sim \left(\frac{\mu_0}{1-\mu_1} + k\right)^{-\gamma}, \qquad \gamma = 1 + \frac{1}{1-\mu_1}. \tag{4.7}$$

The result is once again a power law, Eq. (4.7), and its exponent is controlled entirely by $\mu_1$, the rate at which divergence removes links: the more aggressively the duplicates shed interactions, the steeper the tail and the fewer the giant hubs. As in the previous two chapters, the power law can be traced to a single term that grows in proportion to degree — here the duplication term of Eq. (4.2) — and without it the distribution would decay as a featureless exponential. Copying, all by itself, is a rich-get-richer engine.

## 4.3 Cliquishness from self-interaction

If divergence added and removed links purely at random, this model would make no triangles, and its cliquishness would fade to nothing in a large network. But biology supplies one specific local source of triangles. Some proteins are *self-interacting* — they bind to copies of themselves. When the gene for such a protein is duplicated, the ancestor and its new twin can bind to *each other*, because each still carries the self-binding site (Wagner, 2001). That single interaction, laid down at the moment of duplication, is the seed of a triangle. The short box turns this into the clustering law.

**The mathematics behind it: the clustering hierarchy from self-interaction** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let a duplicated self-interacting protein bond to its ancestor with probability $q_v$. Then whenever a neighbor of node $i$ is duplicated, $i$ gains not only the copy as a new neighbor but, with probability $q_v$, a link between two of its neighbors (the ancestor and the copy). Hence the number of links $e_i$ between the neighbors of node $i$ change as

$$\frac{\partial e_i}{\partial n} \approx q_v \frac{\partial k_i}{\partial n}. \tag{4.8}$$

Integrating, assuming $e_i = 0$ when $k_i = 1$, we get $e_i = q_v(k_i - 1)$. Inserting this result into the clustering definition,

$$\langle c \rangle_k = \frac{2e(k)}{k(k-1)} \approx \frac{2q_v}{k}. \tag{4.9}$$

So cliquishness again falls as one over the degree, Eq. (4.9) — the clustering hierarchy of the introduction, reached now by a third independent route. There is one telling refinement: because removing an interaction also destroys triangles, and the biggest hubs have the most triangles to lose, divergence makes the clustering of high-degree nodes decay a little *faster* than one over the degree. That slightly-too-steep falloff is a small signature that distinguishes duplication from the search and closure mechanisms.

## 4.4 When duplication and divergence are coupled

In a real protein network the two processes cannot truly be independent. The network does a job — it keeps the cell alive — so losing the wrong interaction can be lethal, and which links a duplicate keeps is under natural selection. The classical view of Ohno (1970) lets one redundant copy decay freely; the more modern *subfunctionalization* picture of Force et al. (1999) has the two copies divide the ancestor's duties between them, each keeping part, together keeping the whole. Either way the fates of the two copies' links are *coupled*: a shared interaction is far more likely to be retained by one copy

than dropped by both. To capture this, Vazquez et al. (2003) use the following rule. Starting from two connected nodes, repeat:

- *Duplication.* Pick a node $i$ at random and add a copy $i'$ joined to every neighbor of $i$; with probability $q_v$ also add the link $i$–$i'$ (the self-interaction case).
- *Divergence.* For each node $j$ now joined to both $i$ and $i'$, delete one of the two redundant links $(i, j)$ or $(i', j)$, at random, with probability $1 - q_e$.

The divergence step touches only the *redundant* pairs just created, and that is what couples it to duplication. Genomic data showing that duplicates diverge soon after they are born (Wagner, 2001) justify treating divergence as finishing before the next duplication, so the node count $n$ doubles as a clock. A related model with lopsided divergence is studied in Vazquez (2003).

Coupling makes the large-scale behavior considerably richer, in two ways worth previewing before the box. First, a single number — the retention parameter $q_e$ — decides whether the network stays sparse or grows ever denser, with a sharp switch between the two regimes. Second, the degree distribution is no longer a plain power law but a *multifractal* one. A quick word on that term: a plain power law is described by one exponent, the same at every scale; a multifractal is described by a whole continuum of exponents, because different "moments" of the distribution (the average degree, the average of the squared degree, and so on) scale with different powers of the network size. The box records the transition and the moment exponents; the interpretation follows.

**The mathematics behind it: the density transition and the multifractal spectrum** *(this box can be skipped)*

Tracking the mean degree through one duplication event gives

$$\langle k\rangle(n+1) = \frac{n\langle k\rangle(n) + 2q_v + (2q_e - 1)\langle k\rangle(n)}{n+1} \tag{4.10}$$

which in the large-network limit switches behavior at $q_e = 1/2$: for $q_e < 1/2$ the mean degree saturates at the finite value $\langle k\rangle = 2q_v/(1 - 2q_e)$, while for $q_e > 1/2$ it grows without bound as $N^{2q_e - 1}$. A rate-equation treatment in the manner of Kim et al. (2002) gives

an attachment rate $A(k) = (q_v + q_e k)/n$ — linear in degree again — and predicts that the $l$-th moment of the degree distribution scales as $M_l \sim n^{\sigma_l(q_e)}$ with

$$\sigma_l(q_e) = l\, q_e + 2\left[\left(\frac{1+q_e}{2}\right)^l - 1\right]. \tag{4.11}$$

For each $l$ there is a value $q_l$ at which $\sigma_l$ changes sign, with $q_1 = 1/2$ and $q_2 = 2\sqrt{3} - 3 \approx 0.46$.

The two messages of the box are these. First, Eq. (4.10) shows a genuine switch at $q_e = 1/2$: keep too few links and the network settles into a sparse steady state; keep enough and it densifies forever. Second, and more subtle, the moment exponents $\sigma_l$ in Eq. (4.11) depend on $l$ in a curved, *nonlinear* way — the hallmark of a multifractal. Where the earlier chapters gave clean single power laws, duplication gives a spectrum of exponents, and the reason is exactly the inheritance at its core: each newcomer copies the degree environment of its parent, injecting a kind of heritable heterogeneity that a single exponent cannot capture. The deletion of links from the copies is what converts that inheritance into multifractality.

## 4.5 Disassortative correlations

Simulations spanning network sizes from a thousand to a million nodes confirm the analysis (Vazquez et al., 2003; Vazquez, 2003): the moment exponents match the multifractal prediction; the clustering falls with degree as a power law with exponent at or above one (steepening as link loss grows, just as Eq. (4.9) and its caveat foretold); and the average neighbor degree *decreases* with degree, $\langle k_{nn}\rangle(k) \sim k^{-0.1}$. The duplication network is therefore *disassortative* — its hubs are surrounded by poorly-connected partners rather than by each other.

This is the correct sign. Disassortative mixing is precisely what Maslov and Sneppen (2002) measured in the protein interaction network of yeast, and it files duplication alongside the technological networks of Chapter 2 and against the social networks of Chapter 3. With this third mechanism in hand, the three rules of the book so

far bracket the empirical landscape, as the table summarizes (here $\beta$ is the rate at which cliquishness falls with degree, and $\alpha$ the slope of the neighbor-degree curve — positive for assortative, negative for disassortative):

| Mechanism | $\langle c \rangle_k \sim k^{-\beta}$ | $\langle k_{nn} \rangle_k \sim k^{\alpha}$ |
|---|---|---|
| Connecting neighbors | $0 < \beta < 1$ | $\alpha > 0$ |
| Random walk | $\beta = 1$ | $\alpha \leq 0$ |
| Duplication–divergence | $\beta \geq 1$ | $\alpha < 0$ |

Every local rule produces a clustering hierarchy; what differs is the *sign* of the correlations, which sorts the rules into the assortative (social, closure-driven) and disassortative (technological and biological, reach-driven) classes seen in real data.

## 4.6 The unifying principle

Three different stories — surfing a network, closing a triangle, copying a node — have each delivered the same effective "rich get richer." That is no accident, and the duplication picture makes the reason simple enough to state in a single sentence.

Picking a node *at random* plays no favorites: every node is equally likely, hub or not. But none of the local rules in this book act on a randomly chosen node. They act on a *neighbor* of one — the page a surfer steps to, the friend a friend introduces, the partner a duplicated gene inherits. And the chance that a particular node $i$ is the neighbor of a randomly chosen node is

$$\frac{k_i}{\sum_j k_j}, \tag{4.12}$$

which is exactly the linear preferential-attachment probability of the Barabási–Albert model (Barabási and Albert, 1999). High-degree nodes are over-represented among the neighbors of a random node for the most elementary of reasons: they belong to more neighborhoods, so more random nodes have them as a neighbor. Preferential attachment never has to be imposed. It is induced automatically the instant a growth rule takes one step out from a random node to one of its neighbors. The clustering hierarchy has

the same local root — a rule that makes one link to a node tends to make another among that node's neighbors — and the sign of the degree correlations depends on *which* neighbor gets chosen. Locality is the common cause, and the three mechanisms are three faces of it.

## 4.7 Summary

Biological networks grow by duplication: a node is copied along with its connections, and the copies then diverge by gaining and losing links. Because a node gains a link whenever one of its neighbors is duplicated, the rule builds in an effective "rich get richer" and hence a power-law degree distribution, while duplications of self-interacting proteins generate a clustering hierarchy that link loss steepens. Coupling divergence to duplication adds a density transition at $q_e = 1/2$ and a multifractal degree distribution born of inheritance, and the model reproduces the disassortative correlations measured in real protein networks. Together with the two previous chapters, duplication completes a simple and general principle: a growth rule that attaches to a *neighbor* of a randomly chosen node attaches preferentially by degree — and so preferential attachment, the clustering hierarchy, and degree correlations are all the generic harvest of locality.

# Chapter 5

# Activity specialization

## 5.1 Projects as growing networks

The duplication rule of the previous chapter was born in biology, but copying is not a biological privilege. This chapter applies the same idea to a very different system — the schedule of a large engineering project — and gets, in return, a surprising practical payoff: an explanation of why big projects so reliably run late.

A project schedule can be drawn as a network, called an *activity network*. Its nodes are the individual activities, or tasks, that make up the project, and its links record *precedence*: a link from activity $a$ to activity $b$ means $b$ cannot begin until $a$ is finished — you cannot paint a wall before it is built. Because work only flows forward in time, the network has no loops; in the jargon it is a *directed acyclic graph*, with starting activities (no predecessors) and finishing activities (no successors). For such a network there is one object that has ruled project management since the 1950s: the *critical path*. This is the longest chain of dependent activities running from start to finish — the route through the project with no slack anywhere along it, so that delaying *any* activity on it pushes back the whole project's end date by the same amount (Kelley and Walker, 1959). The manager's time-honored prescription is therefore simple: watch the critical path, and guard it at all costs.

And yet projects keep finishing late. A survey of more than ten

thousand of them found only a few percent delivered on time and on budget, and fifteen years of improvements in management practice barely moved that figure (Flyvbjerg et al., 2003). This stubborn record hints that the critical path — a single one-dimensional thread — may be the wrong thing to watch in schedules that have grown into genuinely complex networks. Following Vazquez et al. (2023), this chapter grows such schedules from a local rule, shows that the critical path *shrinks toward irrelevance* as projects get bigger, and relocates the real source of delay risk in the network as a whole.

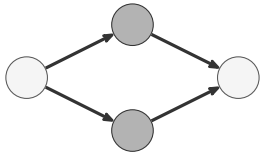
## 5.2 The duplication–split rule

Where does a schedule come from? Not in one piece. A plan is *refined*: a coarse activity is broken into finer ones, again and again, until the plan is detailed enough to execute. There are two natural ways to break an activity in two, and they correspond to two kinds of work. This is our local rule, with a single dial, the duplication probability $q$. Beginning from two activities in series, repeat: pick an existing activity at random and, with probability $q$, *duplicate* it, otherwise *split* it.

- *Duplication* (probability $q$). A *generic* activity is split into two smaller activities that run *in parallel* — think of doubling a crew so two teams do the same kind of work at once. Both copies inherit *all* the predecessors and *all* the successors of the parent. Duplication *widens* the schedule, adding parallel strands of work.

- *Split* (probability $1 - q$). A *specialized* activity is cut into two activities run *in sequence* — one specialist does the first part and hands off to another who does the second. The parent keeps its predecessors, the new activity takes over its successors, and a link joins the two. Splitting *lengthens* the schedule, extending a chain.

So the dial $q$ measures how a project is organized (Figure 5.1). Small $q$ means almost every refinement is a split: work is broken into ever-longer chains of specialists, and the schedule is nearly a single long line. Large $q$ means almost every refinement is a duplication:



(a) duplication: in parallel



(b) split: in sequence

Figure 5.1: **Refining an activity.** A generic activity is replaced either by (a) two copies that run *in parallel*, both inheriting the predecessor (left, gray) and successor (right, gray) of the parent — duplication, which widens the schedule — or by (b) two specialized activities that run *in sequence* — a split, which lengthens it.

generic work is parallelized into many simultaneous strands, and the schedule fans out into a broad web. The same copying that duplicated a gene in the previous chapter here duplicates an activity; the new ingredient is the *split* — the act of *specialization* that gives the chapter its name — and the forward-flowing, start-to-finish structure of a schedule.

## 5.3 Predecessors and successors: identical power laws

Because the rule copies an activity together with its predecessors and successors, it is a duplication rule of the kind that produced power-law degrees in the previous chapter — only now there are two degrees to track, the number of predecessors (the in-degree) and the number of successors (the out-degree). The box works out the distribution of predecessors by following how many activities have each number of them; the same argument applies verbatim to successors. The result is in the paragraph after.

**The mathematics behind it: the distribution of predecessors** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $n_k(n)$ be the number of activities with $k$ predecessors when the schedule has $n$ activities in all. Adding one activity changes this count by

$$n_k(n+1) = n_k(n) + q\left[\frac{k-1}{n}\,n_{k-1}(n) - \frac{k}{n}\,n_k(n) + \frac{1}{n}\,n_k(n)\right] + (1-q)\,\delta_{k,1} \tag{5.1}$$

the bracket collecting the duplication events (an activity climbs from $k-1$ to $k$ predecessors when one of its predecessors is duplicated, and so on) and the last term adding a fresh single-predecessor activity at each split. Looking for a stable shape $n_k(n) = n\,p_k$ turns this into a recurrence,

$$p_k = q\big[(k-1)\,p_{k-1} - k\,p_k + p_k\big] + (1-q)\,\delta_{k,1}, \tag{5.2}$$

which solves in closed form (with $\Gamma$ the gamma function) to

$$p_k = \prod_{s=1}^{k-1} \frac{s}{\frac{1}{q}+s}\;p_1 = \Gamma\!\left(\tfrac{1}{q}+1\right)\frac{\Gamma(k)}{\Gamma\!\left(\tfrac{1}{q}+k\right)}\,p_1, \tag{5.3}$$

with the power-law tail

$$p_k \sim k^{-1/q}. \tag{5.4}$$

The result, Eq. (5.4), is a power law with exponent $\gamma = 1/q$. A wide, duplication-heavy schedule (large $q$) has the heaviest tail of highly-connected activities; at $q = 1/2$ we recover the familiar value $\gamma = 2$. The very same reasoning, run on successors instead of predecessors, gives the *identical* distribution for the out-degree. That coincidence is the model's signature prediction — the spread of predecessor counts and the spread of successor counts should look the same — and it follows directly from the even-handed way duplication treats the two ends of an activity.

## 5.4 The vanishing critical path

The degrees are a local property; the critical path is a global one. Remarkably, the same rule fixes how the critical path grows with the

size of the project, and the answer overturns the manager's intuition. The box does the short calculation; the consequences follow.

**The mathematics behind it: how the critical path scales** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $c$ be the number of activities on the critical path of an $n$-activity schedule. The path can only lengthen when a *split* lands on it (a split inserts an activity in series), and the chance that the activity picked for refinement lies on the critical path is $c/n$. Hence

$$\frac{dc}{dn} = (1-q)\,\frac{c}{n}, \tag{5.5}$$

which integrates to $c \sim n^{1-q}$, so the *fraction* of activities on the critical path shrinks as

$$\frac{c}{n} \sim n^{-\alpha(q)}, \qquad \alpha(q) \le q. \tag{5.6}$$

Because distances here grow as a power of size, $c \sim n^{1/D}$, the network is a *fractal* with dimension

$$D = \frac{1}{1-\alpha(q)}. \tag{5.7}$$

The headline is Eq. (5.6): for any amount of duplication ($q > 0$), the critical path is a *vanishing fraction* of the project as the project grows. The bigger and more parallel the schedule, the smaller the slice of the work that the manager's cherished path actually covers — so watching the critical path means watching an ever-shrinking sliver of the whole. (Simulations confirm the power-law shrinkage, with the measured exponent $\alpha$ a little below the simple bound $q$; for instance $\alpha \approx 0.11$, 0.28, 0.43 at $q = 0.20$, 0.50, 0.70.)

The scaling also tells us what *kind* of network a schedule is. In a small-world network, distances grow only logarithmically with size — doubling the network barely lengthens the longest path. Here distances grow as a *power* of size, the mark of a *fractal* network: one whose "size" and "length" are tied together by a fixed dimension $D$, much as a physical fractal looks the same at every magnification. Duplication–split schedules are thus a class apart — power-law degrees like a scale-free network, but power-law (not logarithmic)

distances, unlike a small world. Specialization builds the long fractal chains; duplication stacks them up in parallel.

## 5.5 Real project schedules

This is not just a story about a model. Vazquez et al. (2023) examined 77 real construction projects, together worth more than ten billion dollars, which yielded 323 activity networks — snapshots of projects at different stages — ranging from about a hundred to sixteen thousand activities. Three predictions survive the encounter with data. First, the predecessor and successor counts are each power-law distributed, and fitting them *separately* yields duplication indices $q$ that agree, just as the model demands they should. Second, those indices fall between roughly 0.1 and 0.5, most above 0.2: real schedules sit on the split-dominated, nearly-linear side — but with enough duplication to matter. Third, the share of activities on the critical path falls with project size right across the collection, confirming that the critical path really does dwindle as projects grow.

## 5.6 Delay risk as percolation

If the critical path fades to insignificance and yet projects are still late, where does the delay risk live? The answer is that it is spread across the whole network, and it is governed by *percolation* — the same mathematics that describes how water seeps through porous rock or how a forest fire spreads from tree to tree.

Picture an outside shock — bad weather, a strike, a pandemic — that pushes some activities past their planned finish. A delay only passes to a downstream activity if it is large enough to use up the spare time, the *free float*, built into that dependency; otherwise the buffer absorbs it and the delay stops there. Now treat each dependency as a channel that passes a delay along with some probability $p$, and ask what fraction of activities end up delayed beyond their own slack — the *delay incidence*. This is exactly a percolation problem: delays spread through the network of dependencies like fire through a forest, and percolation theory says such spreading has a sharp

*threshold* (Albert et al., 2000; Ellinas, 2019; Schwartz et al., 2002),

$$p_c = \frac{1}{\langle k \rangle}, \tag{5.8}$$

where $\langle k \rangle$ is the average number of downstream dependencies per activity. The meaning of a threshold is stark: below $p_c$ delays stay local and project-wide overruns essentially never happen; above $p_c$ a finite fraction of projects suffer a system-wide cascade — the fire jumps the firebreaks.

The data choose between two stories cleanly. If the critical path governed delay, the incidence ought to track $p\,c$ (transmission times critical-path size); in the real projects that correlation is negligible. If percolation governs delay, the incidence ought to switch on exactly at $p - p_c = 0$; and that is what the construction projects show — below threshold, delay incidence stays under one percent; above it, the incidence climbs, reaching fifteen percent of all activities in the worst cases. The true control knob of project delay is $p - p_c$, a property of the *whole* network, not $p\,c$, a property of one path through it.

Here is the chapter's practical lesson, and its link to the rest of the book. The very same local rule that sets the degree distributions also sets the average degree $\langle k \rangle$, and through Eq. (5.8) the threshold for catastrophic delay. A project's tendency to run late is written into the network its activities have grown into — not into any single path through it.

## 5.7 Summary

Project schedules are forward-flowing networks of activities, grown by a local refinement rule: pick an activity and either duplicate it into parallel copies (probability $q$) or split it into specialized sequential parts. This duplication–split rule predicts identical power-law distributions for the numbers of predecessors and successors, $p_k \sim k^{-1/q}$; a critical path that grows only as $c \sim n^{1-q}$ and so vanishes as a fraction of large projects; and a fractal, rather than small-world, geometry. All three hold in 77 real construction projects. And because the critical path becomes irrelevant at scale, delay risk is

better read through percolation, with a threshold $p_c = 1/\langle k \rangle$ fixed by the grown network's average degree — so that project performance, in the end, is a property of the activity network as a whole.

# Chapter 6

# Emergence of communities

## 6.1 Communities nobody designed

So far the local rules of this book have explained the *degree* structure of networks — their power laws, their clustering hierarchy, their correlations. This chapter turns to a feature of an altogether different kind: *community structure*. A community is a group of nodes that are densely connected among themselves but only sparsely connected to the rest of the network — a clump that hangs together. They are everywhere in real data: people fall into social circles, web pages into topics, proteins into functional modules, each group talking mostly to itself. Splitting a network into such groups is what researchers mean by *community detection*, and a network that splits cleanly is said to have strong community structure.

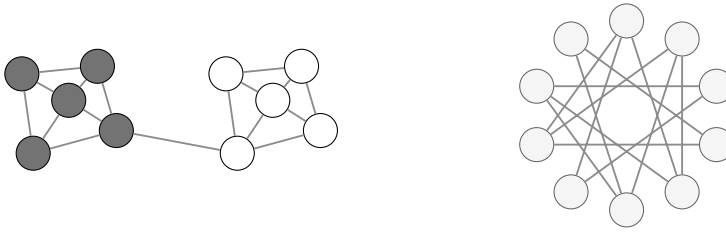
Where do these communities come from? The usual answer points to differences between the nodes themselves — *node heterogeneity*, in the jargon. People of the same profession or politics, web pages on the same subject, proteins with the same biological function: nodes of a kind, the story goes, are simply more likely to link to one another, and that built-in preference is what carves the network into groups. On this view, communities are stamped onto the network by properties the nodes carried in from the start.

The thesis of this chapter, following Vazquez (2025), is that no such stamp is needed. *Communities emerge from local growth rules even when every node is identical.* The first hint is decades old: Jin et al. (2001) showed that a social network grown purely by triadic closure — the friends-of-friends rule of Chapter 3 — develops communities although its nodes are all of one type, and the same was later seen in the gene-duplication models of Chapter 4 (Solé et al., 2002). If a featureless local rule segregates a network into groups all by itself, then community structure joins preferential attachment and the clustering hierarchy as one more thing that *emerges* from locality rather than being designed in.

To make that claim sharp we should ask it as a quantitative question, and the right way to frame it comes from a corner of mathematics called *Ramsey theory.* Ramsey theory studies how large a random structure must become before some orderly pattern is forced to appear. Its best-known nugget is a party fact: in any gathering of six people, there are always either three who all know one another or three who are all mutual strangers — order of that kind is unavoidable once the group is big enough. We will ask the analogous question of growing networks: given a local growth rule, how large must the network become before it is virtually *certain* to contain communities? This chapter is, in effect, a Ramsey theory of community structure in growing networks.

## 6.2 The Ramsey community number

Before we can measure when communities appear, we need a trustworthy way to *detect* them, and here some care is required, because the most popular method can be fooled. That method, *modularity optimization*, looks for the division of a network that packs the most links inside groups; the trouble is that it will happily report groups even in a completely random network that has no real structure at all (Newman, 2006; Fortunato, 2010). To avoid being deceived, the work relies instead on two more discerning tools: the *stochastic block model*, which fits the network to a statistical model of blocks and keeps only the structure that genuinely earns its keep (Karrer and Newman, 2011), cross-checked against *Infomap*, which finds groups by watching where a random walker gets trapped (Rosvall



(a) grown by a local rule (b) after random rewiring

Figure 6.1: **Communities emerge from local rules.** (a) A network grown by a local rule settles into dense communities (two here, one dark gray, one white) joined by only a few links. (b) Shuffling the links at random while keeping every node's number of connections destroys the communities — so the structure was the work of the rule, not of the degrees alone.

and Bergstrom, 2008). Both, crucially, report *no* communities in a truly random network.

That last point also supplies the essential control. To be sure a community is the work of the growth rule and not merely of the degrees, one compares the grown network against a *rewired* version of itself — the links shuffled at random while every node keeps its number of connections (this shuffling is called the configuration model). If the communities survive the shuffle, they were never more than an accident of the degrees; if they vanish, they were the doing of the local rule. For every local model in this chapter, the shuffled version has no communities at all — so whatever structure we find is genuinely built by the dynamics.

With detection settled, we can pose the question precisely (Figure 6.1). The box below states the two definitions that do the work; both are short, and their meaning is given in words right after, so the box can be skipped.

**The mathematics behind it: the communities likelihood and the Ramsey community number** *(this box can be skipped)*

For a growth rule $f_G$ that produces a network of $n$ nodes, let a detection method $f_\kappa$ return the number $\kappa$ of communities it finds. Define the *communities likelihood* as the probability — estimated by generating many networks — that an $n$-node instance has more than one community,

$$P_\kappa(n) = \text{Prob}\{\, \kappa \geq 2 \,\}. \tag{6.1}$$

The *Ramsey community number* is then the smallest size at which communities are all but guaranteed, at a confidence $1 - \epsilon$ (we use $\epsilon = 0.05$, i.e. 95%):

$$r_\kappa = \min\{\, n : P_\kappa(n) \geq 1 - \epsilon \,\}. \tag{6.2}$$

A rule is said to have the *emergent communities property* when such an $r_\kappa$ exists.

In plain terms: $P_\kappa(n)$ is the chance that a network grown to size $n$ has communities, and the Ramsey community number $r_\kappa$ is the size beyond which that chance is essentially $(1 - \epsilon)100\%$. A *finite* $r_\kappa$ is the fingerprint of emergence — grow the network past it and communities are a near-certainty. A rule for which no such size exists, no matter how large the network, simply does not make communities on its own. The whole question "do communities emerge from this rule?" thus reduces to "is $r_\kappa$ finite?"

One caution should be lodged now and collected later. The definition above is stated *relative to a detection method* $f_\kappa$: $r_\kappa$ is a property of the network *and* of the rule used to interrogate it, and the two cannot be separated. For most of this chapter that dependence is a technicality, the choice of method shifting the numbers without touching the conclusions. In the last part of the chapter, where we can compute $r_\kappa$ exactly, it will turn out to be rather more than a technicality.

## 6.3 Local rules grow communities

We now line up two local rules against two controls. The local rules — local search and duplication–split, both met earlier in this book —

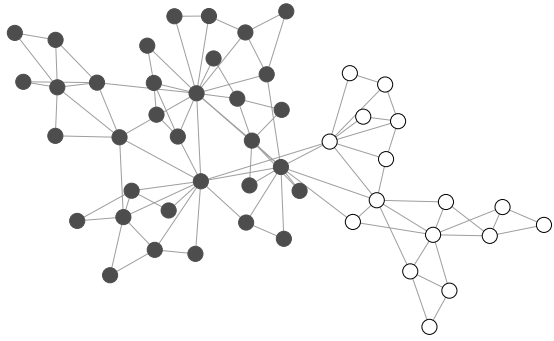


Figure 6.2: **Communities in a local-search network.** An instance of the local-search model $LS(n{=}50, \ell{=}1)$. The stochastic block model resolves two communities, shown dark gray and white; they emerge even though the rule treats every node alike and never mentions groups.

have the emergent communities property; the controls — reshuffling a network's links, and growing one with no locality at all — do not. Holding the four side by side is the whole argument of the chapter in miniature.

**Local search.** The model $LS(n, \ell)$ is the search rule of Chapter 2 in undirected form (Vazquez, 2001): each new node takes a short walk of $\ell$ steps from a random starting node and links to every node it visits. It carries preferential attachment and high clustering, and — though nothing in the rule ever mentions groups — the block model resolves clear communities, with $P_\kappa$ climbing from near zero around $n = 10$ to a near-certain one beyond about $n = 100$, and staying there out to a hundred thousand nodes (Vazquez, 2025). Figure 6.2 shows one such network.

**Duplication–split.** The model $DS(n, q)$ is the undirected cousin of the project-schedule rule of Chapter 5: a new node either copies all of a random node's links (probability $q$) or splits one of its links in two. This model is the decisive case, because it builds *no triangles whatsoever* — duplication makes none, and splitting destroys any

that might form — and yet communities emerge just as reliably. The lesson is sharp: a network does not need to be cliquish to have communities. What it needs is locality, not triangles. Figure 6.3 shows an instance: two communities, and not a triangle in sight.

**Degree-preserving randomization.** To be sure the communities are the work of the local rule and not of the degrees alone, we need a way to wipe out the local structure while leaving every degree untouched. The *configuration model*, met when we defined the Ramsey number, does exactly that: it takes a finished network and reshuffles its links at random, keeping each node's number of connections fixed but scrambling *which* nodes are joined. Applied to a local-search or a duplication–split network, this reshuffling destroys the communities outright — the randomized versions have no finite Ramsey number at all (the two "randomized" rows in the table below). Whatever the local rules built, the bare list of degrees cannot sustain.

**Barabási–Albert.** Finally, $BA(n, m)$, the canonical preferential-attachment model, is our *non-local* control: a growing, rich-get-richer network in which each newcomer attaches its $m$ links to nodes drawn from the *whole* graph, never once consulting a neighborhood. Despite its growth and its rich-get-richer rule it has no emergent communities (the last row of the table), and the next section is devoted to teasing apart exactly why.

A few representative Ramsey numbers, based on numerical estimates for $\epsilon = 0.05$ (Vazquez, 2025), make the pattern concrete:

| Model | $r_\kappa$ (block model) | $r_\kappa$ (Infomap) |
|---|---|---|
| $LS(\ell = 1)$ | 81 | 222 |
| $DS(q = 0.5)$ | 98 | 622 |
| $LS(\ell = 1)$, randomized | — | — |
| $DS(q = 0.5)$, randomized | — | — |
| $BA(m = 2)$ | — | — |

The two columns already show that $r_\kappa$ depends on how one looks: Infomap needs two to six times the size the block model does. The dependence goes deeper than a choice of algorithm. Chapter 8 fits

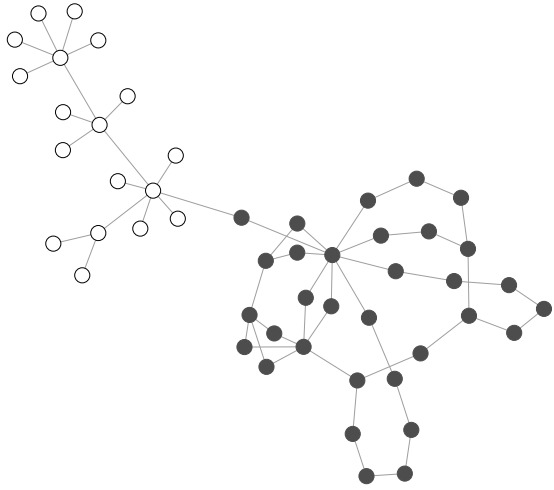


Figure 6.3: **Communities in a duplication–split network.** An instance of the duplication–split model $DS(n{=}50, q{=}0.3)$. Two communities (dark gray and white) again emerge — even though this rule builds no triangles at all, so the network is far less cliquish than the local-search one of Figure 6.2.

these same rules with a block model that can also describe its links as planted triangles and squares, and finds $r_\kappa = 200$ for $LS(\ell = 1)$ against the 81 above, while $DS(q = 0.5)$ does not move at all — because local search's structure *is* triangles, and a method that can name a triangle stops counting it as evidence for a community. Read the numbers below as properties of a rule seen through an instrument, which is what the definition says they are.

Every genuinely local rule has a finite Ramsey number — grow it past a few hundred nodes and communities are certain. The rules without local structure — the bottom three rows, the two reshuffled networks and the Barabási–Albert model — have none: the dashes mean communities never become certain, however large the network. The exact figures differ between the two detection methods — there is no single "true" definition of a community, and where the line falls depends a little on how one draws it — but the *split* between

local rules (finite) and non-local ones (infinite) is the same either way. Local structure is a necessary condition for communities to emerge.

## 6.4 When globality fails: the Barabási–Albert model

The natural control is the Barabási–Albert model (Barabási and Albert, 1999), the textbook growing network with *no* locality at all: each newcomer attaches its $m$ links to nodes chosen from the *whole* network in proportion to their degree. It has growth and preferential attachment, but no step that ever looks at a node's neighborhood — and it does *not* have the emergent communities property. Its community likelihood rises only to about one-half near a thousand nodes and then *falls* as the network grows further, never reaching certainty. The little structure it has comes from the mere age-ordering of its nodes, not from any local rule, and it washes out at scale.

The boundary case is illuminating. Give the model a baseline "attractiveness" $a$, so that a node is chosen with a probability proportional to $a + k_i / \sum_j k_j$ — a fixed head-start $a$ on top of the usual degree preference. This tunes the degree exponent to $\gamma = 2 + a/m$. Tracking the Ramsey number across these variants reveals a clean rule of thumb: communities emerge exactly when the network is *clustered* enough. The Ramsey number falls as the average clustering coefficient rises, and *diverges* — communities never become certain — as the clustering goes to zero (Vazquez, 2025). The standard Barabási–Albert model sits right at that vanishing point, because its clustering decays toward zero as it grows (like $(\ln n)^2/n$): the bigger it gets, the fewer short cycles it has, and short cycles are what local structure is made of. So even here the principle holds — where the dynamics happen to generate appreciable clustering (an *implicit* bit of local structure), communities appear; where clustering fades, they do not.

## 6.5 How local must "local" be?

If locality is the cause, exactly how local must a connection be to count? Two dials settle it: the length of the cycles a rule creates, and the distance it reaches across. Triadic closure closes triangles (cycles of length three); the duplication–split rule works with squares (length four). To sweep the cycle length freely, use the *bubble model*: at each step a chain of $L$ new nodes is added and its two ends are attached to the two ends of a randomly chosen existing link, creating a fresh cycle of length $L + 2$. As $L$ grows — as the rule weaves ever longer cycles — the Ramsey number climbs with it, and steeply: from $r_\kappa = 108$ for the shortest cycles to more than fifty thousand by $L = 9$ (Vazquez, 2025), as the table below records. The climb is not quite smooth — riding on top of it is a regular even–odd alternation, the odd-length cycles bringing communities on sooner than the even cycles around them, an effect plainest for the shorter cycles — but the overall message is unmistakable: short cycles, tight local feedback, bring communities on soonest.

| $L$ | cycle length $L + 2$ | $r_\kappa$ |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | 3 | 108 |
| 2 | 4 | 326 |
| 3 | 5 | 246 |
| 4 | 6 | 2201 |
| 5 | 7 | 752 |
| 6 | 8 | 6595 |
| 7 | 9 | 2740 |
| 8 | 10 | 15863 |
| 9 | 11 | 56160 |

Distance matters just as much. In the bubble model the chain's two ends attach to nodes that are a single step apart (the ends of one link). Loosen this so the ends may attach to nodes up to $W$ steps apart, with the chain length fixed at $L = 1$. For $W = 1$ communities still emerge with certainty, at $r_\kappa = 108$; stretching to $W = 2$ pushes the threshold up roughly tenfold, to $r_\kappa = 1090$, but the communities still come. At $W = 3$ — and likewise if the ends are joined to nodes picked anywhere at random — they stop appearing altogether, the Ramsey number ceasing to exist (the dash in the table) (Vazquez,

2025).

| $W$ | $r_\kappa$ |
|---|---|
| 1 | 108 |
| 2 | 1090 |
| 3 | — |

For this model, "local" means roughly two steps: communities form when new links reinforce ties among nearby nodes, and dissolve once links are allowed to leap across the network. This is the whole book's premise made quantitative. It is not growth, nor preferential attachment, nor even clustering in the abstract that carves a network into communities — it is the *locality* of the rule by which it grew.

## 6.6 Networks we can solve exactly

Everything so far has been measured, not proved. The Ramsey numbers of the last three sections came from growing many networks and running a detection algorithm on each — honest work, but it leaves the central question in the dark. We know *that* communities appear beyond a certain size. We do not know *why*, and we cannot say what the size depends on.

To answer that we need cases simple enough to solve with pencil and paper. Three have recently been found, and the rest of this chapter is their story. Each strips the problem down to a different bone. The *ring* (Vazquez, 2026e) removes growth, randomness, and heterogeneity all at once, leaving nothing but local wiring. The *diamond lattice* (Vazquez, 2026d) — the same lattice whose shortest paths we shall count in Chapter 9 — lets us watch, exactly, why the evidence for communities accumulates at all. The *pseudofractal web* (Vazquez, 2026c) asks whether the communities we find are real or an illusion cast by the hubs.

A warning before we start: these three networks are not *grown* at all. They are fixed, deterministic constructions, and no detection algorithm is ever run on them. What they isolate is locality itself, stripped of every other ingredient, and what they answer is not "can an algorithm find the communities?" but "at what size does the split become the better description?" That is the question the Ramsey number was always asking, and here we can answer it exactly.

The trick that makes all three solvable is to use the block model not as an algorithm but as a *formula*. Given a network and a candidate split, the probability of the data under each hypothesis can be integrated in closed form, and the two compared.

**The mathematics behind it: the block model as a formula** *(this box can be skipped)*

Suppose the nodes are divided into blocks, and that the chance of a link between two nodes depends only on which blocks they are in: $\theta_1$ within block 1, $\theta_2$ within block 2, $\theta_{12}$ between. We do not know these probabilities, so we average over them, giving each a $\mathrm{Beta}(\alpha,\alpha)$ prior, and likewise average over the label prior $\pi$ that decides how nodes are apportioned:

$$P = \frac{1}{Z}\int \prod_{i\in\{1,2\}} \theta_i^{E_i}(1-\theta_i)^{\binom{n_i}{2}-E_i} \times \theta_{12}^{E_{12}}(1-\theta_{12})^{n_1 n_2 - E_{12}} \times \pi^{n_1}(1-\pi)^{n-n_1}\, P(\theta)P(\pi)\, d\theta\, d\pi. \tag{6.3}$$

Here $n_i$ is the size of block $i$, $E_i$ the number of links inside it, and $E_{12}$ the number crossing between. Every integral is of the same standard shape,

$$\int_0^1 x^{E+\alpha-1}(1-x)^{N-E+\alpha-1}\, dx = \mathrm{B}(E{+}\alpha,\, N{-}E{+}\alpha), \tag{6.4}$$

where B is the Beta function. So each hypothesis collapses to a product of Beta functions, and their ratio $R$ — the *evidence ratio* — can be evaluated exactly. All we ever need is a handful of link counts.

Writing $R$ for the ratio of the evidence for the split to that for no split, the posterior weight of the partition is

$$P(\text{split}) = \frac{R}{1+R} = \frac{1}{1+e^{-\log R}}, \tag{6.5}$$

so $\log R > 0$ means the split is the better description, and the Ramsey number is the smallest size at which $P(\text{split})$ reaches the certainty $q$ we demand.

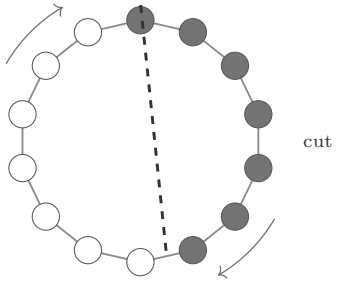



Figure 6.4: **Cutting the ring.** The block model splits the ring into two contiguous arcs (dark and white), preferring this to no split at all once the ring is large enough. But every node looks the same, so the cut (dashed) could sit between any pair of beads and score exactly the same: the model says the ring *must* be cut, without saying where. The two arcs are real communities in the way a magnet has a real direction — fixed in any one outcome, undetermined by the symmetry.

## 6.7 The ring wants to be broken

Begin with the least promising network imaginable. Place $n$ nodes on a circle and join each to its $c$ nearest neighbors on either side — the *circulant ring* $C_n(1, \ldots, c)$, the unrewired lattice that Watts and Strogatz started from. Every node is identical. Every node has the same degree $2c$, and the ring has $cn$ links. Nothing grows, nothing is random, and there is no group of nodes that belongs together more than any other. If any network has no communities, this one does not.

Ask the block model anyway. The candidate split is into two contiguous arcs (Figure 6.4), and the counts it needs are elementary.

**The mathematics behind it: the ring's link counts and its evidence ratio** *(this box can be skipped)*

Take an arc of $n_i$ consecutive nodes. A link of span $k$ joins nodes $k$ apart, and $n_i - k$ such links fit inside the arc, so summing over the

spans $k = 1, \ldots, c$,

$$E_i = \sum_{k=1}^{c} (n_i - k) = c\, n_i - \frac{c(c+1)}{2}, \tag{6.6}$$

and the pairs inside the arc that are *not* linked number $\binom{n_i}{2} - E_i = \binom{n_i - c}{2}$. Only links near the two cut points cross between the arcs, and counting them by span gives

$$E_{12} = 2 \sum_{k=1}^{c} k = c(c+1), \tag{6.7}$$

independent of $n$. As a check, $E_1 + E_2 + E_{12} = cn$. For the balanced split $n_1 = n_2 = m \equiv n/2$; the unpartitioned ring has all $cn$ links among $\binom{n}{2}$ pairs. Feeding these into Eq. (6.3) and using Eq. (6.4) on every integral,

$$\begin{aligned} R = \Big[ & \mathrm{B}\big(cm - \tfrac{c(c+1)}{2} + \alpha,\ \tbinom{m-c}{2} + \alpha\big)^2 \\ & \times \mathrm{B}\big(c(c+1) + \alpha,\ m^2 - c(c+1) + \alpha\big) \\ & \times \mathrm{B}(m + \alpha,\ m + \alpha) \Big] \\ \Big/ \Big[ & \mathrm{B}(\alpha, \alpha)^2\, \mathrm{B}\big(cn + \alpha,\ \tbinom{n}{2} - cn + \alpha\big) \\ & \times \mathrm{B}(\alpha,\ n + \alpha) \Big]. \end{aligned} \tag{6.8}$$

No approximation has been made: this is exact for every $n$, $c$ and $\alpha$.

Evaluating Eq. (6.8) gives an answer that depends, with startling sharpness, on the range $c$ (Figure 6.5a). The plain cycle, $c = 1$, is *never* split: its evidence ratio decays as a power of the size,

$$\log R \sim A - (2\alpha + 3) \log n \longrightarrow -\infty, \tag{6.9}$$

so that $P(\text{split}) \sim n^{-(2\alpha+3)}$ vanishes and $r_\kappa = \infty$. But the next-nearest-neighbor ring, $c = 2$, is split as soon as it exceeds about thirty-five nodes — $r_\kappa \simeq 34$ at 95% certainty — and beyond that the evidence piles up in proportion to the size, $\log R \sim (\ln 2)\, n$. A featureless ring of beads, given one extra reach, acquires communities.

Why should one extra neighbor make such a difference? The published answer is that a plain cycle offers no density contrast for

the block model to exploit. That cannot be right: an arc of a cycle is twice as dense as the whole cycle, and so is an arc of any other ring — the contrast is a factor of two for *every* $c$. The real reason is a cancellation, and it is worth seeing because it generalizes.

**The mathematics behind it: why the ring breaks, and when** *(this box can be skipped)*

Two quantities compete. Cutting the ring into two arcs of $n/2$ makes each arc look twice as dense as the whole ring did: the arcs hold nearly all $cn$ links but only about half the node pairs. Each link therefore gains $\ln 2$ of evidence, for a total *gain* of $cn \ln 2$. Against this stands the price of naming the split — of saying *which* nodes go in which block. That price is the label term of Eq. (6.8), and at $\alpha = 1$ it is not merely of order $n \ln 2$ but exactly a binomial coefficient. With $n = 2m$,

$$\frac{\mathrm{B}(m+1, m+1)}{\mathrm{B}(1, n+1)} = \frac{(m!)^2}{(2m+1)!}\,(n+1) = \frac{(m!)^2}{n!} = \binom{n}{n/2}^{-1}, \qquad (6.10)$$

so the label term contributes

$$-\log \binom{n}{n/2} \simeq -\,n \ln 2, \qquad (6.11)$$

the entropy of labeling $n$ nodes with two labels. Subtracting the price from the gain,

$$\log R \;\simeq\; \big(cn - n\big) \ln 2 \;=\; (c-1)\, n \ln 2. \qquad (6.12)$$

Since $cn$ is the number of links $m$, this reads $\log R \simeq (m-n)\ln 2$: the ring is split exactly when its links outnumber its nodes.

Equation (6.12) goes beyond what the ring paper states — it reports only the $c = 2$ case — but it is easily checked against the exact formula for $c = 1, \ldots, 4$, and it passes (Figure 6.5b). It also dissolves the mystery of the cycle. The cycle is not *reluctant* to break; it is exactly *balanced*. A cycle has precisely as many links as nodes, so gain and price cancel to the last term, and the fate of the split is left to the smaller corrections of Eq. (6.9), which happen to be negative. Move to $c = 2$ and the cancellation is broken by a

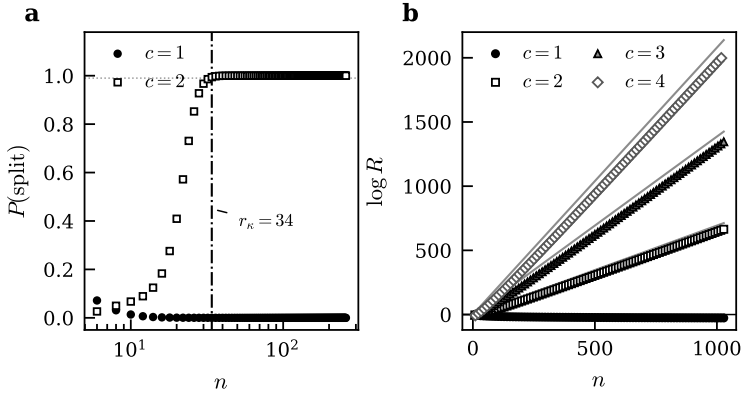



Figure 6.5: **The ring wants to be broken.** (a) The probability that a block model prefers two arcs to no split. The plain cycle ($c = 1$) is never split; the next-nearest-neighbor ring ($c = 2$) is split beyond $r_\kappa \simeq 34$ nodes (dash-dotted line; dotted line marks 99% certainty). (b) The evidence for the split against the prediction $\log R \simeq (c-1)\, n \ln 2$ (lines), Eq. (6.12), for $c = 1, \ldots, 4$. The cycle lies exactly on zero: it is balanced, not reluctant.

whole factor of $n$. The celebrated contrast between the cycle and the ring is thus not a transition at all but a knife edge: $c = 1$ sits at the zero of a perfectly smooth family, and the evidence grows linearly in $c - 1$ thereafter.

And now the connection this book has been building toward. The quantity $m - n$ is, up to one, the number of *independent cycles* a connected network carries. A tree has none, and is never split. A single ring has exactly one, and sits exactly on the fence. A network with an extensive number of independent cycles is split with an evidence proportional to how many it has. The same short loops that Chapter 9 will show multiplying shortest paths are what carve a network into communities here — two faces, again, of the one local coin.

There remains something troubling about calling the two arcs communities, and it should be said plainly. The ring looks the same

from every node; rotate it by one bead and it is unchanged. So if cutting it at some point is favored, then cutting it at any *other* point is favored exactly as much: all $n$ rotations of the balanced split have identical evidence. The block model is not telling us where the communities are. It is telling us that the ring *must be cut somewhere*, while remaining perfectly silent about where — and it is the ring's own symmetry that keeps it silent. Physicists know this situation well. A magnet below its critical temperature must point somewhere, though nothing in its physics prefers north to south; the symmetry of the laws survives in the multiplicity of the outcomes, not in any one of them. The ring's communities are of exactly this kind: real, in that the split genuinely describes the network better; degenerate, in that no particular split is preferred. The ring does not have communities so much as it wants to be broken.

## 6.8 Why communities emerge at all

The ring shows that locality suffices. It does not explain why size should be the deciding variable — why every one of these networks has a threshold at all. For that we turn to the diamond lattice, which we shall meet again in Chapter 9: begin with a single link between two poles $A$ and $B$, and at each generation replace *every* link by $b$ parallel paths of $s$ links each. Take $b = s = 2$, the classic Migdal–Kadanoff cell (Migdal, 1975; Kadanoff, 1976). Generation $t$ has

$$m = (bs)^t = 4^t \text{ links}, \qquad n_t = \tfrac{1}{3}\big(2 \cdot 4^t + 4\big) \text{ nodes}, \tag{6.13}$$

and a node born at generation $k$ ends with degree $2 \cdot 2^{t-k}$, while the two poles are permanent hubs of degree $b^t = 2^t$. The lattice is strongly degree-heterogeneous, which is what will make the next section's question sharp.

The $b$ bundles hanging between the poles are the obvious candidate communities (Figure 6.6). Take block 1 to be one bundle together with the two poles, block 2 the other bundle. Because the bundles meet *only* at the poles, every crossing link joins a pole to a bundle-2 node, and the counts close in themselves.

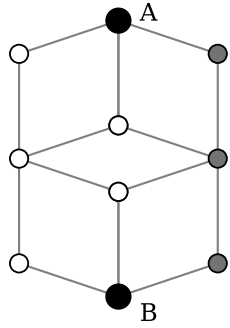



Figure 6.6: **The diamond's two communities.** The $b = s = 2$ diamond lattice at generation $t = 2$. Its two bundles — the left half (open circles) and the right half (gray) — are the two communities; they touch only at the poles $A$ and $B$ (black), so the only links crossing between them are the few at top and bottom. As the lattice grows, that seam becomes an ever fainter share of each bundle's interior, which is why the split sharpens without limit.

**The mathematics behind it: the counts, and the map that carries them** *(this box can be skipped)*

For the bundle cut of the $b = s = 2$ diamond,

$$\begin{aligned} e_{11} &= \tfrac{4^t}{2}, & e_{22} &= \tfrac{4^t}{2} - 2^t, \\ e_{12} &= 2^t, & \kappa_1 &= 4^t + 2^t, \\ \kappa_2 &= 4^t - 2^t, \end{aligned} \tag{6.14}$$

where $e_{rs}$ counts links between blocks $r$ and $s$ and $\kappa_r$ is the sum of degrees in block $r$. The seam is *subextensive*: $e_{12} = 2^t = \sqrt{m}$, so the fraction of links crossing the cut decays geometrically, $e_{12}/m = (1/s)^t \to 0$.

The point of the lattice is that these tallies renormalize *exactly*. Collect them in $\mathbf{v} = (e_{11}, e_{22}, e_{12}, \kappa_1, \kappa_2)^\top$; then $\mathbf{v}(t{+}1) = M\mathbf{v}(t)$

with

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & 0 & 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 4 & 2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & -2 & 4 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 2 & 0 & 4 \end{pmatrix}. \tag{6.15}$$

The entries read off the construction. A link inside either block is replaced by four links whose new nodes inherit its bundle label, so within-block links quadruple. A seam link joins a pole to a bundle-2 node; of its four children, the two at the pole stay seam links and the two at the far end are absorbed into block 2 — whence $e'_{12} = 2e_{12}$, with the displaced pair reappearing in $e'_{22}$. The spectrum is what matters:

$$\lambda_{\text{vol}} = bs, \qquad \lambda_{\text{seam}} = b. \tag{6.16}$$

Read backwards, $M^{-1}$ is precisely the Migdal–Kadanoff decimation that strips the youngest generation; read forwards, $M$ is the growth generator of the detection problem.

Two eigenvalues, and their ratio is the whole story:

$$\frac{\lambda_{\text{seam}}}{\lambda_{\text{vol}}} = \frac{1}{s}. \tag{6.17}$$

For $s \geq 2$ the seam is left behind by the bulk, so the boundary between the communities grows ever fainter relative to their interiors, and the split gets better and better with size. For $s = 1$ the two rates are equal, the seam keeps pace, and the lattice never separates — the diamond's exact counterpart of the plain cycle, and a pleasing echo of it. In a sentence: $b$ sets how many communities there are, and $s$ sets how sharply they are separated.

To weigh the evidence we need a null model that already knows the degrees — otherwise, as the next section will show, we would only be measuring the hubs. The degree-corrected block model (Karrer and Newman, 2011) supplies one.

**The mathematics behind it: the degree-corrected evidence**
*(this box can be skipped)*

Let each node carry a propensity $\theta_i = k_i/\sqrt{2m}$ and let the expected number of links between $i$ and $j$ be $\theta_i\theta_j\,\omega_{g_ig_j}$, where $g_i$ is the block of $i$. Setting every $\omega_{rs} = 1$ reproduces the configuration model exactly — a network with the same degrees and nothing else — so $\omega_{rs}$ measures departure from chance. The expected block-pair weights are

$$\Omega_{rr} = \frac{\kappa_r^2}{4m}, \qquad \Omega_{rs} = \frac{\kappa_r\kappa_s}{2m} \quad (r \neq s). \tag{6.18}$$

Giving each $\omega_{rs}$ a Gamma$(\alpha,\alpha)$ prior, of mean one and so centered on the configuration model, and integrating it out,

$$Z(e,\Omega) = \frac{\alpha^\alpha}{\Gamma(\alpha)}\int_0^\infty \omega^{e+\alpha-1}e^{-(\Omega+\alpha)\omega}\,d\omega = \frac{\alpha^\alpha}{\Gamma(\alpha)}\,\frac{\Gamma(e+\alpha)}{(\Omega+\alpha)^{e+\alpha}}. \tag{6.19}$$

The evidence ratio for the split against no split is then

$$R_{\mathrm{dc}} = \frac{Z(e_{11},\Omega_{11})\,Z(e_{22},\Omega_{22})\,Z(e_{12},\Omega_{12})}{Z(m,\,m)}. \tag{6.20}$$

For large counts, Stirling turns this into something recognizable,

$$\log R_{\mathrm{dc}} \simeq \sum_{r\le s} e_{rs}\,\ln\frac{e_{rs}}{\Omega_{rs}}, \tag{6.21}$$

the surprise — in the information-theorist's sense — of finding the links where they are rather than where the degrees alone would have put them. This is the Bayesian, degree-corrected counterpart of modularity.

Everything now follows from two ratios. Write $u_{\mathrm{in}} = e_{rr}/\Omega_{rr}$ for the density inside a block relative to chance, and $u_\times = e_{12}/\Omega_{12}$ for the seam. Inserting Eq. (6.14) into Eq. (6.18) gives them exactly, as rational functions of $x = 2^t$:

$$u_{\mathrm{in}} = \frac{2x^2}{(x\pm1)^2}, \qquad u_\times = \frac{2x}{x^2-1}. \tag{6.22}$$

**The mathematics behind it: the evidence per link** *(this box can be skipped)*

Under the flow, Eq. (6.22) converges to the *community fixed point* (Figure 6.7b),

$$(u_{\text{in}}, u_{\times}) \longrightarrow (K, 0), \tag{6.23}$$

with $K = b$ the number of communities, the seam density decaying as $(\lambda_{\text{seam}}/\lambda_{\text{vol}})^t = (1/s)^t$. At the fixed point each within-block term of Eq. (6.21) contributes $\frac{m}{2} \ln K$ and the cross term is subleading, so the evidence density converges to a pure number:

$$\frac{\log R_{\text{dc}}}{m} \longrightarrow \ln K. \tag{6.24}$$

The reason is pure counting, and owes nothing to the diamond. If $K$ equal, well-separated communities hold all the links, each holds $e_{rr} = m/K$ of them, while the configuration model — knowing only the degrees — expects $\Omega_{rr} = m/K^2$. The ratio is $K$ identically, and every link contributes exactly $\ln K$: the entropy of resolving which of $K$ communities it belongs to. This is the same $\ln 2$ per link that broke the ring.

Equation (6.24) explains the emergence of communities in one line, and it is the answer this chapter has been missing. The evidence for a partition is *extensive*: it grows in proportion to the number of links, each one contributing its $\ln K$. The price of positing the partition — the extra block affinities a model must fit — grows only like the *logarithm* of the size. A quantity growing like $m \ln K$ must eventually overtake one growing like $\ln m$, and once it does it never looks back. Emergence is not a delicate phenomenon requiring a special mechanism; it is arithmetic. All that remains to ask is *where* the crossing happens:

$$r_\kappa(q) = n_t\big|_{t_\star}, \qquad t_\star = \min\left\{t : \log R_{\text{dc}}(t) \geq \ln \tfrac{q}{1-q}\right\}, \tag{6.25}$$

the threshold $\ln[q/(1-q)]$ being set by the certainty $q$ we demand (Figure 6.7a). With $\log R_{\text{dc}} \simeq (\ln K)(bs)^t$ from Eq. (6.24), the crossing generation is

$$t_\star \simeq \left\lceil \log_{bs} \frac{\ln[q/(1-q)]}{\ln K} \right\rceil. \tag{6.26}$$

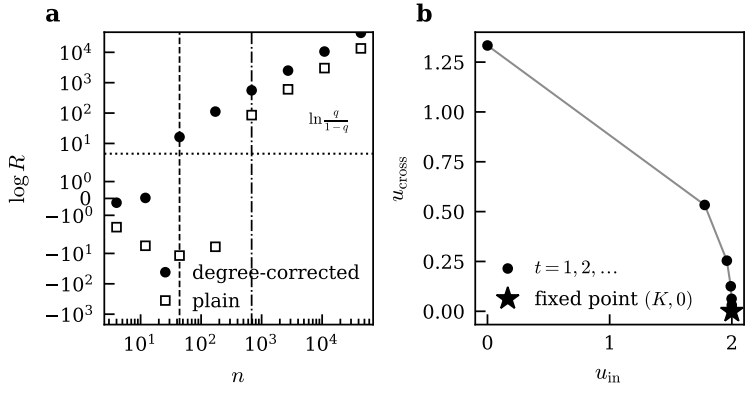



Figure 6.7: **The Ramsey number as a crossing.** (a) Evidence for the split on the diamond lattice against size. $r_\kappa$ is simply where the curve clears the threshold $\ln[q/(1-q)]$ (dotted, $q = 0.99$): at $n = 44$ for a degree-corrected block model (dashed line) but only at $n = 684$ for a plain one (dash-dotted). (b) The densities of Eq. (6.22) flow to the community fixed point $(K, 0)$: the interiors settle at $K = 2$ times chance, the seam fades to nothing.

This is the precise sense in which the Ramsey number is a renormalization-group crossing: it is the generation at which a running, extensive evidence — driven by the volume eigenvalue, once the flow has turned onto the community fixed point — first clears a fixed detection threshold.

The whole $(b, s)$ family can be done at once, and the result is the closest thing this book has to a formula for emergence.

**The mathematics behind it: the Ramsey number in closed form** *(this box can be skipped)*

The key structural fact is a lemma: for $s \geq 2$, at every generation each link either lies inside a single bundle or joins a pole to a bundle node; no link ever joins two distinct bundles. (Induction on the replacement: a link inside a bundle spawns links inside that bundle,

and a pole-to-bundle link spawns pole-to-bundle links and bundle-interior links.) So write $c_t$ for the number of pole-to-bundle links of one bundle and $i_t$ for its interior links. Replacement gives the triangular recursion

$$c_{t+1} = b\,c_t, \qquad i_{t+1} = bs\,i_t + b(s-1)\,c_t, \tag{6.27}$$

whose spectrum can be read straight off the diagonal — $\lambda_{\mathrm{vol}} = bs$ and $\lambda_{\mathrm{seam}} = b$, now proved for all $(b, s)$, not just the symmetric cell where the two roles cannot be told apart. With $c_1 = 2$, $i_1 = s-2$,

$$c_t = 2\,b^{\,t-1}, \qquad i_t = b^{\,t-1}\big(s^t - 2\big). \tag{6.28}$$

The block statistics follow: $e_{00} = i_t + c_t = b^{\,t-1}s^t$ for the pole block, $e_{rr} = i_t$ and $e_{0r} = c_t$ for each bundle $r \geq 1$, and $e_{rs} = 0$ for distinct bundles. The degree sums are $\kappa_r = 2b^{\,t-1}(s^t{-}1)$ and $\kappa_0 = 2b^{\,t-1}(s^t{-}1{+}b)$, and since each replaced link adds $b(s{-}1)$ nodes,

$$n_t = 2 + \frac{b(s{-}1)\big[(bs)^t - 1\big]}{bs - 1}. \tag{6.29}$$

The densities, with $x = s^t$, are again rational and again flow to $(b, 0)$:

$$\frac{e_{00}}{\Omega_{00}} = \frac{b\,x^2}{(x{+}b{-}1)^2}, \quad \frac{e_{rr}}{\Omega_{rr}} = \frac{b\,x(x{-}2)}{(x{-}1)^2}, \quad \frac{e_{0r}}{\Omega_{0r}} \to \frac{b}{s^t}. \tag{6.30}$$

The $\ln b$ contributions sum to $m \ln b$ *exactly*, and the only deficit is the seam's — the price of the $b^t$ crossing links still present:

$$\log R_{\mathrm{dc}} = m \ln b \,\big[1 - \delta_t\big], \qquad \delta_t = \frac{2(b{-}1)}{b \ln b}\,\frac{t \ln s + 1}{s^t}. \tag{6.31}$$

Setting this equal to the threshold and inverting Eq. (6.29),

$$\begin{aligned} r_\kappa(b, s; q) &= 2 + \frac{b(s{-}1)}{bs - 1}\Big[(bs)^{t_\star} - 1\Big], \\ t_\star &= \left\lceil \log_{bs}\left( \ln \tfrac{q}{1-q} \Big/ \ln b \right) \right\rceil. \end{aligned} \tag{6.32}$$

Equation (6.32) deserves a moment. The Ramsey community number, which three sections ago was a number we could only obtain by simulating thousands of networks, is here a formula. And look at what survives in it: $b$, through the entropy accumulated per link,

and $s$, through the volume growth. The degrees drop out. The priors drop out. The details of the lattice drop out. Emergence, it turns out, depends on almost nothing about the network except how fast its communities grow and how fast their boundary does.

## 6.9 Communities, or just degrees?

One doubt remains, and it is the sharpest of all. Every network in this book is hub-dominated. A block model handed a scale-free network can improve its fit simply by putting the hubs in one group and the rest in another — not because there is any community structure, but because there is a degree distribution to absorb. How do we know that what we have been calling communities is not just the hubs in disguise?

The pseudofractal web of Dorogovtsev et al. (2002) settles it. Its rule is as local as they come: start from a triangle, and at every generation let each existing link spawn a new node joined to both of its ends, keeping all the old links (Figure 6.8). What grows is deterministic, and elementary bookkeeping gives

$$n_t = \tfrac{3}{2}\big(3^t + 1\big), \qquad E_t = 3^{\,t+1}, \tag{6.33}$$

so the mean degree tends to four. A node born at generation $\tau$ ends with degree $2^{\,t-\tau+1}$, and counting nodes by birth generation gives a power-law degree distribution, $p(k) \sim k^{-\gamma}$ with

$$\gamma = 1 + \frac{\ln 3}{\ln 2} \simeq 2.585, \tag{6.34}$$

squarely in the scale-free range of real networks. Three seed hubs of degree $2^{t+1}$ tower over everything. This web has exactly the degree heterogeneity that makes the doubt bite.

It also has two rival splits with completely different characters. The *branch* cut follows the recursive construction, separating one branch of the web from the others. The *hub–leaf* cut ignores the construction entirely and simply puts the high-degree nodes on one side.

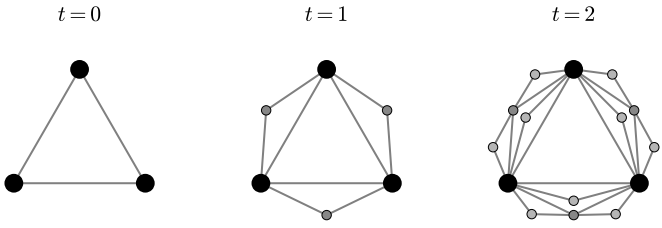



Figure 6.8: **Building the pseudofractal web.** The deterministic rule, shown for the first three generations. Start from a triangle ($t = 0$); at each step, every existing link gives birth to a new node joined to both its ends, and the old links are kept. The three corners of the original triangle (black) never stop gaining neighbors and become the towering hubs; each later node is fainter the later it was born.

**The mathematics behind it: the branch cut, and what a degree-blind model makes of it** *(this box can be skipped)*

Label the three seed links $0, 1, 2$; every new node and both its links inherit the label of the link that spawned it, so each non-seed node sits in exactly one branch. Take block 1 to be one branch plus the three seed hubs, block 2 the other two branches. The counts are exact:

$$n_1 = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(3^t + 5\big), \qquad n_2 = 3^t - 1,$$
$$E_1 = 3^t + 2, \qquad E_2 = 2 \cdot 3^t + 2 - 2^{\,t+2}, \tag{6.35}$$
$$E_{12} = 2^{\,t+2} - 4,$$

with $n_1 + n_2 = n_t$ and $E_1 + E_2 + E_{12} = E_t$. The seam is thin: $E_{12}$ grows only as $2^t = n^{\ln 2/\ln 3} \simeq n^{0.631}$, so the fraction of crossing links $E_{12}/E_t \sim (2/3)^t \to 0$ — the structural fact that drives everything. Feeding Eq. (6.35) into the plain evidence Eq. (6.3) and applying Stirling gives a linear growth,

$$\log R \sim \Big(\ln 3 - \tfrac{2}{3}\ln 2\Big)\, n \approx 0.6365\, n, \tag{6.36}$$

independent of the prior.

Now correct for the degrees. The block degree sums of the branch cut are

$$\kappa_1 = 2 \cdot 3^t + 2^{\,t+2}, \qquad \kappa_2 = 4 \cdot 3^t - 2^{\,t+2}, \tag{6.37}$$

with $\kappa_1 + \kappa_2 = 2E_t$, and inserting these into Eq. (6.18) gives densities that *exceed* the configuration model's expectation inside the blocks while the crossing density vanishes:

$$\frac{E_1}{\Omega_{11}} \to 3, \qquad \frac{E_2}{\Omega_{22}} \to \tfrac{3}{2}, \qquad \frac{E_{12}}{\Omega_{12}} \sim \left(\tfrac{2}{3}\right)^t \to 0. \tag{6.38}$$

The branch cut therefore survives the correction, and Eq. (6.21) gives its slope:

$$\log R_{\mathrm{dc}} \sim \left(2\ln 3 - \tfrac{4}{3}\ln 2\right) n \approx 1.2730\, n, \tag{6.39}$$

exactly *twice* the plain slope of Eq. (6.36). Correcting for the degrees does not weaken the case for these communities. It doubles it.

The result is a reversal, and it is damning for the naive method. The plain block model prefers the hub–leaf cut — it is chasing the degree gradient, exactly as feared. Correct for degrees and the hub–leaf cut collapses while the branch cut strengthens: the recursive communities are real, and they are what a degree-blind detector was missing while it stared at the hubs. The two verdicts on *when* disagree just as violently (Figure 6.9). The plain model reports no communities until $n = 1095$; the corrected model has been sure of them since $n = 42$. Same network, same partition, same question — and a twenty-five-fold disagreement about the answer. The direction of that disagreement is the counterintuitive part: the degree gradient, far from manufacturing the split, *delays* the detector that cannot see past it.

The moral is not that one number is right and the other wrong. It is that $r_\kappa$ was never a property of the network alone. It is a property of the network together with the question we ask of it, and the warning lodged when we defined it now has to be paid. The exactly solvable cases are valuable precisely because they let us see this: a quantity that looked like a fact about the web turns out to depend, by a factor of twenty-five, on which null model we hold it against. That does not dissolve the chapter's thesis — under *either* rule the local construction has a finite $r_\kappa$, while a network with no

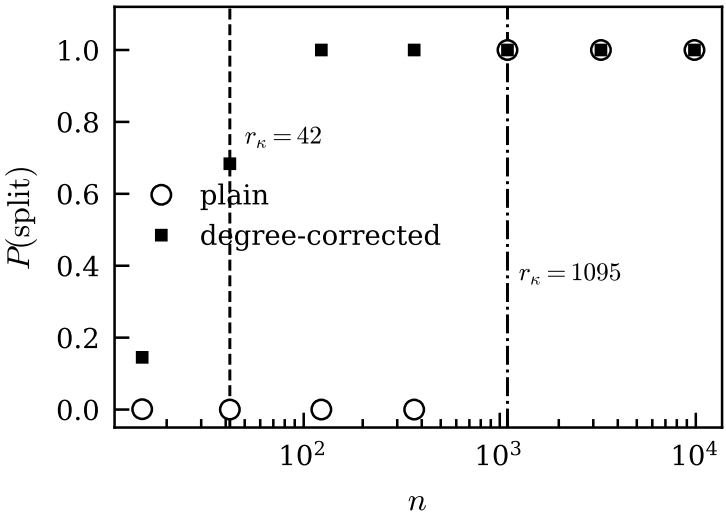



Figure 6.9: **Communities, or just degrees?** The pseudofractal web under a plain block model (open circles) and one corrected for the degree sequence (filled squares). The corrected model is certain of the recursive communities from $n = 42$; the plain one denies them until $n = 1095$. The degree gradient, far from manufacturing the split, *delays* the detector that cannot see past it.

local structure has none — but it does mean that a bare Ramsey number, quoted without its detection rule, says less than it appears to.

## 6.10 How many communities?

We have been asking whether a network splits in two. That was a convenience, and it is time to drop it. A self-similar network has structure at every scale, so why stop at the first cut?

Take the pseudofractal web again, and cut it three ways instead of two, one block per branch. The symmetry now works for us rather

than against us, and the counts are cleaner than the branch cut's:

$$n_r = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(3^t + 1\big), \quad \kappa_r = 2 \cdot 3^t, \quad e_{rr} = 3^t - 2^t, \quad e_{rs} = 2^t. \tag{6.40}$$

The densities behave exactly as the diamond's fixed point promised, with $K = 3$:

$$\frac{e_{rr}}{\Omega_{rr}} = 3\big(1 - (2/3)^t\big) \to 3, \qquad \frac{e_{rs}}{\Omega_{rs}} = \tfrac{3}{2}(2/3)^t \to 0, \tag{6.41}$$

and the evidence density is $\ln 3$ per link, just as Eq. (6.24) requires of three well-separated communities:

$$\log R^{(3)}_{\rm dc} \sim 2 \ln 3 \, n \approx 2.197 \, n. \tag{6.42}$$

This beats the two-block cut of Eq. (6.39) by exactly $\frac{4}{3} \ln 2 \, n$ — the evidence the branch cut forfeited by lumping two communities together. Three blocks describe the web better than two. And having seen that, there is no reason to stop: removing the links of generation $d$ leaves $3^{d+1}$ statistically identical sub-webs, and each level of refinement adds another $\simeq 2 \ln 3 \, n$ to the evidence.

What stops it? The seams do. Every cut has to pay for the links it severs, and the deeper the cut the more of them there are. On the diamond the competition can be written down exactly. A depth-$d$ cut severs $c(d) = 2^{t+d}$ links, leaving a fraction $e_{\rm in}/m = 1 - 2^{d-t}$ inside blocks — each level doubling the interface, which is the seam eigenvalue $\lambda_{\rm seam} = b = 2$ acting once per level. Balancing that against the reward for splitting the degree sum evenly gives a modularity

$$Q(d) = \frac{e_{\rm in}}{m} - \gamma \frac{\sum_c \kappa_c^2}{(2m)^2} = 1 - 2^{\,d-t} - \gamma \, 2^{-d} + O(2^{-t}), \tag{6.43}$$

where $\gamma$ is the resolution at which we choose to look. Maximizing over the depth gives $2^{2d} = \gamma 2^t$, that is

$$d_\star = \tfrac{1}{2}\big(t + \log_2 \gamma\big), \qquad q_{\rm opt} = 2^{d_\star} = \sqrt{\gamma}\; 2^{t/2} \sim \sqrt{\gamma \, n}. \tag{6.44}$$

The number of communities that best describes the network is not two, and is not any fixed number: it *grows with the network*, as its square root. The web does the same, with $K_{\rm opt} = 3^{\lfloor t/2 \rfloor} \sim \sqrt{n}$.

The optimum sits at the geometric midpoint of the network's own hierarchy — about $\sqrt{n}$ communities of about $\sqrt{n}$ nodes each — and the two-block cut we labored over is merely the top of that tree. It is worth noting that $\sqrt{n}$ is the same scale that Chapter 9 will find in the exponent of the shortest path multiplicity on this very lattice; both are the seam scale $b^t$ in disguise.

## 6.11 Communities as a state of matter

There is one more thing the diamond will give us, and it is the strangest. So far communities have been an inference: the partition a statistician prefers. But the quantity being optimized is a Hamiltonian, and a Hamiltonian is physics. Written in the form of Reichardt and Bornholdt (2004),

$$\mathcal{H} = -\sum_{i \neq j} \left( A_{ij} - \gamma\, p_{ij} \right) \delta(\sigma_i, \sigma_j), \qquad p_{ij} = \frac{\kappa_i \kappa_j}{2m}, \tag{6.45}$$

where $\sigma_i$ labels the community of node $i$ and $A_{ij}$ is the adjacency matrix, the ground state is the community partition, and at $\gamma = 1$ this is modularity itself. For two communities the labels are Ising spins, and the Hamiltonian rearranges into something a physicist recognizes at sight:

$$\mathcal{H} = -\sum_{\langle ij \rangle} \sigma_i \sigma_j + \frac{\gamma}{4m} \Big[ M_\kappa^2 - \sum_i \kappa_i^2 \Big], \qquad M_\kappa = \sum_i \kappa_i \sigma_i. \tag{6.46}$$

A ferromagnet — neighbors want to agree, which is cohesion — plus an infinite-range, degree-weighted penalty that punishes the whole network for agreeing too much, which is what forces a split.

Because the penalty couples the spins only through the single collective variable $M_\kappa$, the model can be solved exactly on the diamond by decimation, and the answer is a genuine phase. Take the correlation between the two poles, $-\langle \sigma_A \sigma_B \rangle$, as the order parameter. Below the ferromagnetic critical temperature

$$\frac{k_B T_c}{J} = 1.641, \tag{6.47}$$

the two poles lock into *opposite* communities for any resolution $\gamma > 0$, however small — the degree-weighted penalty bites hardest on the

two highest-degree nodes — and the order survives as $n \to \infty$. The resolution selects *which* partition orders, not *whether* it does. The contrast with a plain ferromagnet is the whole point: an ordinary Ising model on the same lattice has no such phase, its ground state being the trivial single community. It is the community penalty that changes the ground state into a partition.

Push to the growing hierarchy of the last section and the picture completes. With $q = 2^d$ colors the model becomes a Potts model, whose series and parallel decimations are

$$\begin{aligned} A_{\text{ser}} &= A_1 A_2 + (q{-}1) B_1 B_2, \\ B_{\text{ser}} &= A_1 B_2 + B_1 A_2 + (q{-}2) B_1 B_2, \\ A_{\text{par}} &= A_1 A_2, \qquad B_{\text{par}} = B_1 B_2, \end{aligned} \tag{6.48}$$

with $A$ the weight for two ends in the same community and $B$ for different ones. Solving these, every $q > 2$ orders through a *first-order* transition — the partition snaps into place rather than fading in, as is known for Potts models on hierarchical lattices (Griffiths and Kaufman, 1982) — at a temperature that falls only logarithmically with the number of communities,

$$\frac{k_B T_c(q)}{J} \sim \frac{1}{c \ln q}, \qquad c \approx 0.70. \tag{6.49}$$

So the hierarchy orders level by level, coarsest first, each finer level freezing at a lower temperature; and since $q_{\text{opt}} \sim \sqrt{n}$, the finest level still orders at $k_B T_c / J \sim 1/\ln n$. Every thermodynamically stable level of the hierarchy survives as the network grows.

The conclusion is worth stating baldly. On this lattice the community structure is not merely detectable, in the sense that a statistician would infer it. It is *ordered*, in the sense that a physicist would recognize: a phase of matter, with a critical temperature, an order parameter, and a cascade of transitions building the hierarchy from the top down. Communities, born of nothing but local wiring, turn out to be a state that a network can be in.

## 6.12 How many communities do real networks have?

Everything so far has been theory: models grown by hand, and lattices solved with pencil and paper. It is time to ask the real world. The question of Section 6.10 — *how many* communities a network has, and how that number grows — was answered there only for self-similar constructions, where the best description settled on about $\sqrt{n}$ communities of $\sqrt{n}$ nodes each. Does anything so clean survive contact with the messy networks of the world? Following Vazquez (2026a), we can now say that it does, and better than the models led us to expect.

Two idealized limits fix the range of possibilities (Figure 6.10). At one end is a network built of dense modules, like Watts's *caveman* graph — a ring of tight cliques, each clique so much denser inside than out that it is unmistakably its own community (Watts, 1999). There the number of communities $B$ simply counts the cliques, so it grows in direct proportion to size, $B \propto n$: the *modular* limit, exponent one. At the other end are the self-similar networks of Section 6.10, whose community count grows only as the square root, $B \propto \sqrt{n}$: the *fractal* limit, exponent one half. Writing $B \propto n^{\beta}$, every network must fall somewhere in $\frac{1}{2} \leq \beta \leq 1$. Where is an empirical question, and until it is measured we do not know whether real networks resemble stacks of modules, self-similar fractals, or neither.

So measure it. Take close to a hundred undirected networks from the Netzschleuder repository (Peixoto, 2020), chosen only to span the widest possible range of sizes — from Zachary's thirty-four-member karate club to networks of more than two million nodes — and drawn from social, biological, infrastructural and collaboration settings with nothing else in common. Count the communities of each with the degree-corrected block model, letting the method infer the number of groups from the data rather than fixing it in advance (Peixoto, 2013; Karrer and Newman, 2011). The result is a clean straight line on logarithmic axes, across more than four decades of size (Figure 6.11):

$$B \propto n^{\beta}, \qquad \beta \approx 0.61, \tag{6.50}$$

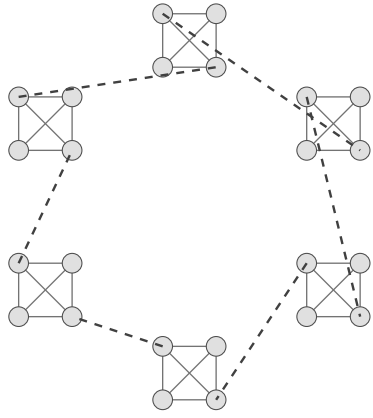


Figure 6.10: **The modular limit: the caveman graph.** A ring of tight cliques (here six cliques of four nodes), each joined to its neighbors by a single bridge (dashed). Each clique is so much denser inside than out that it is unmistakably one community, so the number of communities simply counts the cliques and grows in proportion to size, $B \propto n$ ($\beta = 1$). The self-similar networks of Section 6.10 sit at the opposite limit, $\beta = \frac{1}{2}$; real networks fall between.

with a bootstrap 95% confidence interval, $[0.55, 0.67]$, that lies wholly above one half and excludes it. The karate club resolves into a single group, a football schedule into ten, the Internet into several dozen, the largest social and collaboration networks into hundreds — and one exponent threads them all, although they share no common origin, rule, or scale. Real networks are *super-fractal*: they carry more resolvable community structure than self-similar models predict, yet they fall far short of the modular extreme.

The scatter about the line is not noise but signal: it tracks how dense the network is. At a fixed number of nodes, a denser web carries more information and supports a finer division, so dense networks (the darker points in Figure 6.11) sit above the line and sparse ones below, a trend that is statistically firm across the sample. The extreme cases are the geographic networks — roads, power grids, transport — which are the sparsest of all and lie furthest below; their position is explained by their low density, not by their spatial

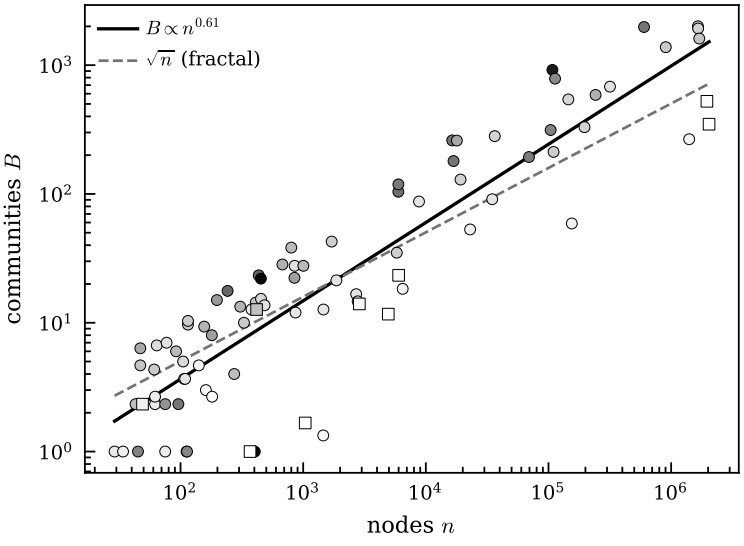



Figure 6.11: **The number of communities grows as a power law of size.** Number of communities $B$ against number of nodes $n$ for close to a hundred real networks (log–log), each counted with the degree-corrected block model. The solid line is the fitted power law $B \propto n^{0.61}$; the dashed line is the fractal $\sqrt{n}$. Denser networks (darker fill) sit above the line, sparse ones below; geographic, spatially embedded networks (squares) are the sparsest and fall furthest below. The exponent lies well above the fractal one half.

embedding as such.

A cross-section of unrelated networks is one kind of evidence; following a *single* system as it grows, so that the same mechanism lays down every point, is a sharper one. Do this for the three systems of the previous chapter — the very networks whose shortest paths we counted there — and each again traces a power law (Figure 6.12): the Internet at the autonomous-system level, $\beta \approx 0.62$; the protein interactomes across organisms, $\approx 0.55$; and the condensed-matter co-authorship network, accumulated year by year to nearly four

hundred thousand authors, $\approx 0.71$. Grown by its own rules, each system multiplies its communities as a power law of size, with an exponent again between one half and two thirds.

And the book's own local rules do the same. Grow the triadic-closure and duplication–split models — the social and biological rules of Chapters 3 and 4 — to a hundred thousand nodes and count their communities exactly as for the data, and both yield clean power laws with super-fractal exponents, $\beta \approx 0.56$ and 0.60, their confidence intervals again above one half (Figure 6.13). The super-fractal exponent is thus not a peculiarity of the data but a consequence of local growth: the same rules that make communities emerge at all, earlier in this chapter, also fix how their number multiplies with size, and fix it in the range the real networks occupy.

One qualification has to be entered here, and it is taken up properly in Chapter 7. The counts above come from a flat block model, whose own resolution cannot exceed $\sqrt{n}$ groups however many are present. That ceiling has the same functional form as the fractal limit the exponent is being compared against, so the instrument cannot report a value far above one half even in principle. Refitting these two rules with a model whose resolution is not so bounded raises $\beta$ from 0.50 and 0.60 to about 0.95 on the very same networks, and refitting the real networks of Figure 6.11 the same way raises the exponent of Eq. (6.50) from 0.63 to 0.80, with an interval lying wholly above two thirds. What survives that is the inequality $\beta > \frac{1}{2}$, which only strengthens; what does not survive unqualified is the particular value and the picture of a balance struck midway between fractal and modular.

The reading of Eq. (6.50) is simple and worth stating plainly. The natural number of parts into which a network divides is not fixed but grows with the network, as $n^{\beta}$, while the typical community swells as $n^{1-\beta}$. With $\frac{1}{2} < \beta < \frac{2}{3}$ both grow without bound, yet the communities remain a vanishing fraction of the whole: one can neither summarize an arbitrarily large network with a fixed handful of groups, nor shatter it into ever more without limit. The exponent sets the balance — and that it sits reliably above one half, across systems that share nothing else, is the finding. The number of communities is a stable, measurable property of how a network is organized, and network growth by local rules is what herds a system's

components into that many clusters.

## 6.13 Summary

Community structure, long blamed on built-in differences between nodes, is instead something that *emerges* from growing a network by local rules, even when every node is identical. Made precise through the Ramsey community number $r_\kappa$ — the size beyond which communities are all but certain — the statement is clean: the local rules of earlier chapters (search and duplication–split) have a finite $r_\kappa$, while their degree-preserving shuffles, and the non-local Barabási–Albert model, have none. Triangles are not required (duplication–split makes none and still segregates), but locality is: communities come soonest for rules that close short cycles between nearby nodes, and disappear once links may span the whole network.

Three networks simple enough to solve exactly turn all of that from a measurement into a theory. A featureless ring of beads, with no growth and no randomness whatever, is already split in two once each bead reaches beyond its nearest neighbor. The evidence for the split is $\log R \simeq (m-n)\ln 2$: a gain of $\ln 2$ for every link, against a price of $n \ln 2$ for saying which node goes where. So a network is broken into communities precisely when it carries more links than nodes — which is to say, when it carries an extensive number of independent cycles. A tree never breaks; a single cycle sits exactly on the fence, which is why the plain cycle is not reluctant to split but exactly balanced. The same short loops that Chapter 9 shows multiplying shortest paths are what carve a network into communities.

The diamond lattice says why any threshold exists at all. Its block-model tallies renormalize exactly, under a map with just two eigenvalues — $bs$ for the bulk of a community, $b$ for the seam between them — whose ratio $1/s$ decides everything: for $s \geq 2$ the seam is left behind and the communities sharpen without limit, while for $s = 1$ it keeps pace and the lattice never separates, the exact counterpart of the plain cycle. The densities flow to a fixed point where each community is $K$ times denser than chance and the seam has vanished, so every link contributes $\ln K$ — the entropy of resolving which community it belongs to — and the evidence is *extensive* while the

price of positing a partition grows only *logarithmically*. A quantity growing like $m \ln K$ must overtake one growing like $\ln m$. Emergence is not delicate; it is arithmetic, and $r_\kappa$ merely records where the crossing falls — now a closed formula in which the degrees, the priors, and the lattice all drop out, leaving only how fast the communities grow and how fast their boundary does.

The pseudofractal web supplies the caution and the reassurance together. Correct for the degree sequence — score the split against a null that already knows every node's degree — and the same web's Ramsey number moves from 1095 to 42, while the preferred cut flips from the hubs to the branches. The communities are real: they not only survive the correction but double their evidence under it, and the degree gradient turns out to *delay* a degree-blind detector rather than fool it. But $r_\kappa$ belongs to the network and the question together, never to the network alone.

Two closing surprises from the solvable models. Asking how many communities, rather than whether there are two, gives an answer that grows with the network: about $\sqrt{n}$ communities of about $\sqrt{n}$ nodes, the geometric midpoint of the network's own hierarchy, and the same $\sqrt{n}$ that governs shortest path multiplicity on the same lattice. And the partition is not merely something a statistician infers: written as a Hamiltonian it has a critical temperature, an order parameter, and a cascade of first-order transitions that build the hierarchy level by level. Communities are a state the network is in.

Held up to the real world, the count grows faster than the fractal models predict. Across close to a hundred real networks, and within single systems followed as they grow, the number of communities is a power law of size, $B \propto n^\beta$ with $\beta$ above the self-similar $\sqrt{n}$ — measured here as between one half and two thirds, though Chapter 7 shows that the upper end of that range is set by the resolving power of the method as much as by the networks, and that lifting it pushes the exponent towards the modular $n$. The book's own local rules reproduce whichever value the method reports, so the inequality, at least, is one more regularity that locality accounts for.

Having already accounted for degree distributions, the clustering hierarchy, and degree correlations, this chapter adds community structure — both its emergence and the power law that counts it —

to the list of global patterns that locality alone can explain (Vazquez, 2002).

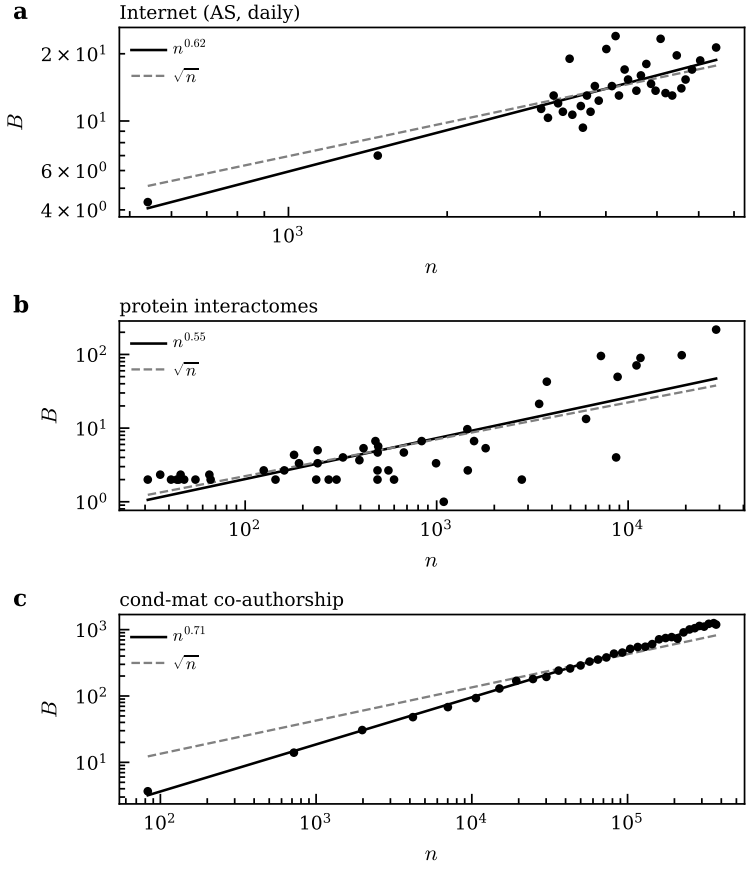



Figure 6.12: **The power law holds within a single growing system.** Number of communities $B$ against size $n$ (log–log) as three systems grow: (a) the Internet at the autonomous-system level, from daily snapshots; (b) protein interactomes across organisms; (c) the `cond-mat` co-authorship network, accumulated year by year to nearly 400,000 authors. Each is a power law (solid line, fitted exponent) above the fractal $\sqrt{n}$ (dashed) — the same super-fractal range as the cross-section of Figure 6.11, but now with the same rule laying down every point.

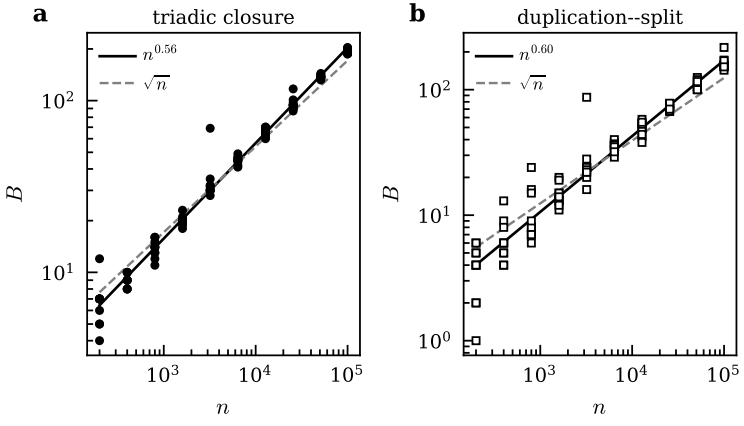



Figure 6.13: **Local rules reproduce the super-fractal exponent.** Number of communities against size for the two local-growth models grown to $10^5$ nodes: (a) triadic closure and (b) duplication–split. Each follows a power law (solid line) with an exponent above the fractal $\sqrt{n}$ (dashed), in the same super-fractal range as the real networks of Figure 6.11.

# Chapter 7

# Nested communities

## 7.1 A photograph of the whole

The last chapter counted communities. It found that the number grows as a power of the size, $B \propto n^{\beta}$ with $\beta \approx 0.61$, and compared that exponent with the $\sqrt{n}$ of the self-similar models. This chapter asks what that comparison means, and the answer turns out to reach further than the question.

Start with a way of looking at a network that we have not used yet. Draw its adjacency matrix as a picture: one pixel for each pair of nodes, black if they are linked, white if they are not. Order the nodes so that similar ones sit together. Now grow the network and watch the picture. If the network is *dense* — if each node links to a fixed *fraction* of the others — the picture settles down. The individual pixels become too small to see, and what survives is a pattern of greys: a smooth function $W(x, y)$ on the unit square giving, for each pair of positions, the probability of a link (Figure 7.1a). That limiting function is called a *graphon*, and it is the object that a growing dense network converges to (Lovász and Szegedy, 2006; Borgs et al., 2008). Two networks with the same graphon are the same network as far as any large-scale statistic can tell.

This is a powerful idea, and it has a large and beautiful theory attached to it. It is also, applied naively to the networks in this book, useless — and the precise way in which it fails is instructive.

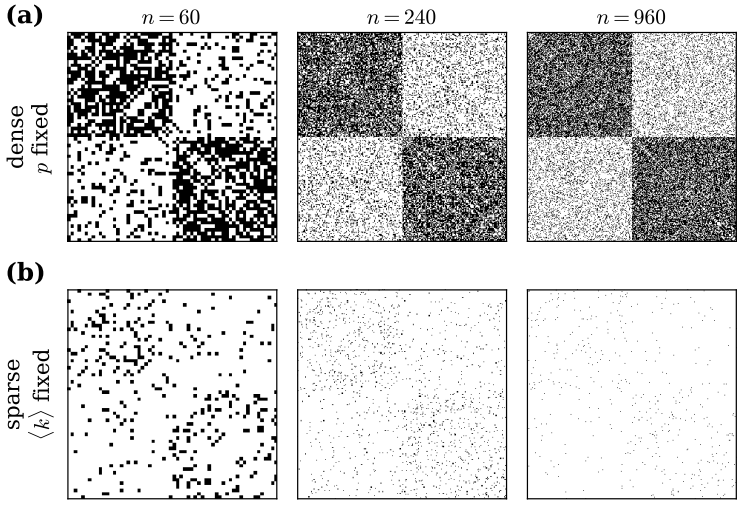



Figure 7.1: **The limit picture, under two scalings.** Adjacency matrices of the same two-block structure at $n = 60$, 240, 960, nodes ordered by block. (a) Dense: the link probabilities are held fixed, and the picture sharpens onto a step function — the graphon. (b) Sparse: the mean degree is held fixed instead, so the probabilities fall as $1/n$. The structure is identical, and just as detectable, but the picture fades to white. Real networks are of the second kind.

The reason is the second row of Figure 7.1. Real networks are not dense. The Internet, the interactome, a co-authorship graph, all keep a roughly fixed mean degree as they grow; so does every model in this book. When the mean degree is fixed the link probability falls like $1/n$, the pixels thin out, and the picture converges — to white. The limit exists, and it has thrown away everything we care about.

The obvious repair is to turn up the contrast: divide the whole picture by its own average darkness before taking the limit, so that what survives is the *pattern* of the greys rather than their absolute level. This works, and it is the substance of a theory of sparse graph limits developed by Borgs et al. (2019). Rescaling costs something.

Dividing by a shrinking average makes the values grow without bound, so the limit is no longer a probability between zero and one; it is what analysts call an $L^p$ *function*, meaning one that may spike as high as it likes provided the average of its $p$-th power stays finite. A spike can be tall or it can be broad, but not both. That is exactly the licence a hub needs — a few nodes joined to a large fraction of the rest — and it is why the theory has to be rebuilt around a class of functions wider than the bounded ones. The gain is real. It is the first limit theory that copes with hubs, and with the power-law degree distributions that come with them.

There are then three regimes, not two, and it is worth knowing which one a network is in. Dense networks have ordinary bounded graphons. Networks that are sparse but *densifying* — the link probability falling to zero while the mean degree still creeps up — have $L^p$ graphons. And networks of genuinely fixed mean degree have neither. The rescaling that saves the middle case needs the mean degree to grow without bound, and when it does not, the rescaled picture concentrates instead of settling: for the ring it piles up along the diagonal, approaching not a function but a line of infinite density.

Which regime a real system is in is a question with an answer, and the systems followed through this book do not give the same one. Track the mean degree against size and fit $\langle k \rangle \propto n^{\delta}$: the Internet at the autonomous-system level, over 733 snapshots, gives $\delta = -0.04$ — flat, or very slightly thinning, a mean degree that stays near four while the network grows sixty-fold. That is the third regime, and no limit theory yet reaches it. The cond-mat co-authorship network gives $\delta = +0.36$, and its mean degree climbs from 2.2 to 19 as it grows from four hundred to four hundred thousand authors. That is the middle regime: co-authorship densifies, and it is the one system here that the $L^p$ theory actually covers.

The interactomes appear to densify too, more gently, but the appearance should not be trusted: that series runs across *organisms* rather than across time, and a better-studied organism has both more proteins catalogued and more interactions recorded per protein. The trend there measures the attention of biologists at least as much as the architecture of cells.

Even the middle regime is tighter than it looks, in a way the

book's own models can measure. Since the exponent $p$ says how tall a spike the class will tolerate, membership in $L^p$ is a condition on how extreme the hubs are allowed to be: for a degree distribution $p_k \sim k^{-\gamma}$ it holds when $p < \gamma - 1$, while the theory itself needs $p > 1$, so there is a usable window only for $\gamma > 2$. The pseudofractal web of the last chapter has $\gamma \simeq 2.585$, leaving the window $1 < p < 1.585$; real networks, whose exponents cluster between two and three, are all squeezed into the same narrow slot, and it closes entirely as $\gamma \to 2$. The limit theory reaches the scale-free world, but only just.

Being in the third regime is worth stating plainly, because it explains the shape of the previous chapter. The evidence for a partition there grew like $m \ln K$, in proportion to the number of *links*; the graphon limit normalizes by the number of *pairs*, which is $n^2$. The two scales differ by the mean degree, and in the sparse world that ratio is the whole story. It is why the last chapter had to compute at finite $n$ and could not simply take a limit. The finite-size calculation was not a convenience. It was the only instrument that sees anything.

## 7.2 The block model is a graphon

Set the difficulty aside for a moment, because the language is useful even where the limit theorem is not.

A stochastic block model *is* a graphon — the simplest interesting kind. If the nodes fall into blocks and the link probability depends only on which blocks the endpoints are in, then $W$ is a step function: constant on each rectangle, jumping at the block boundaries. Fitting a block model to a network is fitting a step function to a picture, and asking how many blocks it needs is asking how finely the picture must be pixelated before the description stops improving.

The degree-corrected model of the last chapter is a graphon too, and its shape says exactly what degree correction *does*.

**The mathematics behind it: degree correction, as a factorization** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let the graphon factorize as

$$W(x,y) = f(x)\,f(y)\;w\big(g(x),g(y)\big), \tag{7.1}$$

where $g(x)$ names the block at position $x$, $w$ is constant on block pairs, and $f$ is an arbitrary non-negative function. The first two factors form a *rank-one* graphon: a product $f(x)f(y)$, in which a node's propensity to link is a single number and nothing about *whom* it links to. That is the configuration model, and $f$ is the degree profile. Comparing with the discrete version of the last chapter, $\theta_i = k_i/\sqrt{2m}$ is the empirical estimate of $f$, and $\omega_{rs}$ is the block-constant residual $w$. Setting $w \equiv 1$ recovers the pure degree model, which is exactly the statement made there that $\omega_{rs} = 1$ reproduces the configuration model.

So the two block models of the last chapter differ in one respect only: the baseline they measure structure against. The plain model tests the network against a *constant* graphon; the degree-corrected model tests it against the best *rank-one* graphon. Degree correction is the removal of the rank-one part, nothing more and nothing less.

Seen this way the pseudofractal reversal loses its strangeness. A degree-blind model has no rank-one factor to spend, so the only way it can express a steep degree gradient is through the block structure itself — and it duly spends its blocks on separating hubs from leaves, which is the hub–leaf cut it was found preferring. Give it a rank-one factor and the gradient is absorbed there, leaving the blocks free to describe what actually remains: the branch geometry. The correction does not weaken the case for the branch cut because the branch cut was never what the degrees were explaining.

The evidence itself has a graphon reading as well. The large-count form of the degree-corrected evidence — the sum of $e_{rs}\ln(e_{rs}/\Omega_{rs})$ over block pairs, met in the last chapter — is $m$ times a relative entropy between the fitted residual $w$ and the flat one — the same functional that governs large deviations for random graphs (Chatterjee and Varadhan, 2011). This sharpens a claim made in passing there. The result $\log R_{\mathrm{dc}}/m \to \ln K$ was said to owe nothing to the

diamond lattice; now we can say why. Relative entropy is a property of the limiting shape, not of the construction that produced it, and any arrangement of $K$ equal well-separated blocks has the same one.

## 7.3 How much can be seen

Now to the question the last chapter raised without quite asking: what sets the number of blocks?

Fitting a step function to a picture is a balancing act familiar from any histogram. Too few bins and the description is crude — real variation is averaged away. Too many and each bin holds too little data to estimate, so the description is noise. The optimum sits where the two costs meet, and it moves with the amount of data. This is the classical bias–variance trade-off, and for networks it has been worked out precisely.

**The mathematics behind it: the cost of a $k$-block description** *(this box can be skipped)*

Three terms compete. Smoothness here is measured by the *Hölder exponent*, which grades how violently a surface is allowed to change when one moves a short distance across it: a graphon has smoothness $\alpha$ if, for some constant $M$,

$$|W(x,y) - W(x',y')| \;\le\; M\big(|x-x'|^{\alpha} + |y-y'|^{\alpha}\big), \qquad (7.2)$$

so that $\alpha = 1$ is the Lipschitz case — a surface of bounded slope — and smaller $\alpha$ lets it swing more violently over a short distance. The *approximation* error of describing such a surface by $k$ steps then follows in a line: cover the square with $k \times k$ cells of side $1/k$ and fit a constant on each; two points in a cell are at most $1/k$ apart, so Eq. (7.2) caps the deviation inside it at $Mk^{-\alpha}$, and since the risk is a mean *squared* error, squaring gives $k^{-2\alpha}$. Against it run two estimation costs, established by Gao et al. (2015): a term $k^2/n^2$ for fitting the $k^2$ block parameters themselves, and a term $n^{-1}\ln k$ for the harder problem of not knowing which node belongs to which block. The total is

$$\mathrm{risk}(k) \;\asymp\; k^{-2\alpha} \;+\; \frac{\ln k}{n} \;+\; \frac{k^2}{n^2}. \qquad (7.3)$$

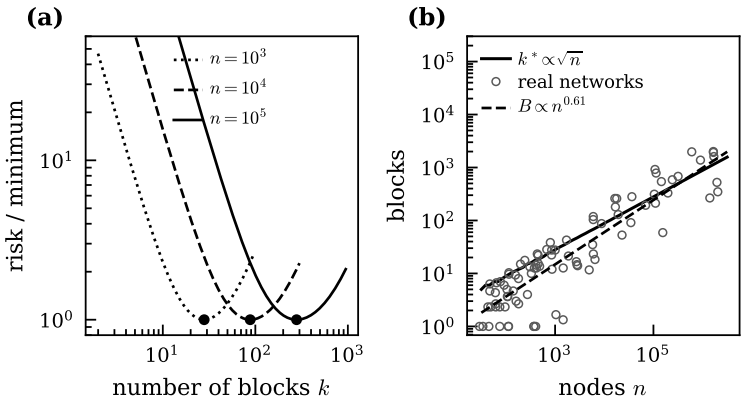



Figure 7.2: **How many blocks can be seen.** (a) The risk of a $k$-block description, Eq. (7.3), for three network sizes, each normalized to its own minimum (dots). The optimum moves right as $\sqrt{n}$. (b) That optimum against size, with the community counts of the real networks of the last chapter and their fitted power law. The vertical placement of the $k^*$ line depends on the graphon's smoothness constant and carries no meaning; its slope of one half does.

The two estimation terms both *grow* with $k$, so on their own they would push towards a single block; it is the approximation error, falling with $k$, that creates an interior optimum. Balancing $k^{-2\alpha}$ against $k^2/n^2$ gives

$$k^* \;\propto\; n^{\,1/(1+\alpha)}. \tag{7.4}$$

Equation (7.4) is the key. For a Lipschitz graphon, $\alpha = 1$ and the optimal description uses

$$k^* \propto \sqrt{n} \tag{7.5}$$

blocks — which is precisely the $\sqrt{n}$ that Olhede and Wolfe (2014) propose for the network histogram, and which Figure 7.2a recovers by direct minimization of Eq. (7.3).

And here the chapter's opening question returns, transformed. The $\sqrt{n}$ that the last chapter used as its fractal yardstick — the

self-similar prediction of $\sqrt{n}$ communities of $\sqrt{n}$ nodes — turns out to be the same $\sqrt{n}$ that statistics arrives at from an entirely different direction, as the resolution at which a smooth shape is best described. The local rule models and the statisticians' histograms agree on a number for reasons that have nothing to do with each other.

## 7.4 Rough, not smooth

Take the agreement seriously and the measured exponent stops being a curiosity and becomes a measurement of something.

The real networks gave $\beta \approx 0.61$, with a bootstrap interval $[0.55, 0.67]$ that excludes one half. Read through Eq. (7.4), an exponent is no longer just a number above or below a fractal benchmark: it is a statement about the smoothness of the shape being described. Inverting $\beta = 1/(1+\alpha)$,

$$\alpha \;=\; \frac{1}{\beta} - 1 \;\approx\; 0.65, \qquad \alpha \in [0.49,\, 0.82], \tag{7.6}$$

and the interval lies wholly below $\alpha = 1$. Direct minimization of Eq. (7.3) at $\alpha = 0.65$ returns an exponent of 0.611, against the measured 0.608.

So the excess over $\sqrt{n}$ is not merely "more communities than a fractal." It says that if real networks are converging to any limiting shape at all, that shape is *rough*: not Lipschitz, not smooth in the sense the estimation theory assumes, but Hölder-continuous with an exponent around two thirds. A smooth graphon — any smooth graphon, of any shape, at any scale, since the smoothness constant sets only the height of the line in Figure 7.2b and not its slope — supports a description that refines as $\sqrt{n}$ and no faster. Real networks refine faster than that. They keep resolving new structure at every scale, at a rate a smooth limit cannot supply.

This is the same conclusion the last chapter reached in its own language, and the same one this book has been reaching since the introduction, arrived at from the outside. A network built by a local rule has no smooth limiting shape to converge to, because the rule keeps writing structure at whatever scale the network has currently reached.

It is worth knowing that this is not a quarrel with the limit theory but an answer to a question its own authors left open. Introducing a network generator built from a singular measure rather than a function, Palla et al. (2010) — Lovász among them — put the alternatives as plainly as they can be put:

> Should we expect that large real graphs converge to some limiting network in a strict sense of the convergence? Or, alternatively, their structure cannot be mapped onto a fixed function, and only an ever-changing (with the size of the network) measure (in the infinite network size limit becoming singular) can be used to reflect the underlying structural complexity?

That was posed in 2010 and left as a question. Equation (7.6) is a measurement bearing on it, taken across a hundred networks, and it comes down on the second side: no fixed smooth function will do, because the description keeps refining faster than any such function allows. The rest of this chapter is about how far that answer can be trusted.

## 7.5 Five meanings of one number

A caution belongs here, and it is a sharp one. Five different arguments in this book and its neighbouring literature all deliver $\sqrt{n}$, and they are not the same statement:

- the *fractal* $\sqrt{n}$ of the self-similar models — a prediction about how many communities the networks themselves hold;
- the *geometric* $\sqrt{n}$ of Chapter 9 — the multiplicity of shortest paths on the same lattice, a prediction about how many ways there are to cross it;
- the *constructive* $\sqrt{n}$ — the resolution any cascade of equal cells is forced to, once its mean degree is held fixed;
- the *statistical* $\sqrt{n}$ of Eq. (7.5) — the best resolution obtainable for a smooth shape, a statement about descriptions;

- the *algorithmic* $\sqrt{n}$ — the resolution limit of the non-nested block model, which cannot report more than of order $\sqrt{n}$ groups no matter how many are present (Peixoto, 2014b), and which is derived, along with the ceiling that replaces it, in Section 7.9.

The last of these has an older and better-known cousin. Long before anyone examined the block model's ceiling, Fortunato and Barthélemy (2007) showed that modularity — then the standard objective for community detection — cannot resolve communities smaller than about $\sqrt{m}$ links in a network of $m$ links, and so merges small ones no matter how clearly separated they are. The mechanism is different: modularity's limit comes from comparing against a global null model, the block model's from the cost of transmitting a matrix. But the lesson is the same, and it is one this chapter will keep returning to. A number of communities reported by a method is a statement about the method as much as about the network, and the only way to tell the two apart is to change the method and watch what moves.

The third of these is the one just met, and it is worth making explicit, because it shows how little the number has to assume. Build a network from a singular measure in the manner of Palla et al. (2010): divide the square into $m^2$ cells, give each a probability, and multiply the whole pattern into itself $k$ times, so that the picture has $m^k$ rows and grows sharper with every iteration. If the cells are all the same size, the mean degree of the resulting network is $Nm^{-2k}$, so holding it fixed while refining the measure forces

$$m^k \;=\; \sqrt{N/\langle k\rangle} \;\propto\; \sqrt{N}. \tag{7.7}$$

The construction resolves $\sqrt{N}$ rows because sparsity leaves it no choice. No network, no estimator and no smoothness assumption enters that argument — only the bookkeeping of keeping a self-similar object sparse.

Three of the five now have reasons, and they are the same reason. The fractal and geometric counts are a lattice's blocks and its routes tallied at the halfway point of its own construction, and the constructive count is what any equal-celled cascade must do to stay sparse; all three are self-similarity keeping its books. That is why

$\beta = 1/2$ is the natural exponent for a self-similar object, and why measuring $\beta > 1/2$ says the object is not one — the multifractal case, where the cells are allowed to differ in size, has no such constraint and its exponent is free. The remaining two agree with them for no reason at all.

The algorithmic $\sqrt{n}$ is a property of neither the network nor the ideal description but of the instrument, and it deserves attention because the counts of the last chapter were produced by exactly that instrument: a flat degree-corrected block model selected by description length. Its ceiling and the null hypothesis under test have the same functional form, which is an uncomfortable coincidence.

The bias runs in the reassuring direction — a ceiling can only suppress the counts of the largest networks and so pull the fitted exponent *down*, meaning $\beta > 1/2$ is measured in spite of the instrument rather than because of it. But the conclusion that survives is correspondingly narrower: these data establish an exponent above one half over four decades of size, and cannot by themselves certify that it persists asymptotically, because the estimator that produced them is not able to report an asymptotic exponent above one half. Only the nested block model, which lifts the ceiling to order $n/\ln n$, can settle that, and re-running the census with it is the obvious next measurement. Should the exponent survive, Eq. (7.6) converts it directly into a statement about the roughness of the limit.

## 7.6 What the ring cannot tell us

One more thing the limit view clarifies, and it is a caveat about a result rather than a strengthening of one.

The ring of the last chapter was found to prefer being split in two, for every range $c \geq 2$. But every node of the ring is identical to every other, and the model was explicit that there is no preferred place to cut: rotate the proposed partition by one bead and the evidence is unchanged. In the language of limits that is a symmetry, and a continuous one. The ring's local limit — what an observer sitting on a node sees, out to any fixed distance (Benjamini and Schramm, 2001) — is an infinite line, the same in every direction, with no communities anywhere in it.

So the ring exhibits, in the cleanest possible form, a distinction

the previous chapter's machinery does not itself draw. Evidence for splitting is not the same as the existence of a partition to be found. The ring supplies the first without the second: a whole continuum of cuts, all equally good, none of them recoverable from the data, and a limit object with no structure at all. What the evidence ratio reports is that one block is a poor description — a true and interesting fact — and not that two particular blocks are the right one. For the diamond lattice and the pseudofractal web, whose partitions are pinned by their construction, no such degeneracy arises and the identification is sound. It is the homogeneous case that needs the care.

The ring is also the only one of the three entitled to that local limit, and the reason is worth recording, because it marks out exactly where this book's networks fall. A local limit of the kind just used requires an absolute ceiling on the degree: every node must look like every other from close up, out to a bounded number of neighbours. The ring obliges — every node has degree $2c$ and always will. The diamond lattice and the pseudofractal web do not: their poles grow without bound, reaching degree $2^t$, so no ceiling exists and the local theory does not apply to them. Nor does the theory at the other end, which needs the number of links to outgrow the number of nodes, while theirs stays proportional to it.

That is a genuine gap, and the book's central examples sit in it: too heavy-tailed for the local theory, too sparse for the global one. It is also a gap the subject knows about and is working to close — a recent line of work (Backhausz and Szegedy, 2018) proposes treating a network not as a picture at all but as an *operator*, and recovers dense graphons and local limits as two special cases of one notion of convergence. Whether it reaches the case that matters here — bounded mean degree with unbounded hubs — is precisely the question to put to it.

## 7.7 What clustering rules out

Everything so far has been about *shape* — whether a limiting picture exists and how finely it can be resolved. There is a blunter test, and the introduction ran it before any of this machinery was in place.

A graphon model, of any kind, draws its links independently

once the positions of the nodes are fixed. That is what makes it tractable, and it has a consequence that cannot be argued away: a triangle needs three links, each drawn separately, so triangles are as rare as three coincidences. In a sparse network the clustering coefficient of such a model collapses to the link density itself, a number of order $\langle k \rangle / n$ — vanishing. Real networks are not like that, and the introduction already measured by how much. Its column $C_{\mathrm{ER}}$, computed there as the clustering of a random network of the same size and density, is precisely the graphon prediction:

| Network | $C$ | $C_{\mathrm{ER}}$ | $C/C_{\mathrm{ER}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| Internet (AS) | 0.230 | 0.00018 | 1254 |
| Gnutella | 0.0055 | 0.000076 | 72 |
| Yeast proteins | 0.071 | 0.0018 | 39 |
| cond-mat co-authorship | 0.657 | 0.00026 | 2541 |

Between forty and two and a half thousand times too many triangles. No adjustment of the shape $W$ repairs a discrepancy of that size, because the shape is not what is wrong: the independence is.

But the argument has to be made carefully, and the careful version is more interesting than the crude one. The comparison above is against a *constant* graphon, and we have already seen in Section 7.2 that the constant is the weaker of the two baselines. Against the *rank-one* graphon — the network reshuffled to preserve every degree — the verdict divides. The Internet's clustering falls only from 0.230 to 0.123 under that reshuffling, a factor of 1.9: its degrees alone, hubs and all, manufacture most of its triangles, because a node of enormous degree is shared by many pairs and closes their triangles by accident. The co-authorship network, whose degrees are far less extreme, still stands 356 times above its own reshuffling.

So the two baselines separate the systems exactly as they separated the pseudofractal's two cuts. Where the degrees are wild, degree heterogeneity accounts for much of the clustering and little is left to explain. Where they are tame, the whole of it survives the strongest degree-preserving null available — and that residue is what Chapter 3 was written to explain. Triadic closure is not an embellishment on a graphon; it is the thing the graphon cannot do.

## 7.8 Locality, or exchangeability

There is a reason all of this bears on the book's thesis rather than merely decorating it, and it is worth ending on.

A graphon is not only a limit; it is a complete description of a certain *kind* of random network — those whose nodes are *exchangeable*, meaning the labels carry no information and any two nodes are, before we look, the same. Shuffle the names of the nodes and the probability of getting that network back is unchanged; nothing about a node except its hidden coordinate $x$ can matter (Aldous, 1981; Diaconis and Janson, 2008). Every graphon model is exchangeable and every exchangeable model is a graphon. Exchangeability is a strong assumption, and what it excludes is precisely geometry: a node's position, its neighbourhood, its history. It excludes locality.

The chapters before this one have argued that networks are built by nodes acting on what is near them — the page a surfer reached, the friend who made the introduction, the gene that was copied. A rule of that kind produces a network in which position matters, in which where a node attached is written into the structure around it. Such a network is not exchangeable, and so it has no graphon in the ordinary sense. The failure of the limit theory to say anything useful about real networks, which began this chapter as an inconvenience, is at bottom the same fact this book has been documenting all along, in a different vocabulary. Sparsity and roughness and the absence of a smooth limit are what locality looks like when a statistician goes looking for a shape.

What the sparse limits should be instead is an open and active question, and the theory of sparse exchangeable graphs (Caron and Fox, 2017) is one serious attempt at it. But it would be wrong to end by filing all of this under work not yet begun, because on one point the previous chapter has already done a piece of it without saying so.

The companion to the $L^p$ theory (Borgs et al., 2018) asks what it should *mean* for a sparse network to converge, and proves that several answers that look quite different are the same answer. One can ask that the rescaled picture settle down. One can ask that the *quotients* settle — the tables of block-to-block densities produced by chopping the network into parts. One can ask that the best partition

at fixed block sizes settle, or that the sum over all such partitions, weighted, settle: a ground state energy and a free energy, in the language of physics. These are all equivalent.

That list is the last chapter's apparatus, item by item. A quotient is exactly the table of counts $e_{rs}$ against expectations $\Omega_{rs}$. Fixed block sizes are exactly the candidate split. The weighted sum over labelings, with the label prior integrated out, is exactly the evidence. And the renormalization flow $(u_{\text{in}}, u_{\times}) \to (K, 0)$ is a quotient converging — proved by hand, for one lattice, in precisely the sense the theorem intends. That is why the resulting $\ln K$ per link is so indifferent to the lattice that produced it: convergence of quotients is a statement about the limiting shape, and any arrangement with the same limiting quotient must give the same free energy.

The hypotheses of that theorem do not cover a bounded-degree lattice, so what the last chapter proved is not a corollary of it; the flow had to be computed. But the agreement of the two routes is worth more than either alone, and it marks out what a limit theory for locally grown networks would have to look like. There is also, on the other side of Eq. (7.6), a number measured across a hundred real networks, still waiting to be explained. The rest of this chapter explains it, and the explanation turns out to be less about the networks than about the two instruments used to count them.

## 7.9 Two priors for the same partition

The last chapter counted communities with a block model, and this one has spent its length on what such a model can and cannot represent. It is time to ask a narrower question, and one that turns out to matter more than it looks: given that a block model is being fitted at all, *which* block model, and does the choice change the answer?

The choice at issue is between the flat model of Chapter 6 and the nested one — both in the microcanonical, degree-corrected form developed by Peixoto (2014c, 2019) on the degree-corrected model of Karrer and Newman (2011), and both fitted here with the same software — and it is worth being precise about the difference, because it is not a difference in what the two can *express*. Both describe a network as $B$ groups together with the matrix $e_{rs}$ of link counts

running between them, both infer $B$ from the data rather than being told it, and any partition one can write down the other can write down too. What differs is the price of naming it.

The flat model transmits the matrix under a uniform prior, as though its $B(B+1)/2$ entries were arbitrary numbers with no relation to one another, which costs about $\frac{1}{2}B^2 \log_2 m$ bits for a network of $m$ links. That charge grows with the square of the number of groups while the saving from splitting a group grows more slowly, and where the two meet is a ceiling: no flat fit recovers more than about $\sqrt{n}$ groups, however many are present (Peixoto, 2014b).

The nested model spends less on the very same object, by declining to treat it as arbitrary. The counts $e_{rs}$ are themselves a network — one node per group, one weighted link per pair — and it is described by a block model of its own, which is described by another, and so on up. A group-level structure that is sparse or modular, as it usually is, then costs a fraction of what spelling out the matrix would; the quadratic charge disappears, and the ceiling rises to around $n/\log n$: some 8700 groups at $n = 10^5$ against 316.

**The mathematics behind it: the price of a block structure, and the ceiling it sets** *(this box can be skipped)*

Both models describe a network by a partition $b$ and the matrix $e_{rs}$ of link counts, and score it by the description length $\Sigma = -\log_2 P(A \mid e, b) - \log_2 P(e, b)$. The first term is the likelihood, which they share. The second is the price of the description, which they do not.

The flat model takes $e_{rs}$ to be an arbitrary symmetric matrix, so it must transmit $B(B+1)/2$ independent entries, each of size up to $m$. That costs about $\frac{1}{2}B^2 \log_2 m$ bits. Splitting one group into two saves at most of order $m/B$ bits of likelihood, so the two terms balance at

$$B_{\max} \;\propto\; \sqrt{m} \;\propto\; \sqrt{n} \tag{7.8}$$

for a network of fixed mean degree (Peixoto, 2014b) — the *algorithmic* $\sqrt{n}$ of Section 7.5, and the only one of the five that is a fact about a method rather than about a network. Past that point every further split costs more to announce than it saves, whatever the network looks like. The ceiling is a property of the code, not of the data.

The nested model refuses the premise that $e_{rs}$ is arbitrary. The counts are themselves a network — one node per group, one weighted

link per pair — so describe them with a block model, whose own count matrix is described by another, and so on until one group remains. Each level costs a fraction of what spelling out its matrix would, provided the group-level structure is itself sparse or modular, which it generally is. The quadratic charge never appears, and the ceiling rises to

$$B_{\max} \;\propto\; n/\log n, \tag{7.9}$$

some 8700 groups at $n = 10^5$ against 316. Setting the hierarchy to a single level recovers the flat model exactly, so the comparison between them is strictly nested and an extra level can only pay for itself or not.

The same arithmetic answers a question the next chapter has to face, so it is worth doing here. Suppose one wanted a block model over $j$-sets of nodes rather than pairs — a natural thought if the object generating the network acts on triples or quadruples. Its count tensor has about $B^j/j!$ entries, and repeating the balance above gives

$$B_{\max} \;\approx\; \left[m\,(j-1)!\,/\ln m\right]^{1/j}, \tag{7.10}$$

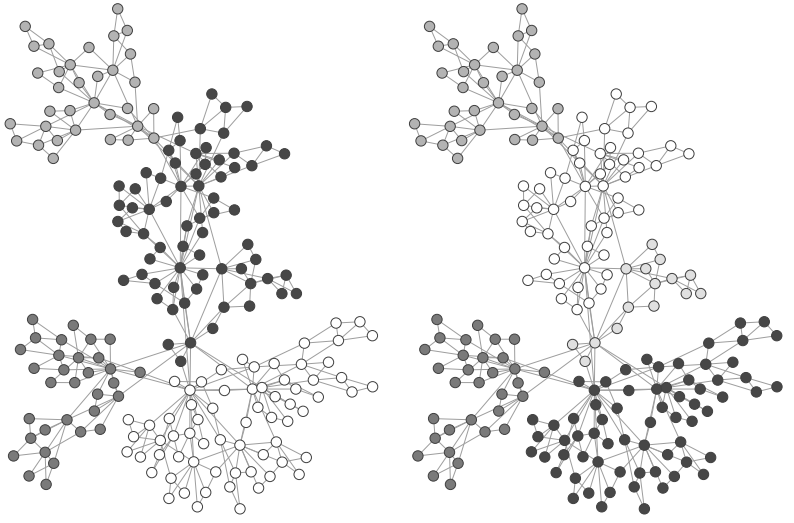
which is $\sqrt{n}$ at $j = 2$ and $n^{1/4}$ at $j = 4$ once $m$ is of order $n$: eighteen groups against three hundred and sixteen at $n = 10^5$. Raising the arity costs resolution, and costs it fast. A model that can no longer see communities is a poor instrument for asking what communities are made of, which is why Chapter 8 reaches for a richer *vocabulary* inside the ordinary pair model rather than for a tensor over $j$-sets.

So the two differ in a prior and not in a likelihood. Given the same partition and the same counts they assign the network the same probability; they disagree only about how surprising the counts were. Figure 7.3 shows what that disagreement looks like on a single network.

## 7.10 Which prior the data prefers

A difference of prior invites an obvious objection. If the two models disagree only in what they expected before seeing anything, on what grounds is either to be believed?

The answer is that a prior is a code, and a code can be measured. The whole point of the description length is that it needs no external



(a) flat, 4 groups, $\Sigma = 2470$ (b) nested, 5 groups, $\Sigma = 2458$

Figure 7.3: **The same network, divided by the two priors.** An instance of $LS(n{=}200, \ell{=}1)$, laid out once and coloured twice. The flat model resolves four groups; the nested model splits the larger of them and resolves five, and it does so while spending twelve bits *fewer* on the description as a whole — which is the sense in which the finer division is not merely permitted but preferred. At $n = 100$ the two return the same three groups: the ceiling has to be approached before it can be felt.

arbiter: the better prior is the one that assigns a shorter description to the data that actually occurred. Both codes are complete, both are fixed before the answer is known, and comparing their lengths is a test rather than a preference.

The comparison is also structurally safe, because the nested model with a single level *is* the flat model. The hierarchy is a strict generalisation, so it can only help, up to the small cost of announcing how many levels there are. One is not choosing between rival beliefs but asking whether an extra layer of description pays for itself.

On real networks it pays, and handsomely. Fitting both models to

fourteen of the networks of Chapter 6, and reading off the description length each achieves:

| network | $n$ | $\Sigma$ flat | $\Sigma$ nested | difference |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| netscience | 379 | 5 775 | 5 583 | −192 |
| kegg_metabolic | 1 865 | 40 142 | 39 709 | −433 |
| urban_streets | 2 870 | 43 262 | 42 793 | −470 |
| celegans_interactome | 5 966 | 619 605 | 606 016 | −13 589 |
| ppi_interolog_human | 16 820 | 3 041 650 | 3 037 343 | −4 307 |
| internet_as | 22 963 | 404 104 | 399 172 | −4 932 |

Across the fourteen the nested model is shorter on thirteen, by 1772 bits on average. The one exception is a tie, on a network the model puts in a single group, where there is no group-level graph to compress and the hierarchy has nothing to do.

The flat model is therefore not wrong. It is a code that pays for arbitrariness it does not need, and the data says so, in bits. Its $\sqrt{n}$ ceiling is a property of that code and not of networks — which matters, because $\sqrt{n}$ is exactly the fractal limit the last chapter's exponent was being compared against.

## 7.11 How many communities?

Chapter 6 measured $B \propto n^{\beta}$ with $\beta \approx 0.61$ and called real networks *super-fractal*: above the self-similar $\frac{1}{2}$, below the modular 1. Everything above says that number should be re-examined with the other prior, and it does not survive intact.

Take the book's own growth rules first, where the networks can be made to order and grown as far as patience allows. Fitting both models to the same realisations over $n = 100$ to 1600 (Figure 7.4):

| rule | flat | nested | difference |
|---|---|---|---|
| $LS(n, 1)$ | 0.54 | 0.94 | +0.40 |
| $DS(n, 0.5)$ | 0.76 | 1.02 | +0.26 |
| $DD(n, 0.5)$ | 0.78 | 1.12 | +0.34 |
| $BB(n, 2)$ | 0.72 | 0.94 | +0.22 |

The flat model reproduces Chapter 6 — it was that chapter's method — and it reproduces it while sitting at its own ceiling. Lift the

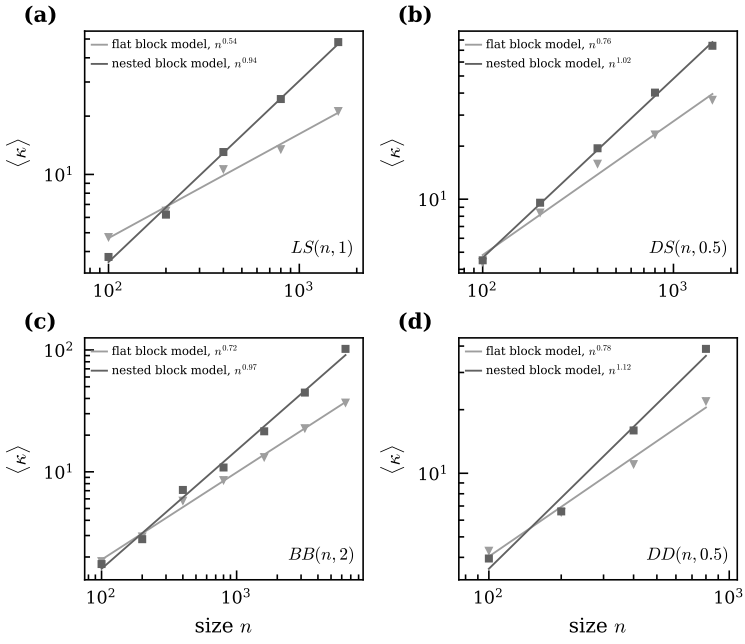



Figure 7.4: **How many communities, under each prior.** The mean number of communities against size for four growth rules, averaged over twenty networks at each size, with the best power law fitted to each method and its exponent in the legend. The flat model comes out near its own $\sqrt{n}$ ceiling throughout; the nested model grows almost in proportion to $n$.

ceiling and every rule moves to the modular limit: the number of communities grows in proportion to the size, and their typical size stops growing. At $n = 1600$ local search divides into groups of about thirty-four nodes and duplication–split into groups of about twenty-one, and those figures barely change as the networks are grown further.

The same question on the real networks gives a smaller shift in the same direction. Refitting close to ninety of them, from twenty-nine

nodes to three hundred thousand, both ways:

| | $\beta$ | 95% interval |
|---|---|---|
| flat, as Chapter 6 published it | 0.633 | [0.57, 0.69] |
| flat, refitted here | 0.630 | [0.57, 0.69] |
| nested | **0.804** | [0.72, 0.88] |

The refit reproduces the published column to three decimals, which is the check that this is the same measurement and not a different one. The nested interval lies wholly above two thirds.

What survives of Chapter 6, then, is the inequality. Every method puts $\beta$ above one half, and lifting the resolution only raises it further, so real networks are certainly not self-similar in their community structure. What does not survive is the particular value, and with it the picture of a balance struck midway between two limits. On the growth rules the answer is the modular limit outright. On the real networks the census gives 0.80 rather than 0.61 — still short of 1, but no longer comfortably inside the range the last chapter named. The exponent was, in part, a property of the instrument.

That 0.80 will not survive Section 7.13 either, and for a reason that has nothing to do with priors. But the resolution question has to be settled before the measurement question can be asked, so it is settled here first.

## 7.12 The density of communities

An exponent of one is a special number, and it is worth pausing on what it would mean if it were exact. If $B$ grows in proportion to $n$, then the ratio

$$b = B/n, \qquad \langle n_B \rangle = 1/b = n/B, \tag{7.11}$$

stops depending on size. Call $b$ the *density of communities* — how many of them there are per node — and $\langle n_B \rangle$ its reciprocal, the mean number of nodes per community. Neither is then a rate of growth any longer; each is a *quantity*, a number a network of any size simply has, and one may tabulate it the way one tabulates a clustering coefficient or a degree exponent. On the growth rules this is very nearly what happens.

| rule | $n$ | $\beta$ | $b$ | $\langle n_B \rangle$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $LS(n, 1)$ | 100–1600 | 0.94 | $0.032 \pm 0.003$ | 31 |
| $DS(n, 0.5)$ | 100–1600 | 1.02 | $0.048 \pm 0.002$ | 21 |
| $DD(n, 0.5)$ | 100–800 | 1.12 | $0.040 \pm 0.006$ | 25 |
| $BB(n, 2)$ | 100–6400 | 0.97 | $0.015 \pm 0.002$ | 66 |

The exponents straddle one, and the density is flat — to within a few per cent for local search and duplication–split across sixteen-fold in size, for the bubble rule across sixty-four-fold. The rules are not saying the same thing: their densities differ by a factor of three, and the typical community runs from twenty-one nodes under duplication–split to sixty-six under the bubble rule. Those numbers are as much a signature of the rule as its degree exponent is. Nothing in the rules sets a community size directly — there is no parameter with units of nodes anywhere in them — and yet each settles on one and holds it while the network grows by orders of magnitude around it.

That is a genuine finding, and it changes the reading of the whole exercise. It is tempting to describe it as the limit these networks converge to, and it is nearly the opposite. A graphon is a picture in which the group structure coarsens: as $n$ grows the number of groups stays put and each group swells in proportion, so that the labels shrink onto a fixed kernel on the unit square. Constant density is that picture refused. Communities of twenty or sixty nodes never swell, and no matter how far the network is grown, the resolution needed to see its structure keeps pace with the network itself. This is a second obstruction, distinct from the sparsity of Section 7.1: a sparse network could still have a fixed community structure, and these do not. What the growth rules converge to under a nested description is not a shape one could draw on the square. It is a density.

On real networks the picture looked, at first, close but not the same.

| networks | no. | $n$ | $\beta$ | $\langle n_B \rangle$ | $b$ slope |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| social | 47 | 34–317080 | 0.80 | 27 | −0.20 |
| biological | 15 | 47–16820 | 0.78 | 38 | −0.22 |
| infrastructure | 10 | 29–34761 | 0.73 | 165 | −0.27 |
| information | 9 | 112–145145 | 0.95 | 27 | −0.05 |
| *all* | 81 | 29–317080 | 0.80 | 31 | −0.20 |

The community sizes are of the same order the rules produce — around thirty nodes, with the infrastructure networks the exception at a hundred and sixty. But the exponent came out below one almost everywhere, and the last column says what that costs: $b$ falling as roughly $n^{-0.2}$, $\langle n_B \rangle$ growing about fourfold across the four decades the census spans. Taken at face value, that is a shortfall the growth rules would have to explain.

It is not to be taken at face value, and seeing why is worth more than the number was.

## 7.13 What a census exponent measures

The two exponents being compared are not measurements of the same thing. The rules' $\beta$ comes from a *growth series*: one mechanism, one object, followed through a sequence of sizes. The census $\beta$ comes from a *cross-section*: eighty-one different networks, built by different processes, recorded by different projects, with size as the only thing ordering them. The first says how the number of communities changes as a network grows. The second says how it varies between systems that happen to differ in size. Nothing guarantees these are the same number, and a census that mixes kinds of network will report the second while looking like the first.

The census behaves the way a cross-section behaves. Restrict it to the sizes the rules were actually run at, $n$ between 100 and 1600, and it returns $\beta = 0.58$; take all of it and it returns 0.80. A genuine scaling law does not move by two tenths depending on which of its instances one includes. Two further symptoms point the same way. Networks sitting above the fitted line are markedly denser than those below — median mean degree 13.4 against 5.8, with the residual correlating with mean degree at Spearman $\rho = +0.43$ — and the spatially embedded networks sit systematically below it. Neither of those moves the exponent much when removed, which is the point: the scatter the line is drawn through is not error but structure, so the interval quoted around 0.80 is narrower than the honest uncertainty.

The way to settle it is to measure the thing the rules measure. A few real systems were recorded repeatedly *while they grew*, and can be fitted along their own histories rather than against each other: the Internet at the autonomous-system level, from daily route-collector

snapshots; the co-authorship network of the history of science, whose links carry the year they were made and can be accumulated; and the physical interactome of yeast, accumulated by the year each interaction was published.

| system | $n$ | pts | $\beta$ | $\langle n_B \rangle$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Internet, autonomous sys. | 2086–6474 | 38 | 1.20 [0.94, 1.55] | 124 |
| co-authorship, hist. of sci. | 2886–182964 | 18 | 1.01 [0.96, 1.06] | 23 |
| yeast interactome, BioGRID | 47–6976 | 13 | 0.90 [0.84, 1.26] | 48 |
| *census*, all kinds | 29–317 080 | 81 | 0.80 [0.72, 0.88] | 31 |

Every one of them exceeds the census figure, and the two that are genuinely growing networks — the Internet and the collaboration graph — come out at one, with the co-authorship interval excluding 0.80 outright. Their community sizes are the ones the rules produce: twenty-three nodes for co-authorship, against twenty-one for duplication–split.

So the shortfall was never a property of real networks. It was a property of averaging over kinds of them. The density of communities is constant, in the systems where the question has been asked properly, and the growth rules were right about it.

The third row is the exception that shows the mechanism. Yeast's interactome is not a growing network at all — the cell's protein interactions are not being created as we watch, they are being *found* — so its series measures how communities scale as a fixed object is discovered. It is the lowest of the three and the only one whose central value falls short of one. That is the same confound this chapter already flagged for the tree-of-life series, where the trend runs across organisms and a better-studied organism has both more proteins catalogued and more interactions recorded per protein. Here it runs across time instead, and it can be quantified: incomplete observation of a network does depress the apparent number of communities, and a census that mixes catalogued networks with grown ones will inherit some of that depression.

Three cautions, so the table is not asked to carry more than it can. The Internet series covers only a threefold range in size, which is why its interval is so much wider than the others; co-authorship, at twenty-onefold, is the one that carries the weight. Three route-collector days were dropped because the collector was partly down; they are snapshots of less of the Internet, not of a smaller one, and

keeping them lowers the exponent to 0.96, which changes nothing about the conclusion. Four co-authorship snapshots were dropped for a reason worth naming, since it is the chapter's own lesson turned on itself: they had been fitted with fewer restarts of the minimiser than the rest, to save time, and a single restart lands in a worse optimum more often on a large network than on a small one. That puts a downward trend into the slope which belongs to the schedule and not to the data. The tell was that the 2005 snapshot came back with fewer communities than the 1995 one, which strictly contains it — a cumulative series cannot lose groups as it grows. And three systems are three, not a survey: what has been shown is that the census exponent is not the growth exponent, and that where the growth exponent can be measured it is one, not that every network in the world obeys it.

The general lesson outlasts the number. An exponent fitted across a heterogeneous collection of networks is a statement about the collection. It answers a question about how systems differ, and it will be read — it was read, in Chapter 6 and in the first half of this section — as a statement about how a network grows. The two coincide only if the collection is homogeneous in everything except size, which no census of real networks is.

One caution belongs with any use of these numbers. A density of communities is not a property of a network alone; it is a property of a network together with the code used to describe it, and this chapter has spent its length showing how much that matters. Under the flat prior the same census gives $\beta = 0.63$. The tables above mean what they say only because the model is fixed — nested, degree-corrected, minimum description length — and a density quoted without naming the model is not a measurement. That is a familiar situation rather than a disqualifying one. The clustering coefficient has two standard definitions that disagree, and the introduction had to say which one it meant before it could say anything about hierarchy.

One thing the change of prior does *not* touch is the Ramsey community number. Fitted both ways, local search crosses the ninety-five per cent threshold at 70 against 80, duplication–split at 90 against 100, duplication–divergence at 40 either way. Resolution decides how finely a network can be cut; it says almost nothing about whether there is anything to cut at all. That second question

depends on something else entirely, and is taken up in the next chapter.

## 7.14 The limit we found

This chapter set out to ask what the limit theories can say about networks grown by local rules, and the answer arrived from an unexpected direction.

The expected answer was a shape. That is what a limit theory offers: let the network grow, let the pixels shrink, and read off the function on the unit square that survives. The chapter's first half is a catalogue of why that does not happen here. Real networks and the local rule models sit in the third regime, of fixed mean degree, where the rescaling that saves the sparse case has nothing to rescale by. Their adjacency pictures are rough rather than smooth, Hölder with an exponent near two thirds, so the histogram theorems that promise $\sqrt{n}$ cells are promising more than can be delivered. And their clustering does not vanish, which any bounded graphon says it must.

There was a natural guess about what to reach for instead, and the shape of the guess was: more arguments. A local rule does not act on pairs. Triadic closure acts on *triples* — a node, its neighbour, and that neighbour's neighbour — and duplication acts on a node, its copy, and their shared neighbours, a configuration of four. If the statistics a rule generates are to be carried by a limiting object at all, the object may need arguments enough to hold the rule's own footprint: a kernel $[0,1]^3 \to [0,1]$ where the rule closes triangles, $[0,1]^4 \to [0,1]$ where it duplicates, with the fitted block model as the two-variable shadow of it. Chapter 8 takes that guess apart, and finds it half right: a two-variable object provably loses the triangles, but a higher-arity kernel indexed by *nodes* does not obviously get them back, and the natural object turns out to be indexed by pairs instead.

Meanwhile this chapter found something the guess does not mention, by asking a narrower question and following it further than intended. Fit the nested model instead of the flat one and the number of communities grows in proportion to the size. The density $b = B/n$ of Eq. (7.11) stops depending on $n$; it becomes a number a network

has, the way it has a clustering coefficient. The growth rules hold it flat over one to two decades and disagree about its value by a factor of three, twenty-one nodes per community under duplication–split against sixty-six under the bubble rule. On the real systems where the question can be asked properly — those recorded repeatedly while they grew — it is flat too, and the collaboration graph settles at twenty-three nodes per community, next to duplication–split's twenty-one.

It is tempting to go one step further and say that the limit is a *nested* structure: communities of communities, all the way up, with the same constant governing every level. The fitted hierarchies appear to say so. Read off the level sizes of a nested fit and the branching ratio is large at the bottom — that is the community size — and then settles at two to four for every level above it, on every rule, which looks like self-similarity.

It is not, and the check that shows it is the one this chapter has been preaching. Fit the same model to a network built with no hierarchy above its bottom level: a planted partition of sixty-four equal groups and nothing else. The model recovers the sixty-four exactly, and then builds a four-four-four tree on top of them. The upper branching is the prior's own scaffolding. (On a network with no communities at all the model correctly returns a single level, so it is not inventing structure from nothing — it is organising real groups into a tree that the data never asked for.) The bottom level is a measurement. The levels above it are a description device, and no claim about a self-similar hierarchy survives them.

What survives is one number, and that is the finding.

> *Conjecture.* For large $n$ a locally grown network does not converge to a kernel on the unit square — not of two arguments, and not of any fixed number. It converges *locally*: the neighbourhood of a typical node settles down, and with it a community of bounded size. What the limit is characterised by is intensive: chief among these quantities the density of communities $b = B/n$, equivalently the mean community size $\langle n_B \rangle$, constant in $n$ and set by the growth rule.

The word *locally* is doing the work the word *almost* used to do, and

it points at a theory that already exists: local weak convergence (Benjamini and Schramm, 2001), in which one keeps a bounded neighbourhood around a randomly chosen root and asks what it looks like, rather than coarsening the whole picture onto a fixed shape. That is the natural home for a network whose communities never grow.

And it explains why a graphon was never going to work, in a way that is worth stating in one sentence. A graphon is the picture in which group structure *coarsens*: as $n$ grows the groups stay fixed in number and swell in proportion, until the labels shrink onto a kernel one could draw. Constant density refuses that twice over. The communities never swell, so there is nothing to shrink onto; and the resolution needed to see the structure keeps pace with the network forever, so no finite description ever suffices. This is an obstruction distinct from sparsity — a sparse network could perfectly well have a fixed community structure, and these do not.

Whether some higher-order exchangeable object could hold a bounded community around a typical node is exactly what remains open, and nothing here settles it. What is settled is that the two-variable picture cannot, and that looking for the answer as a picture at all may have been the wrong instinct.

Two things are worth carrying forward. The first is a warning about instruments, learned twice in this chapter and at some cost. The exponent $\beta$ moved from 0.63 to 0.80 when the prior changed, and from 0.80 to 1 when the sample stopped mixing kinds of network; neither move had anything to do with the networks. A number measured through a method is a statement about the pair, and the only way to tell which half is speaking is to change the method and watch. The second is the density itself, which the next chapter will try to move by changing the vocabulary rather than the resolution — and will fail to.

# Chapter 8

# Communities with network motifs

The last chapter asked how finely a network can be divided, and answered it with two priors over the same object. This one asks a different question: what the divider is allowed to *know* about the thing it is dividing.

Start with cycles, because they are where a network's local structure shows itself. Every network has cycles of every length, and their numbers are not remotely comparable: the yeast interactome holds a couple of hundred triangles and ten thousand cycles of length eight, and a duplication–divergence network of two hundred nodes holds none of length three, five or seven and seven million of length eight. The counts climb steeply with length, and the steepness is not a free parameter — it is set by the short cycles.

That is the fact this chapter is built on, and it is worth stating at the outset. The number of $h$-cycles through a node of degree $k$ is fixed by the degree distribution together with one three-point quantity, the clustering coefficient, and the length enters only as an exponent: the same closing probability applied $h-2$ times around the loop (Section 8.3). Long cycles are not an independent feature of a network. They are what short cycles compound into. A description that has the triangles right has the whole spectrum right, wherever triangles exist at all.

Wherever they do not, the compounding starts from something else, and the question of *which* something else turns out to be answerable by measurement. A rule that closes squares rather than triangles leaves a spectrum with a different shape, and one that closes pentagons a different shape again.

All of which bears on communities in a way that is not obvious until it is stated. A block model divides a network on the evidence of where its links fall. Clustering is evidence: a knot of mutually connected nodes looks like a community. But if the network was grown by a rule that closes triangles everywhere, the knots are not communities at all, and a method that could *name* a triangle would have an innocent explanation available where a method without one has only the partition. So the question of this chapter is whether giving a community model a vocabulary of motifs changes what it reports — and the answer, worked out over the sections that follow, is that it changes one thing and leaves another alone.

The concern is not new, and neither is the vocabulary. Recurring small subgraphs were named *network motifs* by Milo et al. (2002), who found them at frequencies no random graph with the same degrees would produce; random graph ensembles built to contain prescribed subgraphs rather than prescribed links were constructed by Karrer and Newman (2010), and the model of Section 8.4 is a block-structured version of theirs. Closest of all, Peixoto (2022) put exactly the suspicion above to work: a block model in which each link is generated either by community membership or by triadic closure over an existing path, with the assignment inferred alongside the partition. On real networks it removes a good deal of what a plain block model had been calling community structure. What follows differs in two ways. The alphabet is not fixed to the triangle — squares and bicliques are in it too, because Chapter 4's rules do not close triangles — and the target is not any one network but the *scaling*, how the number of communities grows with size and whether that exponent is a property of the network or of the vocabulary used to describe it.

## 8.1 Two questions about arity

Chapter 7 ended by conjecturing that a locally grown network converges to no kernel on the unit square at all, of two arguments or of any number, and that what characterises its limit is instead intensive: a density of communities, constant in size and set by the rule. It reached that conclusion by abandoning an earlier guess — that the limit is a kernel of *higher arity*, three arguments where the rule closes triangles and four where it duplicates, with the fitted block model as the two-variable shadow of it. That guess was abandoned rather than tested there. It is tested here, and this chapter is where both halves of the question — what a two-variable fit loses, and whether more arguments recover it — are taken apart into pieces measurement can reach.

Start from what Chapter 6 actually did. It took networks grown by local rules and *fitted* them — to a stochastic block model, by Bayesian inference. A block model is a two-variable object, a kernel $[0,1]^2 \to [0,1]$ read through group labels, and the fit was good enough to count communities across four decades of size. So a two-variable description already captures something real. The question is what it misses, whether the miss has a shape, and whether an object with more arguments recovers it.

Two questions follow, and the first is answerable now.

### Q1: what does the fitted block model preserve?

Given a network grown by a local rule and the block model that Bayesian inference fits to it, which statistics agree and which do not? The honest answer has a clean first instalment, and the pseudofractal web supplies it, because there every quantity is exact.

**The mathematics behind it: the triangles a two-variable model can hold** *(this box can be skipped)*

The pseudofractal web of Dorogovtsev et al. (2002) has $n = (3^{t+1} + 3)/2$ nodes and $3^{t+1}$ links, and every node added closes exactly one triangle, so it holds exactly $n - 2$ of them. Fit chapter 6's branch cut and ask each fitted model how many it expects, via $\mathrm{tr}(P^3)/6$ for its expected adjacency matrix $P$.

The plain block model assigns one density per block pair. In a sparse network those densities fall like $1/n$, and a triple of blocks contributes $n^3 \times n^{-3}$: the expected count is $O(1)$, and numerically it *saturates* at 21.3 triangles however large the web grows. Against a true count rising like $n$, the deficit grows like $n$ itself.

The degree-corrected model does better, and still fails. Its expected count weights each block by the degree sum $Q_r = \sum_{i \in r} k_i(k_i - 1)$ rather than by its size — $k(k-1)$ and not $k^2$, because a triangle leaves a node by a different link than it entered by, and the fit holds the degrees fixed — and for this web $Q \sim 4^t$ while the degree sum is $S \sim 3^t$, so the count grows as $(Q/S)^3 \sim (64/27)^t$ against a truth growing as $3^t$. The deficit again diverges, now as

$$(81/64)^t \;=\; n^{\,0.214}. \tag{8.1}$$

Allowing the number of blocks to grow as the data demand, $B \propto n^\beta$, helps but does not close it: $B$ blocks of $n/B$ nodes contribute $O(1)$ triangles each, hence $n^\beta$ in all, still short of $\Theta(n)$ by $n^{1-\beta}$.

So the answer to the first question, for this network, is sharp. A two-variable description preserves what the *cut metric* sees — the yardstick the limit theory uses, which judges two networks close when no way of splitting the nodes into two sets reveals a difference in the density of links across the split, and so registers block densities, degrees, the evidence for a partition, everything the last chapter computed — and loses the 3-point structure entirely, by a margin that widens without bound. Even a hierarchy of blocks, refining as fast as real networks demand, recovers only $n^\beta$ of the $n$ triangles.

One warning for anyone testing this at accessible sizes: the failure is not visible early, and it changes sign. At $n \simeq 3000$ the degree-corrected model *over*counts triangles fivefold, and only past $n \sim 10^8$ does it cross over to undercounting. A study stopping at ten thousand nodes would conclude the opposite of the truth.

## Q2: does higher order close the gap?

If two variables are not enough, are three? Here the arity guess meets a genuine obstacle, and the obstacle locates exactly where its content lies.

For *dense* graphs the question is already settled, and settled against the guess. An exchangeable array admits the representation $f(\xi_\emptyset, \xi_i, \xi_j, \xi_{ij})$, and for a simple dense graph the pair-level variable $\xi_{ij}$ can always be absorbed into a threshold, leaving a two-variable kernel. Exchangeability *forces* the graphon form; no higher-order object can add anything. Whatever raising the arity buys, it cannot be that.

Its content therefore lies entirely in the sparse regime — which is the regime this whole chapter has been about, and the reason the clustering of Section 7.7 does not vanish when a graphon says it must. There, the pair-level randomness does not wash out, and the natural object keeps arguments indexed by *pairs* rather than by nodes: not $W(x_i, x_j, x_k)$ but something closer to $W(x_{ij}, x_{ik}, x_{jk})$, which is the shape the limit theory of hypergraphs already takes — a hypergraph being a network whose links may join three or more nodes at once rather than exactly two. The inferential side of that idea has been built: Young et al. (2021) ask, of an ordinary pairwise network, which of its cliques are better explained as single higher-order interactions than as the links they appear to be, and answer by description length, promoting a group to a hyperlink only when the evidence pays for the promotion. It is the same accounting used here, with hyperlinks in place of motifs. That is a refinement of the guess rather than a refutation of it, and it says where to look: triadic closure makes the presence of one link depend on two others sharing a node, and a pair-indexed kernel is the smallest object that can express such a dependence.

## The same failure, with the arity changed

The diamond lattice tests whether any of this was about triangles. It cannot be: the lattice is bipartite and contains no triangle at all. Its rule replaces each link with two parallel paths, so the motif it manufactures is the *four*-cycle, and the same question can be put again with the arity moved by one.

**The mathematics behind it: the four-cycles a two-variable model can hold** *(this box can be skipped)*

After $t$ generations the lattice has $m = 4^t$ links and $n = (2 \cdot 4^t + 4)/3$ nodes. Only the diamonds closed at the *last* generation are still four-cycles — earlier ones have had their links subdivided into longer loops — so the count is exactly $4^{t-1}$, again proportional to $n$. Fitting chapter 6's cut into two branches and evaluating $\mathrm{tr}(P^4)/8$:
The plain block model saturates, as before, and here the constant can be named. In the limit the two blocks are near-independent, each of $n_r \simeq 4^t/3$ nodes at density $p \simeq 9/4^t$, contributing $n_r^4 p^4/8 = 81/8$ four-cycles apiece:

$$\text{plain model} \longrightarrow \tfrac{81}{4} = 20.25 \tag{8.2}$$

four-cycles, for a lattice of any size.
The degree-corrected model is where the two lattices part company. Its count is governed by the ratio of the excess-degree sum to the degree sum, and for this lattice that ratio is not a power of $n$ at all but

$$Q/S \;=\; \sum_i k_i(k_i-1) \Big/ \sum_i k_i \;=\; t \tag{8.3}$$

exactly, so the expected four-cycle count converges to $t^4/4$: *polylogarithmic* in $n$, against a truth growing as $n/6$. At $t = 26$ the lattice holds $1.1 \times 10^{15}$ four-cycles and the fitted degree-corrected model expects $1.2 \times 10^5$ of them.

That gap — a factor of $n/(\ln n)^4$ — is far worse than the pseudofractal's $n^{0.214}$, and the reason is the one thing the two lattices genuinely differ in. The pseudofractal's degrees are wild, $\gamma \simeq 2.585$, and a rank-one model with hubs that extreme manufactures a great many triangles by accident: three links that all happen to touch the same few enormous nodes close a triangle whether or not any rule intended it. The diamond's degrees are milder, $\gamma = 3$ exactly, which is the marginal case where $\sum k_i^2$ outgrows $\sum k_i$ only logarithmically — and a rank-one model then has nothing to fake with.

So the two-variable model's apparent grasp of higher-order structure is not a grasp at all. It is borrowed entirely from degree heterogeneity, and it fails as the degrees become tame. That is a mechanism for something already measured in Section 7.7: there the

degree-preserving null came within a factor of 1.9 of the Internet's clustering, whose degrees are extreme, and fell 356 times short for co-authorship, whose degrees are not. The deterministic lattices say why, and warn against the natural misreading — that degree-corrected models capture clustering. They capture it exactly where the degrees are heavy enough to counterfeit it.

## The whole spectrum at once

Triangles and four-cycles are two points. Asking the question at every cycle length turns the finding from a shortfall into something more damaging.

**The mathematics behind it: why a two-variable model has a one-parameter spectrum** *(this box can be skipped)*

For a model with independent links and expected adjacency $P$, the expected number of $L$-cycles is $\mathrm{tr}(P^L)/2L$. When $P$ is a $K$-block fit this collapses onto a $K \times K$ *transfer matrix*

$$T_{rs} \;=\; \omega_{rs}\sqrt{Q_r Q_s} \qquad \text{(degree-corrected)}, \tag{8.4}$$

with $Q_r = \sum_{i\in r} k_i(k_i-1)$, and $T_{rs} = p_{rs}\sqrt{n_r n_s}$ for the plain model, so that the count at every length is $\mathrm{tr}(T^L)/2L$. The entire motif spectrum is generated by one small matrix, and for large $L$ it is $\lambda^L/2L$ for the leading eigenvalue $\lambda$ — a smooth geometric profile. A two-variable model has no freedom to put a feature at one particular length, whatever its blocks are doing.

The weight is $k(k-1)$ rather than $k^2$ because a cycle leaves a node by a different link than the one it arrived on, and the degree-corrected fit holds the degree sequence fixed: a node offers $k(k-1)$ ordered pairs of links, not $k^2$. The one-block case is then $\langle k^2-k\rangle/\langle k\rangle$, which is the leading eigenvalue of the *non-backtracking* operator, which counts walks forbidden to turn round and retrace the link they arrived on — the natural object for cycles, since a cycle never does. The distinction is invisible in the limits taken below, where the ratio diverges and the $-1$ is lost, but it is worth a factor of 25 at $L = 8$ on a real network, where the ratio is nearer 3.

The lattices do nothing but put features at particular lengths. The diamond is built from four-cycles and carries cycles of length 4,

8, 16, and so on — and *exactly none* at any other length. Counted directly at $t = 5$: zero 3-cycles, 256 four-cycles, zero at five, six and seven, 1024 eight-cycles. The fitted models, meanwhile, expect 8.3 triangles, 42 five-cycles and 104 six-cycles under the plain fit, and 40, 668 and 2994 under the degree-corrected one, at lengths where the lattice contains nothing whatever.

So the failure is not that the numbers are too small. It is that a two-variable model places mass at every length while a locally grown lattice places it at a few, and no adjustment of blocks or degrees can move a smooth profile onto a sparse set of lengths. This is a stronger statement than the triangle deficit, and it is the one that argues for the guess: what a higher-order object buys is not a bigger number but the ability to have a shape.

The pseudofractal makes the same point from the other side. Its degree-corrected fit does not merely undercount; it *changes sign* — overshooting at every length at accessible sizes, by a factor of 3.5 at $L = 3$ and $2 \times 10^4$ at $L = 8$ for $t = 5$, and only crossing over to undercounting at $L = 3$ past $n \sim 10^8$. The reason is now visible in Eq. (8.4): the leading eigenvalue of a degree-corrected fit is essentially $\langle k^2 - k \rangle / \langle k \rangle$, so its spectrum grows like that ratio raised to the length, and for a degree distribution $p(k) \sim k^{-\gamma}$,

$$\lambda \;\sim\; n^{(3-\gamma)/(\gamma-1)} \quad (\gamma < 3), \qquad \lambda \sim \ln n \quad (\gamma = 3). \tag{8.5}$$

For the pseudofractal, $\gamma \simeq 2.585$ gives the exponent 0.2619, which is exactly the growth its transfer matrix shows; for the diamond, $\gamma = 3$ gives the logarithm and $Q/S = t$. One quantity therefore governs both earlier results: the deficit at length $L$ is of order $n/\lambda^L$, undercounting while $\lambda^L < n$ and overcounting after. The rank-one part does not describe higher-order structure at any length. It manufactures a geometric series and happens to cross the truth once.

## 8.2 What the crossing point does on real networks

The crossing is a prediction, and a falsifiable one. Eq. (8.5) places it at $L^* = (\gamma - 1)/(3 - \gamma)$, near 4 for the pseudofractal and receding to infinity as $\gamma \to 3$; equivalently, and without assuming the degree

exponent, at $L^* = \ln n / \ln \lambda$. Either way the deficit should be $n/\lambda^L$, so that $\ln(\text{true}_L/\text{predicted}_L)$ falls linearly in $L$ with slope exactly $-\ln\lambda$. That was tested on 44 real networks, with cycles counted exactly at $L = 3 \ldots 8$ and each fitted model represented by a sample from it — a rewiring that preserves the degrees, and one that preserves the degrees and the fitted block matrix both — rather than by the formula, which counts closed walks and agrees with the cycle count only asymptotically.

Half of the prediction came back confirmed, and it is the half that matters most for the argument. A fitted model's own motif spectrum really is generated by its transfer matrix: on the larger networks the sampled counts sit on $\lambda^L/2L$ to within one per cent at every length (Figure 8.1a). Eq. (8.4) is not an approximation that degrades, and the argument of this section stands on it.

The crossing itself does not survive. Real networks carry many more cycles than their rewirings at *every* length alike — five times more at the median, and four thousand times more for a large co-purchase network — and the excess barely decays: the measured slope is about a tenth of $-\ln\lambda$, thirty-nine of the forty-two networks depart from the predicted slope by more than two standard errors, and five have the excess growing with $L$ rather than shrinking (Figure 8.1b). The deficit is a level, not a slope.

The reason is visible once stated. The lattices' motif counts are extensive and *flat* in $L$ — exactly $n-2$ triangles, exactly $4^{t-1}$ four-cycles — so dividing by a geometric profile leaves a geometric deficit and a crossing. Real networks' cycle counts grow with $L$ at very nearly the rate their rewirings do. The crossing is a property of the deterministic webs, not of networks, and the $L^*$ formula should be read as a statement about them.

Two further cautions came out of the same measurement. The crossing is barely observable in principle: it needs $\lambda^3 < n < \lambda^8$, which for a scale-free degree distribution forces $\gamma \gtrsim 2.5$, and of 163 network families only 20 have any member inside the window at all — for most real networks the model overcounts at every length one can count. And the scaling Eq. (8.5) that converts $\ln n/\ln\lambda$ into $(\gamma-1)/(3-\gamma)$ is not supported: regressing $\ln\lambda$ on $\ln n$ within bands of similar $\gamma$ recovers the predicted exponent in one band of three and misses in the other two, in opposite directions.

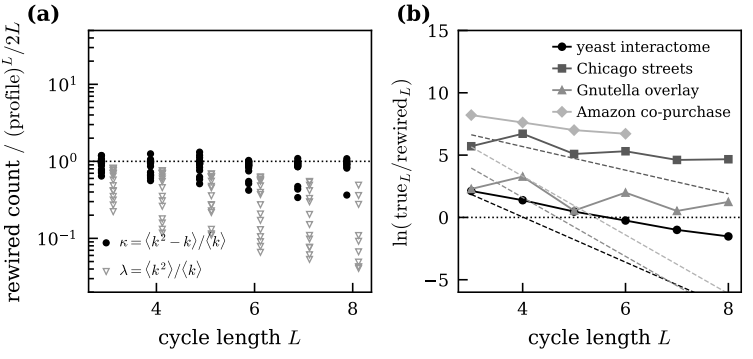



Figure 8.1: The two halves of the prediction, on real networks. **(a)** A degree-preserving rewiring's own cycle counts, divided by the geometric profile its transfer matrix predicts. With the excess-degree branching factor $\langle k^2 - k\rangle / \langle k\rangle$ the ratio sits on 1 at every length; with $\langle k^2\rangle / \langle k\rangle$ it drifts away by an order of magnitude. **(b)** The deficit $\ln(\text{true}_L / \text{rewired}_L)$ for four systems, against the line of slope $-\ln\lambda$ through $L^* = \ln n / \ln\lambda$ that Eq. (8.5) predicts (dashed). The measured curves are large and nearly flat.

None of this touches the support argument, which the same measurement instead strengthened by finding a real network with the diamond's pathology. Fullerenes are molecules, and their cycle spectra are exactly 12 five-cycles and $n/2 - 10$ six-cycles and *nothing at any other length* — twelve pentagons at every size, which is Euler's theorem. Both fitted models put positive mass everywhere: for $C_{6000}$, five triangles, forty-three four-cycles, twenty-seven seven-cycles. There the deficit is not fivefold or four thousandfold, it is infinite in both directions, and no choice of blocks or degrees can repair it.

## 8.3 An arity that can be measured

The guess that a higher-arity kernel is what is needed sets the order by the arity of the rule, and so far that has been an argument

from two lattices. It can be made quantitative, because the cycle spectrum of a real network is already known to be generated by a local quantity of arity three. Write $p_k$ for the degree distribution — the fraction of nodes having degree $k$ — and $c_k$ for the clustering coefficient of a node of degree $k$, the fraction of its neighbour pairs that are themselves linked. Then the number of $h$-cycles through a node of that degree is (Vazquez et al., 2005)

$$\frac{N_h}{n} \;=\; g_h \sum_k p_k \, \frac{(h-1)!}{2} \binom{k}{h-1} c_k^{\,h-2}, \tag{8.6}$$

with $N_h$ the number of $h$-cycles and $g_h$ a correction for multiple counting: choose $h-1$ neighbours of a central node, order them, and close the cycle by requiring $h-2$ links among consecutive ones, each present with probability $c_k$. The degree distribution and one three-point quantity fix the count at *every* length, and the measurement holds at $h = 3, 4, 5$ across co-authorship, the Internet and a semantic network (Vazquez et al., 2005).

This settles a question the transfer matrix leaves open. The tower of longer cycles needs no mechanism of its own: it is the product $c_k^{\,h-2}$, the same closing probability applied $h-2$ times around the loop. Arity three buys not just the triangle but the whole spectrum built from triangles. For a great many real networks, triangles do the job.

They cannot do it for a network that has no triangles. There $c_k = 0$ identically, Eq. (8.6) vanishes at every $h \geq 3$, and the failure is not an underestimate but an empty prediction — against a network that is full of cycles. The book's own duplication–split rule is exactly that case, built so that duplication makes no triangles and splitting destroys any that might form, with the square as its motif. Counting $DS(n, 1/3)$ directly at $n = 2000$: no triangles at all, and then $1.1 \times 10^4$ squares, $7.9 \times 10^3$ five-cycles and $1.3 \times 10^7$ eight-cycles. Nothing about the network is short of cycles; the arity-three generator simply cannot see any of them.

So the order required is set by the shortest cycle the rule closes, and it is measurable rather than postulated. The bubble family makes the point a dial, since $BB(n, L)$ closes a fresh cycle of length $L + 2$ at every step:

| model | motif | $c$ | cycle lengths present, $L = 3 \dots 10$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| $BB(n, 1)$ | triangle | 0.74 | every length |
| $BB(n, 2)$ | square | 0 | $4, 6, 8, 10$ |
| $BB(n, 3)$ | pentagon | 0 | $5, 8$ |
| $BB(n, 4)$ | hexagon | 0 | $6, 10$ |

Only the first is within reach of Eq. (8.6). The others place their mass exactly where the motif and its gluings put it: two faces sharing a link close a cycle of length $a + b - 2$, so pentagons give 5 and 8, hexagons 6 and 10, and everything else is empty. That is the same arithmetic the fullerenes obey — twelve pentagons and $n/2 - 10$ hexagons at any size, then 60 nine-cycles and $3n/2 - 60$ ten-cycles, with seven and eight empty because no two pentagons touch. A molecule and a growth rule, agreeing on a rule about which templates may be adjacent.

## 8.4 Fitting the order, not assuming it

All of that still asks the reader to accept the arity of each rule as given. It can instead be *inferred*, by the same criterion that fits a block model in the first place: minimum description length. The posterior of Section 7.2 is *microcanonical* — it fixes the link counts exactly rather than only on average, so that a model is a set of constraints and the description length counts the networks satisfying them — and $\Sigma = -\log_2 P(A, e, b)$ makes no use of the fact that links join two nodes. Nothing stops us handing it a model built from something else.

**The mathematics behind it: an alphabet of motifs, priced**
*(this box can be skipped)*

The obvious something else — a block model over 4-sets, its count matrix replaced by a four-index tensor — is the wrong choice, and Section 7.9 has already priced it: a $j$-index tensor drops the resolution to $B_{\max} \approx [m(j-1)!/\ln m]^{1/j}$, which at $j = 4$ is $n^{1/4}$, eighteen groups where the pair model recovers three hundred and sixteen. A model that can no longer see communities is a poor instrument for asking what communities are made of.

The affordable object keeps the ordinary block structure and changes what the blocks are built from. Every link is assigned to exactly one *motif instance* drawn from a small alphabet — a link, a triangle, a square — with motifs of arity three and above planted inside a single block, and instances wired by *stub matching*: each node is given a number of loose link-ends, or stubs, and the ends are then paired off at random, so that a node's share of the motifs is fixed by how many stubs it was given. That generative recipe is Karrer and Newman's subgraph configuration model (2010), run inside blocks. Planting $c$ copies of a motif that spans $s$ nodes inside one block can be done in

$$\Omega \;=\; \frac{(sc)!}{\prod_i d_i!\; c!\; a^c} \tag{8.7}$$

ways, where $d_i$ is how many of them node $i$ takes part in and $a$ is the size of the motif's automorphism group — the number of relabellings of its own nodes that leave it unchanged, which is 2 for a link, 6 for a triangle and 8 for a square. Dividing by $a^c$ is what stops the same motif being counted once for each way of writing it down. $\Sigma$ is then the sum of $\log_2 \Omega$ over the blocks together with the cost of the partition and of the counts. The parameters number one count per motif type per block plus the block matrix, $3B + B^2$ for the alphabet used here, rather than the $B^4/24$ of the tensor, so the resolution ceiling stays at Eq. (7.8)'s. The price is that a triangle straddling two blocks is not representable and is described as three links instead.

Two features make this a test rather than a fitting exercise. With the alphabet reduced to the link alone, $\Sigma$ is exactly the description length of the ordinary degree-corrected model, so enlarging the alphabet is a strictly nested comparison and a negative $\Delta\Sigma$ means the motifs paid for themselves. And the criterion can tell a planted triangle from three incidental links, because $c$ planted triangles are more constrained — hence cheaper to specify — than the $3c$ independent links they account for, while the extra counts cost only a little. Where triangles are unavoidable rather than planted the arithmetic goes the other way, and on a nine-node graph carrying 26 of its 36 possible links the criterion correctly plants none at all.

Run against the networks whose construction is known exactly, it recovers the rule:

| network | $n$ | $\Delta\Sigma$ (bits) | selected |
|---|---|---|---|
| pseudofractal, $t = 5$ | 366 | $-398$ | triangle |
| $BB(n, 1)$, Dorogovtsev–Mendes | 500 | $-259$ | triangle |
| diamond, $t = 5$ | 684 | $-1032$ | square |
| $DS(n, 1/3)$ | 500 | $-39$ | square |
| $BB(n, 2)$ | 500 | $-204$ | square |
| $BB(n, 3)$, pentagons | 500 | $+21$ | none |
| $BB(n, 4)$, hexagons | 502 | $+19$ | none |
| fullerene $C_{240}$ | 240 | $+17$ | none |

The last three rows are the ones that matter. Their motifs lie outside the alphabet, and there the enlarged model costs bits and buys nothing — the $+17$ is precisely the price of announcing two totals that turn out to be zero. It does not offer a square when the network was built from pentagons. A planted network with triangles in one community and squares in another is recovered with both, each in its own block; and the diamond at $t = 4$ is decomposed into exactly $64 = 4^{t-1}$ squares, the number it actually contains.

Two cautions. The decomposition assigns each link to one instance, so motifs that overlap cannot all be represented: the pseudofractal holds $n - 2$ triangles but at most a third of its links' worth are disjoint, and 138 were found. The selection is meaningful; the counts are not estimates. And the search is greedy in two coupled directions at once, which can trap it — on the diamond, the branch cut of Chapter 6 places *every* four-cycle across the cut, so from that partition the model finds no motif at all, and only a different starting partition reveals them.

So Question 2 has an answer for grown networks, if not yet for observed ones. A three-variable object pays for itself where the rule closes triangles, a four-variable one where it closes squares, and neither pays where the rule closes something longer — which is the arity guess's own statement, arrived at by measurement rather than by assumption. What remains is to run the same comparison on real networks, where the expectation from everything above is modest: the two-variable failure there is a large and nearly constant factor rather than a growing one, and arity three already accounts for the cycle spectrum wherever triangles exist.

## 8.5 What naming a motif does

The model of the last section is a community detection method, so it can be put to Chapter 6's two questions — when do communities appear, and how many are there — and the answers are not the same ones.

Recall that the Ramsey community number is defined relative to a method, and that Chapter 6 laboured that point without being able to demonstrate it. Here it can be demonstrated, because the three methods compared below differ in exactly one respect and are otherwise the same procedure.

**The mathematics behind it: the three methods, and what separates them** *(this box can be skipped)*

All three minimize the same description length,

$$\Sigma \;=\; -\log_2 P(A\,|\,\text{model}) \;-\; \log_2 P(\text{model}), \tag{8.8}$$

the bits needed to transmit the network together with the model used to compress it, and all three infer the number of communities rather than being told it. All three are also *degree-corrected* in the sense of Eq. (7.1): each node carries its own propensity to link, so that a hub and a leaf can sit in the same community without the fit having to separate them on degree alone. Chapter 6 showed why that matters — the degree-blind fit cuts the pseudofractal into hubs and leaves rather than into branches. With that held fixed, the three differ only in what the model is permitted to say.

*Flat block model.* Blocks, and a $B \times B$ matrix of link counts between them under an uninformative prior. Describing that matrix costs about $\frac{1}{2}B^2 \log_2 m$ bits for a network of $m$ links, which is what caps the recoverable groups at $B_{\max} \propto \sqrt{n}$. This is the method of Chapter 6.

*Nested block model.* The same, except that the matrix of link counts is itself described by a block model, and that one by another, in a hierarchy. The cost of the top-level description falls away and the ceiling rises to $B_{\max} \propto n/\log n$ (Peixoto, 2014b).

*Nested + motifs.* The nested model, with every link additionally assigned to one motif instance — a link, a triangle or a square — as in Eq. (8.7). With the alphabet reduced to the link alone this is exactly the nested model, so the comparison is strictly nested and $\Delta\Sigma < 0$ means the motifs paid for themselves.

> The first two differ in resolving power and nothing else; the second and third differ in vocabulary and nothing else. So a change between the first two is about how finely a method can see, and a change between the last two is about what it is willing to call a community.

Growing local search and duplication–split with the same generators, and fitting every realisation all three ways, gives, at $\epsilon = 0.05$ and a hundred realisations per size:

| | flat | nested | + motifs | published |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $LS(n, 1)$ | 70 | 80 | **200** | 81 |
| $DS(n, 0.5)$ | 90 | 100 | **100** | 98 |

The two block-model columns bracket the published numbers without quite reproducing them, and the gap is worth a word, since the flat column is supposed to be Chapter 6's own method. It is the same method in the sense that matters — a degree-corrected block model, its number of groups inferred by description length — but that names a family of procedures rather than one. The published figures come from a separate implementation (Vazquez, 2025); the fit is a stochastic search whose answer depends on how many restarts it is given and on the version of the library doing it; $P_\kappa$ is estimated from a hundred realisations; and $r_\kappa$ can only land on one of the sizes actually grown, here $\ldots 70, 80, 90, 100 \ldots$, so both published values fall one step above the flat column. Agreement to a grid step is the check that this is the same measurement. Equality was never on offer, and the columns to compare against each other are the three measured here, which do share an implementation.

The motif alphabet then moves one of them and not the other. Local search *is* the triadic-closure rule, so its local structure is triangles; an alphabet that contains the triangle books that structure as planted motifs instead of reading it as evidence for communities, and the size at which communities become certain is pushed from 80 to 200. Duplication–split makes no triangles at all, its squares overlap heavily and compress little, and its Ramsey number does not move (Figure 8.2).

What the same comparison does to the *number* of communities is a question about resolution rather than vocabulary, and the answer is that the alphabet barely touches it. Fitted with motifs, the number

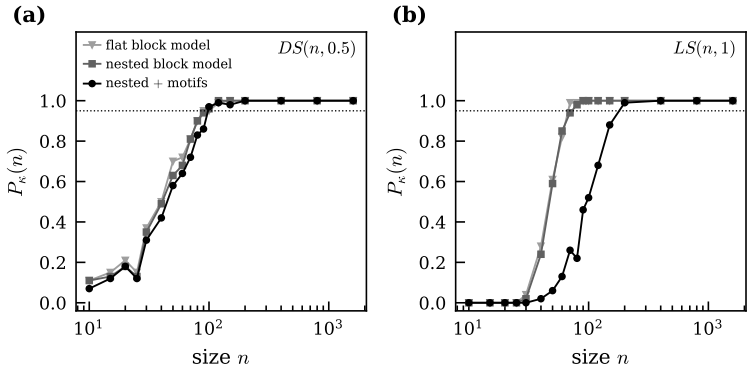



Figure 8.2: **The detection method is part of the answer.** Every panel compares three methods on identical networks: a flat block model, a nested one, and the nested one with triangles and squares in its alphabet. **(a)** duplication–split, **(b)** local search. The communities likelihood $P_\kappa(n)$, from a hundred networks at each size up to $n = 200$ and twenty above it, with the dotted line at the 95% threshold whose crossing defines the Ramsey community number. Duplication–split makes no triangles and the three curves lie on top of one another; local search *is* the triadic-closure rule, and naming its triangles moves the crossing from 80 to 200. How many communities each method finds, rather than whether it finds any, is a matter of resolution rather than vocabulary and is shown in Figure 7.4.

of communities grows with the same exponent the nested model gives on its own, close enough that plotting the two series together would show one curve; that is why Figure 7.4 carries only the two block models, and the comparison is made numerically in Section 8.8 instead.

## 8.6 What the square does not buy

Local search and duplication–split differ in whether the alphabet can name their motif, but neither is a clean test of the square,

and for opposite reasons. Duplication–split closes squares and then *subdivides* them: its split step replaces a link by a path of two, turning a cycle of length $L$ into one of length $L+1$ and destroying the parity, so its cycle counts are non-zero at every length from four upward. The bubble rule $BB(n, 2)$ closes squares and leaves them alone. And there is a third rule, closer to biology than either, that closes squares in profusion and yet defeats the alphabet completely.

That rule is duplication with divergence, $DD(n, q)$: copy a random node, then delete each copied link independently with probability $q$ — $q$ being the divergence, the chance that a redundant link is *lost*, as in Chapter 4. It never subdivides anything, so unlike duplication–split it stays bipartite, a copy sitting on the same side of the division as its original. Counted directly at $q = \frac{1}{2}$:

| | number of cycles of length $L$ | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $DD(n, \frac{1}{2})$ | $L = 3$ | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 |
| $n = 100$ | 0 | 694 | 0 | 9 099 | 0 | 123 001 |
| $n = 200$ | 0 | 3 658 | 0 | 143 822 | 0 | 7 002 135 |

Mass at the even lengths and exactly nothing at the odd ones — the same support as the diamond lattice and $BB(n, 2)$. By the reading of Section 8.3 this is a square-built network if ever there was one.

The motif model declines to plant a single square in it. Fitted at $q$ from 0.2 to 0.6 the enlarged alphabet buys nothing: it costs a few tens of bits on average, and the scatter between repeated fits of the same network is larger than the cost, so the only thing the number says is that nothing was gained. The reason is that duplication does not make a square. It makes a node with $d$ shared neighbours — a complete bipartite $K_{2,d}$ — holding $\binom{d}{2}$ four-cycles laid over one another. At $n = 200$ and $q = \frac{1}{2}$ the sharing runs to fourteen common neighbours between one pair of nodes, so that pair alone accounts for 91 four-cycles, and across the network each link sits in some twenty-four of them. A decomposition that gives every link to exactly one motif can name a handful and must leave the rest unspoken. In $BB(n, 2)$, where each step closes a fresh square on two new nodes, a link sits in 1.3 of them and the alphabet takes them up readily.

The consequences for community detection run in opposite directions (Figure 8.3). For $DD(n, q)$ the alphabet does nothing, the

three curves lie on top of one another, and the Ramsey community number is 40 whichever method is used. For $BB(n, 2)$ the alphabet works, and naming the squares dissolves the apparent communities altogether. Both block models put its Ramsey community number at 400; the motif model never reaches the 95% threshold at all. Its likelihood peaks near 0.65 around $n = 1600$ and then falls away — 0.20 at 3200, and at 6400 every one of ten realisations returns a single community while the block model returns a hundred and two.

Pushed to larger sizes, though, that second statement turns into something more awkward than a suppression. The motif model's answer for $BB(n, 2)$ is not small, it is *bimodal*. At $n = 3200$, sixteen realisations in twenty return a single community and the other four return between thirty-five and forty-one, which is what the block model returns throughout. The two outcomes are not a good answer and a bad one. Averaged over the twenty realisations they differ in description length by eleven bits in fifty-one thousand:

| $BB(n{=}3200, 2)$ | squares planted | $\Sigma$ (bits) |
|---|---|---|
| one community | 686 of 1200 | 51 663 |
| many communities | 414 of 1200 | 51 652 |

One description plants many squares and needs no communities at all; the other finds the communities and plants fewer squares; and the criterion is indifferent between them to a part in five thousand. Which one comes back is settled by where the search happens to start. So the squares and the communities are not competing hypotheses that the description length adjudicates — they are two ways of spending the same bits on the same links, and for this rule they cost the same. That is also why $BB(n, 2)$ carries no motif-model exponent in the table of Section 8.8: its mean is the mixing ratio of two outcomes rather than a law, and it turns over at $n = 3200$ for that reason and no other — as does its likelihood in Figure 8.3a, which is the same mixture seen from the other side.

The caution generalises past this one rule. Wherever an alphabet can absorb the same links that a partition would have explained, the two descriptions trade off against each other, and minimum description length has no reason to prefer either — which is a limit on what any such method can be asked to settle, and not a defect of this implementation.

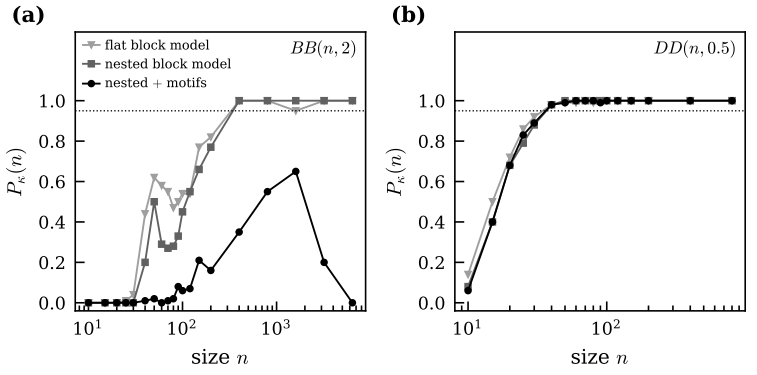



Figure 8.3: **Two rules built from squares, and only one of them says so.** Panels as in Figure 8.2: $P_\kappa$ from a hundred networks at each size up to $n = 200$ and twenty above it. **(a)** $BB(n, 2)$ closes one square per step on two new nodes, so its squares are nearly disjoint, the alphabet takes them up, and the communities the block model reports are largely dissolved. **(b)** $DD(n, q)$ at $q = \frac{1}{2}$ closes squares in far greater numbers, but as overlapping $K_{2,d}$ bicliques rather than separable motifs; the alphabet plants none of them, and all three methods agree.

Adding self-interaction does not rescue it. The duplication rule of Chapter 4 allows the copy to bind its own original with some probability $p$, and since the pair already shares neighbours, every such link closes triangles. At $p = 0.1$ and $q = 0.45$ the network is no longer bipartite, the odd cycle lengths fill in, and the clustering coefficient rises from zero to about 0.18 and stays there as the network grows — the interactome-like behaviour that motivated the rule. The alphabet still plants nothing: at $n = 100$, 200 and 400 the enlarged model costs bits rather than saving them. The triangles stack exactly as the squares did, all of those at a duplicated pair sharing the one link between the pair, so that a single link can carry eleven of them and an edge-disjoint decomposition can name at most one per pair. Duplication defeats the alphabet whether or not it makes triangles, because everything it builds is piled onto the same

shared neighbourhood.

So the alphabet needs more than the right arity. It needs the rule's footprint to be a fixed object that can be named once and counted. Duplication's footprint is a biclique whose size is set by how much of the copied neighbourhood survives, and the square is only its smallest case. That is a third way for the scheme to fail — distinct from a motif outside the alphabet, as with the pentagon-built rules, and from a motif spoiled by subdivision, as with duplication–split — and it is the one most likely to matter, since duplication with divergence is the standard account of how protein interaction networks grow. It is also, as the next section shows, not quite the right diagnosis.

## 8.7 The vocabulary was not the problem

The previous section blamed the alphabet for lacking a symbol. That is a testable complaint, and the test is to supply the symbol.

Add the biclique $K_{2,d}$: two hubs joined to the same $d$ leaves, $d+2$ nodes and $2d$ links. Its automorphism group has size $|\mathrm{Aut}| = 2\,d!$ — the count of relabellings of the motif's own nodes that leave it looking identical, which is what Eq. (8.7) divides by so that one planted copy is charged once rather than once per way of writing it down. Here the two hubs may swap, giving the factor of two, and the $d$ leaves permute freely among themselves, giving the $d!$. It is exactly what duplication builds, and $d = 2$ is the square, so the family starts at $d = 3$. Each $d$ is its own symbol rather than one symbol of variable size, which leaves the pool arithmetic of Eq. (8.7) untouched and makes a fit that reaches for many different $d$ pay to announce each of them.

On a network of planted bicliques it does what it should. Twenty disjoint $K_{2,6}$, which is 240 links:

| alphabet | $\Sigma$ (bits) | planted |
|---|---|---|
| link only | 1820 | — |
| + triangle, square | 1415 | 60 squares |
| + biclique | **1028** | 20 $K_{2,6}$ |

The square alphabet carves each biclique into three disjoint squares and pays 387 bits more than naming it once. (Bicliques have to be

offered before squares, or the squares consume the links first and the larger object can never be seen — a reminder that a greedy search over a nested vocabulary must work from the largest symbol down.)

Now duplication–divergence, with everything in one block. The model finds 760 biclique candidates in $DD(n{=}200, q{=}\frac{1}{2})$ and plants twenty-four of them, two as large as $K_{2,14}$, taking $\Sigma$ from 3711 to 3458: a saving of 252 bits where the square alphabet saved nothing at all. The vocabulary was not the problem. Given the symbol, the model names the structure and profits by it.

What defeats it is the partition. Refit the same network with the block model's own division into eleven groups, and the number of biclique candidates is *zero*. Not few — none. Every duplicated pair has been separated from its shared neighbours by a block boundary, and a motif that straddles a boundary is not representable at all.

That is a more damaging limitation than the one the last section named, and it is self-inflicted. The restriction of motifs to the inside of a single block is what kept the parameter count at $3B + B^2$ rather than the $B^4/24$ of a tensor, and so kept the resolution at $\sqrt{n}$ instead of $n^{1/4}$ (Section 8.4). The saving is real. It also happens to break the scheme on the one rule that most needs it, because duplication puts a copy and its original in different groups — they have the same neighbours but need not be joined to each other, which is exactly the configuration a block model splits.

Worse, the two descriptions cannot be combined. One block with the bicliques named costs 3458 bits; eleven groups with nothing named costs 3163; and there is no fit that has both, because choosing the groups destroys the motifs. The block structure wins by some three hundred bits, so the model reports communities and no motifs, which is what Figure 8.3 shows — but it reports them by default rather than by preference, having been given no option that keeps the duplication visible.

A last caution, which applies to every $\Delta\Sigma$ quoted in these sections. The fit is a stochastic search, and repeated fits of the *same* network return description lengths that differ. For $DD(n, q)$ at $n = 400$ the spread over five fits is around 150 bits, larger than most of the differences being compared. Where a sign is reported here it is the sign of an average, and the small numbers should be read as saying that nothing was gained rather than as measurements of how much

was lost.

## 8.8 Which change moves which number

Three methods have been compared through these sections, and they differ in two ways rather than one. Flat against nested is a difference of resolving power and nothing else; nested against nested-with-motifs is a difference of vocabulary and nothing else (Section 8.4). Setting the results side by side, the two differences turn out to move two different quantities, and each leaves the other alone.

Where the first difference comes from was the subject of Chapter 7, and was priced there exactly: the two models express the same partitions and differ only in what naming one costs, the flat model paying a charge quadratic in the number of groups and so meeting Eq. (7.8)'s ceiling of $\sqrt{n}$, the nested model compressing the group-level structure instead and reaching Eq. (7.9)'s $n/\log n$. Nothing in that arithmetic mentions what the links are made of, which is the first half of why the vocabulary leaves the exponent alone.

| | $\beta$, growth of $\kappa$ | | | change | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | flat | nested | +motifs | nested−flat | motifs−nested |
| $LS(n, 1)$ | 0.54 | 0.94 | 1.04 | +0.40 | +0.11 |
| $DS(n, 0.5)$ | 0.76 | 1.02 | 1.01 | +0.26 | −0.01 |
| $DD(n, 0.5)$ | 0.78 | 1.12 | 1.11 | +0.34 | −0.01 |
| | $r_\kappa$, onset of communities | | | ratio | |
| $LS(n, 1)$ | 70 | 80 | 200 | 1.14 | 2.50 |
| $DS(n, 0.5)$ | 90 | 100 | 100 | 1.11 | 1.00 |
| $DD(n, 0.5)$ | 40 | 40 | 40 | 1.00 | 1.00 |

Lifting the resolution moves the exponent by two to four tenths every time, and moves the onset by at most a seventh. Changing the vocabulary moves the exponent by a hundredth — excepting local search, where the alphabet does match the rule — and moves the onset by a factor of two and a half where the alphabet contains the rule's own motif, and not at all where it does not. ($BB(n, 2)$ is left out of the table because its motif-model $\kappa$ is bimodal and its mean is not an exponent; on the other measure it is the extreme case, its onset going from 400 to never.)

The reason is not mysterious once separated. The exponent is a statement about how finely a network can be cut, and nothing about the vocabulary for describing links changes how many groups a method is able to resolve — that is fixed by what the description length charges for the block structure, $\sqrt{n}$ for the flat model against $n/\log n$ for the nested one. The Ramsey number is a statement about whether there is evidence to cut at all, and that does depend on the vocabulary, because a method that can name a triangle has an innocent explanation available for clustering that a method without one does not. Two knobs, two numbers, and each knob turns its own.

This tidies up the uncomfortable conclusion of Section 8.5. The claim there was that Chapter 6's exponent is in part a statement about the flat block model rather than about the networks, and it can now be said without reference to motifs at all. The motif alphabet is irrelevant to $\beta$; the whole of the shift is the nested model, which is a standard tool and not one invented here. Whatever else is uncertain about the machinery of the last four sections, that conclusion does not rest on it.

It also settles the question the last chapter left at its door. What Chapter 7 found was a density: with the resolution lifted, the number of communities grows in proportion to the size, so the density $b = B/n$ becomes a number a network has rather than a rate at which something grows. The obvious worry about such a quantity is that it might be an artefact of a poor vocabulary — that a model forced to describe every triangle as three separate links would invent communities to absorb what it could not name, and that a richer alphabet would dissolve them. It does not. Give the model triangles, squares and bicliques and the density stays where the nested prior put it, to a hundredth in $\beta$ on every rule where the comparison is clean. The density survives the one attack this chapter knows how to mount on it.

Two instrument effects have now been found and separated, and it is worth noticing that they were found the same way. Chapter 6's 0.61 became 0.80 when the prior stopped charging quadratically for groups, and 0.80 became 1 when the sample stopped mixing grown networks with catalogued ones. Neither move was about networks; both were found by changing one thing about the method

and watching which number moved. What this chapter adds is a negative of the same kind, and negatives of this kind are worth as much: the vocabulary was changed, and nothing moved.

# Chapter 9

# Boosting shortest path multiplicity

## 9.1 The redundancy of shortest paths

The small-world property, met back in the introduction, promises that any two nodes of a real network are joined by a *short* path — only a few hops apart. It says nothing, though, about how *many* short paths there are. That count turns out to matter a great deal. If the only shortest route between two nodes runs through a single chain of intermediaries, the connection is fragile: cut one link and the shortest route is gone. If instead there are several shortest routes side by side, the connection is robust, and whatever flows between the two nodes — a message, a signal, a delay — can travel along all of them at once. The quantity that captures this is the *shortest path multiplicity*: the number of distinct shortest routes between a pair of nodes. A simple picture: if two friends can each be reached from you in two handshakes, but by two completely different chains of acquaintances, the multiplicity of that connection is two. In real networks this multiplicity is conspicuously high.

And it is not an isolated fact. Deng et al. (2026) found that, across many real networks, the abundance of multiple shortest paths is strongly correlated with *community structure* — the very groupings of the previous chapter — more strongly than with any other

standard measure. Two networks of the same size and the same degree distribution can differ widely in their path multiplicity, and the difference tracks how community-rich they are. A correlation like that begs for an explanation. Does community structure somehow *cause* paths to multiply, or do both spring from a common deeper source? The previous chapter hands us the obvious suspect: local growth rules, which we saw conjure communities out of nothing but locality. This chapter, following Vazquez (2026b), completes the case by showing that those same local rules also *boost* the multiplicity of shortest paths — so that the striking link between paths and communities is not one causing the other, but the shared shadow cast by the rule that grew the network.

The mechanism is easy to picture once named. Local rules build short *cycles* — closed loops — as a matter of course: a triangle whenever a friend introduces a friend, a square whenever a gene is copied. And a cycle is exactly a structure that offers more than one way around. In a network with no loops at all — a *tree* — there is precisely one route between any two nodes; the more loops a network carries, the more alternative shortest routes it affords. Path multiplicity is simply what local rules leave behind when they close loops.

## 9.2 Defining the multiplicity

We need only one quantity. Write $\mu_{ij}(G)$ for the number of distinct shortest paths between nodes $i$ and $j$ in a network $G$ — counting every route that ties for the minimum number of hops. Averaging this over all pairs of nodes, and over many networks grown the same way, gives the *average shortest path multiplicity* $\langle \mu \rangle$, the single number we will follow as the network grows to size $n$. A tree, with its unique routes, has $\langle \mu \rangle = 1$ exactly; anything above one measures the redundancy that loops provide. The whole chapter is about one question: how fast does $\langle \mu \rangle$ rise as the network gets bigger, and does that rate betray whether the network was grown by a local rule?

Four growth rules will do all the work, and we have met them all before. Their definitions matter here more than they have so far, because we are about to compute their exponents, so let us state them exactly.

*Local search*, $LS(n, \ell)$, the search rule of Chapter 2 in undirected form. Start from two connected nodes. To add a node, pick an existing node at random, take an $\ell$-step random walk from it, and link the newcomer to every node the walk visited. It carries preferential attachment because the chance of being visited, beyond the entry node, is proportional to degree; and it makes at least one triangle at every step, between the entry point and the first neighbor visited. For $\ell = 1$ it *is* the triadic-closure rule of Chapter 3.

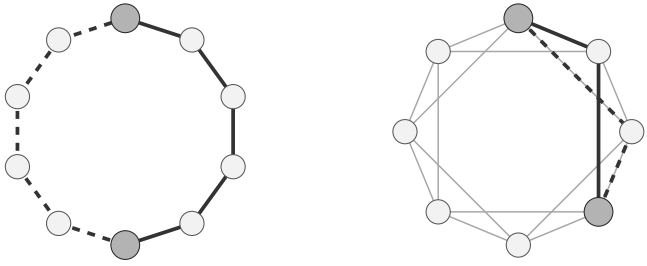
*Duplication–split*, $DS(n, q)$, the undirected cousin of the project rule of Chapter 5. Start from a cycle of four nodes, so that no node has degree below two and no cycle is shorter than four. To add a node $i$, pick an existing node $j$ at random. With probability $q$, make $i$ a duplicate of $j$, linking $i$ to every neighbor of $j$. Otherwise pick a random neighbor $k$ of $j$ and *split* the link: delete $(j, k)$ and create $(i, j)$ and $(i, k)$. It carries preferential attachment because the chance that a node has a neighbor duplicated is proportional to its degree. Duplication makes no triangles and splitting destroys any that might form; its motif is the square.

The *bubble* model, $BB(n, L)$. Start from a cycle of $L + 2$ nodes. At each step add a chain of $L$ new nodes and attach the two ends of the chain to the two ends of a randomly chosen existing link, closing a fresh cycle of length $L+2$. It carries preferential attachment because the chance of sitting at the end of the chosen link is proportional to degree. $BB(n, 1)$ is the Dorogovtsev–Mendes rule.

Against these we set the *Barabási–Albert* model $BA(n, m)$: start from a complete graph of $m+1$ nodes, and let every newcomer attach $m$ links to nodes chosen from the *whole* network with probability proportional to degree. It is our non-local control.

## 9.3 The simplest case: a ring

Before any of that, it is worth feeling the measure on the plainest network that has a loop at all — the same ring we broke into communities in the previous chapter. Place $n$ nodes on a circle, each joined to its two neighbors: the cycle $C_n$. Between any two nodes there are two ways round, and the shortest path is simply the shorter arc. Almost always one arc is strictly shorter than the other, so the shortest path is *unique* and $\mu_{ij} = 1$. The single exception is a pair



(a) cycle $C_n(1)$: $\mu = 2$ (b) ring $C_n(1,2)$: $\mu = 2$

Figure 9.1: **Multiplicity on a ring.** (a) On the plain cycle, the two arcs between antipodal nodes tie, so both are shortest ($\mu = 2$); every other pair has one arc strictly shorter, hence a unique shortest path. (b) On the next-nearest-neighbor ring, a step may cover one node or two, so for endpoints an odd number of steps apart there are several ways to combine the steps into a shortest path — here the two two-hop routes from one highlighted node to the other. Redundancy that was confined to the lone antipodal pair in (a) now appears for pair after pair.

of nodes exactly opposite each other on the circle: the two arcs then tie, and both are shortest, so $\mu_{ij} = 2$ (Figure 9.1).

Those antipodal pairs are rare — there are only about $n/2$ of them among the $\binom{n}{2}$ pairs in the ring — so averaging gives

$$\langle \mu \rangle = 1 + \frac{1}{n-1} \longrightarrow 1. \tag{9.1}$$

A plain ring, in other words, is barely more redundant than a tree. Its one loop buys a second route for exactly one pair of nodes, the two farthest apart, and for nobody else.

Give each node one more neighbor, though, and redundancy switches on (Figure 9.1b). In the ring $C_n(1,2)$, where every node also links to its second neighbors, a shortest path may step by one node or by two, and the freedom to mix those steps creates ties. Between two nodes $j$ steps apart, when $j$ is odd, there are exactly

$$\mu = \frac{j+1}{2} \tag{9.2}$$

shortest paths — one for each position of the lone single-step among the double-steps — while for even $j$ the all-doubles route is unique. The redundancy now *grows* with how far apart the endpoints are, instead of sitting at one, and the average multiplicity climbs with the size of the ring rather than creeping down to it.

That the two rings behave so differently comes down to a single number — the same one that decided their communities in the previous chapter. A connected network of $n$ nodes and $m$ links carries $m - n + 1$ independent cycles. The plain ring has $m = n$: one loop, and we have just seen it lifts the multiplicity by a mere $1/(n-1)$. The next-nearest ring has $m = 2n$, so $m - n = n$ — an *extensive* number of independent cycles — and its multiplicity grows in step. This is exactly the threshold at which Chapter 6 found the ring beginning to break into communities: there, too, a network split precisely when it carried more links than nodes. Both measures switch on together, at the same lever. Redundant routes, like community structure, need loops in extensive number — supplied here by a ring of longer reach, and in the rest of this chapter by growth rules that pile cycles up as the network grows.

## 9.4 The baseline: random networks

To judge what counts as "boosted," we first need the expectation in the *absence* of any local structure. The natural reference is a random network, and here we can do better than simulate — we can calculate. The answer is remarkably simple, and it turns on a single property of the degree distribution: the *average excess degree*

$$c_2 = \frac{\langle k(k-1)\rangle}{\langle k\rangle}, \tag{9.3}$$

which is the average number of *further* links you find when you arrive at a node by following one of its links — its degree, less the link you came in on. It is the natural branching factor of a network: from where you stand, $c_2$ is how many ways the path onward can continue.

The cleanest way to see where Eq. (9.3) comes from is to do the simplest case first — the classic random graph of Erdős and Rényi,

in which every one of the $\binom{n}{2}$ possible links is present with the same probability $p$ — and then repair it for a general degree distribution.

**The mathematics behind it: counting the shortest paths of a random graph** *(this box can be skipped)*

Write $c = np$ for the mean degree and $D = \ln n / \ln c$ for the typical distance between two nodes, and assume $c > 1$ so the graph is connected. Fix two nodes. A path of length $d$ between them uses $d-1$ intermediate nodes, in order, drawn from the remaining $n-2$, so the number of *candidate* paths is

$$m_d = (n-2)(n-3)\cdots(n-d) \approx n^{\,d-1} \tag{9.4}$$

for $d \ll n$. Each candidate is *realized* only if all $d$ of its links happen to be present, which has probability $p^d$; treating the candidates as independent, the number realized is binomial, with mean

$$\langle M_d \rangle = m_d\, p^d \approx \frac{(np)^d}{n} = c^{\,d-D}. \tag{9.5}$$

The shortest paths are those at the smallest $d$ for which any path exists at all, so we must weight $\langle M_d \rangle$ by the probability $F_{d-1}$ that nothing shorter exists:

$$\langle \mu \rangle = \sum_d \langle M_d \rangle\, F_{d-1}. \tag{9.6}$$

Since $\Pr(M_d = 0) = (1-p^d)^{m_d} \approx e^{-\langle M_d \rangle}$ for $p \ll 1$,

$$F_d = \prod_{k=1}^{d} \Pr(M_k = 0) = \exp\Big( -\sum_{k=1}^{d} \langle M_k \rangle \Big). \tag{9.7}$$

The sum in the exponent is a geometric series of ratio $c > 1$, so it is dominated by its last term, $\sum_{k \le d} \langle M_k \rangle \approx c^{\,d-D}$, and

$$F_d \approx \exp\big( -c^{\,d-D} \big). \tag{9.8}$$

Substituting Eqs. (9.5) and (9.8) into Eq. (9.6),

$$\langle \mu \rangle \approx \sum_d c^{\,d-D}\, \exp\big( -c^{\,d-D-1} \big). \tag{9.9}$$

The summand is the function $x e^{-x/c}$ evaluated along a geometric ladder: it climbs by a factor $c$ per hop while $d < D$, and is then cut

down super-exponentially. It therefore peaks sharply, one hop beyond the typical distance, at $d = D + 1$, and evaluating it there leaves

$$\langle \mu \rangle \approx \frac{c}{e} + O(1), \tag{9.10}$$

the $e$ being simply the value of $xe^{-x}$ at its maximum.

Equation (9.10) already tells us three things. If the graph is *sparse* — $c$ fixed as $n$ grows, which holds for every real network — the multiplicity is a *constant*. If it is *minimally connected*, $c = b \ln n$, the multiplicity grows as $(b/e) \ln n$. And if it is *dense*, $c \sim n$, it grows in proportion to $n$, recovering a result of Dong et al. (2025). But a real network is sparse *and* hub-dominated, and an Erdős–Rényi graph is neither. We need the same calculation for an arbitrary degree distribution.

**The mathematics behind it: the same count for any degree distribution** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let the degrees follow $\pi_k$, with mean $c_1 = \sum_k \pi_k k$ and excess degree $c_2 = \sum_k \pi_k k(k-1)/c_1$. (We write $\pi_k$ rather than $p_k$ here because $p$ is already the probability that a link exists.) The calculation runs exactly as before; only the probability that the next link exists changes.

Build a candidate path node by node. The first step is from a node picked at random to another node picked at random, which are linked with probability $p_1 = c_1/n$, with associated distance $D_1 = \ln n / \ln c_1$. Every step after the first is different, because we now stand at the *end of a link*, and a node reached by following a link is not a typical node: its degree is distributed as $k\pi_k/c_1$, and one of those links is the one we arrived on, leaving $k - 1$. The next node is picked at random and has degree $k'$ with probability $\pi_{k'}$; the chance the two are linked is $kk'/(nc_1)$, which on averaging over both gives

$$p_2 = \frac{c_2 c_1}{n c_1} = \frac{c_2}{n}, \qquad D_2 = \frac{\ln n}{\ln c_2}. \tag{9.11}$$

So a path of length $d$ costs one factor of $p_1$ and $d - 1$ factors of $p_2$, and Eqs. (9.5) and (9.8) become

$$\langle M_d \rangle \approx c_1 c_2^{d - D_2 - 1}, \qquad F_d \approx \exp\big( - c_1 c_2^{d - D_2 - 1} \big), \tag{9.12}$$

for $d > 1$. Substituting into Eq. (9.6),

$$\langle \mu \rangle \approx \sum_d c_1 c_2^{d-D_2-1} \exp\big( - c_1 c_2^{d-D_2-2} \big), \tag{9.13}$$

whose summand again peaks sharply, now where $c_1 c_2^{d-D_2-2} = 1$, leaving

$$\langle \mu \rangle \approx \frac{c_2}{e} + O(1). \tag{9.14}$$

For an Erdős–Rényi graph $c_2 = c_1 = c$ and we recover Eq. (9.10).

Equation (9.14) is the baseline, and it is worth pausing on how much it explains. The multiplicity of a random network is simply its branching factor, divided by $e$. The mean degree does not appear; the whole distribution of degrees enters through the single number $c_2$. And notice what happened between the two boxes: $c_1$ was replaced by $c_2$ everywhere it mattered, because after the first step a path is always standing at the end of a link, where the branching is the *excess* degree and not the degree.

Everything now hinges on how $c_2$ behaves as the network grows, and since $c_2$ involves $\langle k^2 \rangle$, that is a question about hubs.

**The mathematics behind it: how the excess degree grows with size** *(this box can be skipped)*

Take a scale-free network, $p(k) \sim k^{-\gamma}$. For $\gamma > 3$ the second moment $\langle k^2 \rangle$ converges, so $c_2$ tends to a constant and there is nothing to discuss. For $\gamma \leq 3$ it diverges, and the divergence is cut off only by the largest degree actually present. That largest degree follows from asking which $k$ is rare enough to appear about once in a network of $n$ nodes, $p(k_{\max}) = 1/n$:

$$k_{\max} \sim n^{1/\gamma}. \tag{9.15}$$

Now do the sum. For $\gamma = 3$ the summand $k^2 p(k) \sim 1/k$, so

$$c_2 \sim \sum_{k=1}^{k_{\max}} \frac{1}{k} \sim \ln k_{\max} \sim \ln n, \tag{9.16}$$

the logarithm of the size. For $2 < \gamma < 3$ the sum is dominated by its

upper end, $c_2 \sim k_{\max}^{3-\gamma}$, and using Eq. (9.15),

$$c_2 \sim n^{-1+3/\gamma}. \tag{9.17}$$

It is worth doing the $\gamma = 3$ case explicitly, since three of our models share it. There $p_k = A\,\Gamma(k)/\Gamma(3+k) = A/[(2+k)(1+k)k]$, so

$$\langle k \rangle \sim A \sum_{k\geq 2} \frac{1}{(2+k)(1+k)} = A \sum_{k\geq 2} \Big( \frac{1}{k+1} - \frac{1}{k+2} \Big) \sim \frac{A}{3}, \tag{9.18}$$

a telescoping sum that converges, while

$$\langle k^2 \rangle \sim A \sum_{k=1}^{k_{\max}} \frac{1}{k} \sim A \ln k_{\max} \sim \frac{A}{3} \ln n \tag{9.19}$$

does not. Their ratio is $c_2 \sim \ln n$, confirming Eq. (9.16).

Feeding the three cases into Eq. (9.14) gives the baseline in full:

$$\langle \mu \rangle = a, \qquad \gamma > 3, \tag{9.20}$$

$$\langle \mu \rangle = a + \tfrac{1}{e} \ln n, \qquad \gamma = 3, \tag{9.21}$$

$$\langle \mu \rangle = a + b\, n^{\alpha}, \qquad \alpha = \tfrac{3}{\gamma} - 1, \qquad 2 < \gamma < 3. \tag{9.22}$$

When $\gamma > 3$ the multiplicity *stops growing altogether*. At $\gamma = 3$ it creeps up like $\ln n$ — about as slow as growth gets, since to add a fixed amount you must *multiply* the size — and the predicted slope is not merely logarithmic but exactly $1/e$. Below $\gamma = 3$ the hubs are heavy enough to drive a genuine power law. So there is no single random baseline: the bar that a local rule must clear is set by the degree distribution it happens to produce, and we must compare like with like.

## 9.5 Which rule makes which exponent

That last sentence obliges us to know the exponent of every model in this chapter. Happily one calculation settles them all at once, because all four rules — and the shuffled versions we shall compare them against — attach in the same way: a node gains links at a rate that is affine in its degree.

**The mathematics behind it: one rate equation for every model** *(this box can be skipped)*

Let $n_k(n)$ be the expected number of nodes of degree $k$ once the network has grown to $n$ nodes. Suppose a node of degree $k$ gains a link at rate $(a+bk)/n$ — a constant part $a$ and a preferential part $b$ — and that the newcomer arrives either with degree 2, with probability $c$, or as a duplicate of an existing node, at rate $d/n$. Then

$$n_k(n+1) = n_k(n) + \frac{a+b(k-1)}{n}\, n_{k-1} - \frac{a+bk}{n}\, n_k + c\,\delta_{k2} + \frac{d}{n}\, n_k. \tag{9.23}$$

The first two terms are the traffic in and out of degree $k$; the last two account for the newcomer's own degree. This is mean field: the expectation after the step is computed from the expectations before it, ignoring the fluctuations of a single addition. Look for a steady state in which the shape of the distribution is fixed and only its size grows, $n_k(n) = n\,p_k$. Substituting and cancelling one power of $n$ gives a recursion in $k$ alone,

$$p_k = \frac{\eta + k - 1}{\nu + k}\, p_{k-1} + \frac{c}{b}\,\frac{1}{\nu+k}\,\delta_{k2}, \qquad \eta = \frac{a}{b}, \quad \nu = \frac{1+a-d}{b}, \tag{9.24}$$

which unrolls into a ratio of Gamma functions,

$$p_k = \frac{c}{b}\,\frac{\Gamma(2+\nu)}{\Gamma(2+\eta)}\,\frac{\Gamma(k+\eta)}{\Gamma(k+1+\nu)}. \tag{9.25}$$

(Check it by induction: it holds at $k=2$, and substituting $p_{k-1}$ from Eq. (9.25) into Eq. (9.24) returns $p_k$.) For $k \gg \max(\eta,\nu)$ the ratio of Gammas behaves as $k^{\eta-\nu-1}$, a power law $p_k \sim k^{-\gamma}$ with

$$\gamma = 1 + \frac{1-d}{b}. \tag{9.26}$$

Only two of the four constants survive: the preferential rate $b$, and the duplication rate $d$.

Equation (9.26) is a small master key. Read off each rule's constants and its exponent falls out.

For $BA(n,2)$ every newcomer brings two links and hands them

out in proportion to degree, so $a = 0$, $b = 1/2$, $c = 1$, $d = 0$, and

$$\gamma_{BA} = 3. \tag{9.27}$$

For $LS(n, \ell)$ the walk lands on the entry node uniformly, which is the constant part $a = 1$, and thereafter in proportion to degree, giving $b = \ell/\langle k \rangle = \ell/[2(\ell + 1)]$ with $c = 1$, $d = 0$, so that

$$\gamma_{LS} = \frac{3\ell + 2}{\ell}. \tag{9.28}$$

For $DS(n, q)$ duplication is the only source of preference, $b = q$, and it is also the only way the newcomer copies a degree, $d = q$, with $a = 0$ and $c = 1 - q$; then $\eta = 0$, $\nu = -1 + 1/q$ and

$$\gamma_{DS} = \frac{1}{q}. \tag{9.29}$$

For $BB(n, L)$ the chain's ends land on a random link, so $b = 2/\langle k \rangle = 1/(L + 1)$ with $a = 0$, $c = 1$, $d = 0$, $\eta = 0$, $\nu = L + 1$, and

$$\gamma_{BB} = L + 2. \tag{9.30}$$

Two coincidences in this list are worth having. First, $DS(n, q)$ and $BB(n, L)$ produce the *same* degree distribution whenever $q = (L + 2)^{-1}$ — so any difference in their multiplicity cannot be blamed on their degrees. Second, and this is what makes the comparisons of the next section fair, $DS(n, 1/3)$, $BB(n, 1)$ and $BA(n, 2)$ all sit at $\gamma = 3$: three rules, one degree distribution, and — as we are about to see — three quite different multiplicities.

And now the baseline can be made concrete. Take a network grown by a local rule and shuffle its links at random while leaving every node's degree untouched — the same configuration-model scramble used as a control in the previous chapter. The result keeps the degree distribution and destroys everything else; we mark it with a star. By Eq. (9.28) the randomized local-search network $LS(n, 1)^*$ has $\gamma = 5$, and so by Eq. (9.20) its multiplicity must *stop growing*; it duly flattens out (Figure 9.2a). By Eq. (9.29) the randomized $DS(n, 1/3)^*$ has $\gamma = 3$, and creeps up logarithmically, close to the predicted slope $1/e$ (Figure 9.2b). The randomized $DS(n, 2/5)^*$ has $\gamma = 5/2$, for which Eq. (9.22) predicts $\alpha = 3/\gamma - 1 = 1/5$, and it

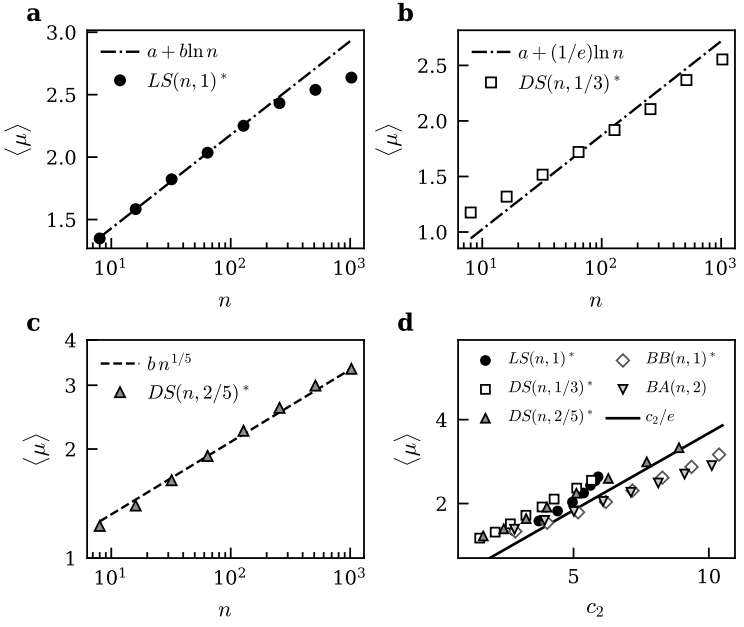



Figure 9.2: **The random baseline.** Average shortest path multiplicity $\langle \mu \rangle$ against network size $n$ for randomized networks (starred), which keep each node's degree but destroy all local structure. (a) $LS(n,1)^*$, degree exponent $\gamma = 5$: growth stalls, the points falling away from the fitted logarithm. (b) $DS(n,1/3)^*$, $\gamma = 3$: logarithmic, near the predicted slope $1/e$. (c) $DS(n,2/5)^*$, $\gamma = 5/2$: the predicted power law $n^{1/5}$. (d) All models, including the non-local $BA(n,2)$, plotted against the excess degree $c_2$ collapse onto the mean-field line $c_2/e$ of Eq. (9.14).

climbs as $n^{1/5}$ (Figure 9.2c). Plotted against $c_2$ rather than $n$, all of them — and the Barabási–Albert model with them — collapse onto the single mean-field line $c_2/e$ of Eq. (9.14) (Figure 9.2d). Three regimes, one formula, and no fitted parameter anywhere except the additive constants.

The Barabási–Albert model deserves its own note, because it is

a *growing* network yet lands squarely on the random baseline. With $m = 2$ it has $\gamma = 3$ by Eq. (9.27), and its multiplicity creeps up logarithmically, exactly as its reshuffled cousins do. It has no local structure to lose: its newcomers attach across the whole graph and never consult a neighborhood. This echoes the previous chapter, where the very same model failed to develop communities. Lacking locality, it builds neither the modules nor the redundant paths, and on both counts it behaves as though its links had been shuffled at random.

## 9.6 Local rules boost the multiplicity

Now run the same models *without* shuffling, and compare each against its own starred baseline (Figure 9.3). The multiplicity climbs decisively faster. It helps to keep a ladder of growth rates in mind: constant, then logarithmic, then *log-quadratic*, then *exponential* — each rung leaving the one below it far behind.

Most local rules — local search and the bubble model among them — sit on the log-quadratic rung,

$$\langle \mu \rangle = a + b \ln n + c(\ln n)^2, \tag{9.31}$$

the extra squared term bending the curve clearly upward. For $LS(n, 1)$ this is a particularly sharp contrast: the unshuffled network grows without limit while the shuffled one, with the very same degrees, stops growing altogether. Whatever is doing the work is not in the degree distribution at all.

The duplication–split rule is different, and dramatically so: its multiplicity grows *exponentially* with size,

$$\langle \mu \rangle = a\, e^{bn}, \qquad a, b > 0. \tag{9.32}$$

Exponential growth is a different world from logarithmic. Over the same range of sizes in which its shuffled counterpart moves from $\langle \mu \rangle \approx 1.2$ to 2.6, the unshuffled $DS(n, 1/3)$ runs from 1.3 to more than $10^5$: by a thousand nodes, a typical pair of nodes is joined by hundreds of thousands of equally short routes. Copying, it turns out, is the great multiplier of shortest paths, and that is what the title of this chapter names.

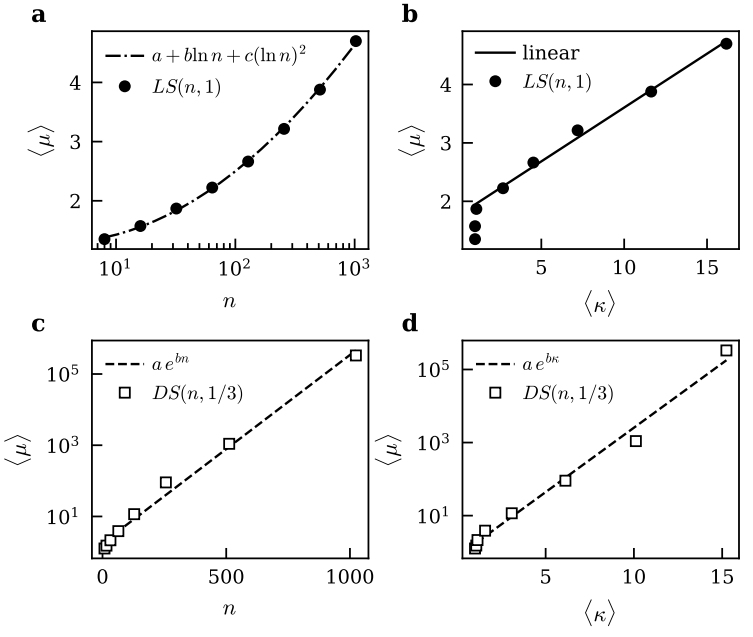
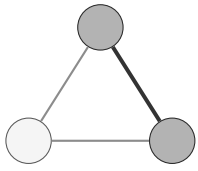


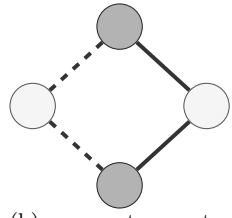

Figure 9.3: **Local rules boost the multiplicity.** (a) Local search $LS(n,1)$ grows log-quadratically, Eq. (9.31) — while its shuffled counterpart, with identical degrees, saturates (Figure 9.2a). (b) The same data against the inferred number of communities $\langle\kappa\rangle$: linear. (c) Duplication–split $DS(n,1/3)$ grows exponentially, Eq. (9.32); note the linear size axis and the logarithmic multiplicity axis, and that the vertical scale spans five decades. (d) Against $\langle\kappa\rangle$: exponential again. Communities are only detectable beyond the Ramsey size $r_\kappa$, so the leftmost points in (b) and (d) sit at $\langle\kappa\rangle = 1$.

## 9.7 Cycles and the boost

Why should duplication outrun the rest? The answer is in the kind of loop each rule makes. The triadic-closure rule of the friends chapter closes *triangles*, loops of length three — but in a triangle the two nodes flanking a third are themselves directly linked, so there is still



(a) triangle: one route



(b) square: two routes

Figure 9.4: **Why squares multiply routes.** The two highlighted corners are the endpoints. (a) In a triangle they are joined directly — a single shortest route. (b) In a square they are opposite corners, two steps apart by *two* distinct routes (drawn solid and dashed), one around each side. Local rules that close four-cycles, such as gene duplication, thread the network with these redundant shortest paths.

only *one* shortest route between any pair. A triangle adds cohesion but no extra routes. Duplication, by contrast, closes *squares*, loops of length four, and a square is the smallest loop that genuinely offers a choice: its two opposite corners are two hops apart by *two* different paths, one around each side. That single observation is the seed of the boost; the box pushes it a little further, and the takeaway follows.

Figure 9.4 makes the contrast concrete.

**The mathematics behind it: why copying multiplies routes** *(this box can be skipped)*

When a node is duplicated, the copy and the original share all their neighbors, so any two of those neighbors sit at opposite corners of a four-cycle — each such pair instantly gains a second shortest route. A duplicated node of degree $k$ creates $\binom{k}{2} = k(k-1)/2$ such squares in a single stroke. Moreover the duplication rule carries its own preferential attachment, the chance of copying a node being proportional to its degree, which (as in Chapter 5) builds a heavy-tailed degree distribution with exponent $\gamma = 1/q$. Squares are thus laid down in proportion to $k(k-1)$ — the very combination that

Eq. (9.3) says controls the multiplicity — on top of a distribution with many high-degree nodes. Each round of copying compounds the squares laid down by the last, and it is this compounding, rather than any one square, that is the suspected origin of the exponential law, Eq. (9.32), though a full account of it remains open.

The lesson of the box is that squares, not triangles, are what multiply shortest routes. The bubble model lets us test that directly, since it dials the loop length by hand: a chain of $L$ added nodes makes a loop of length $L + 2$. The geometric intuition survives the test (Figure 9.5a). Even-length loops, whose opposite corners enjoy two equal routes, enrich the network more than odd ones: $L = 2$ and $L = 4$ sit well above $L = 1$ and $L = 3$. But the test also sets a limit on how much the geometry explains. Every bubble model, whatever its loop length, stays on the log-quadratic rung. Even loops beat odd ones, and squares beat triangles — yet neither buys the exponential. The square-counting explains why duplication *outruns* triadic closure; the full ferocity of duplication–split needs the compounding above.

One more clue shows that randomness itself plays a role (Figure 9.5b). The Dorogovtsev–Goltsev–Mendes "pseudofractal" network (Dorogovtsev et al., 2002) is a *deterministic* relative of the bubble model, grown by a fixed clockwork rule rather than a random one: at every step, new nodes are added to *every* link at once. Its degree distribution is scale-free with $\gamma = 1 + \ln 3/\ln 2 \approx 2.6$, so by Eq. (9.22) its randomized version should show a power law with $\alpha \approx 0.16$ — and it does. The deterministic original is a power law too, but a *slower* one. Being deterministic it can be solved exactly, as the next section does, and the exponent comes out at $\alpha = 0.100$, comfortably below the 0.161 of its own shuffle. So the deterministic construction falls *below* the random network built from its own degrees. The speed-up is not a property of the loop geometry alone; a clockwork rule that closes loops everywhere at once does worse than chance. It is the interplay of randomness and locality together, not either by itself, that boosts the multiplicity.

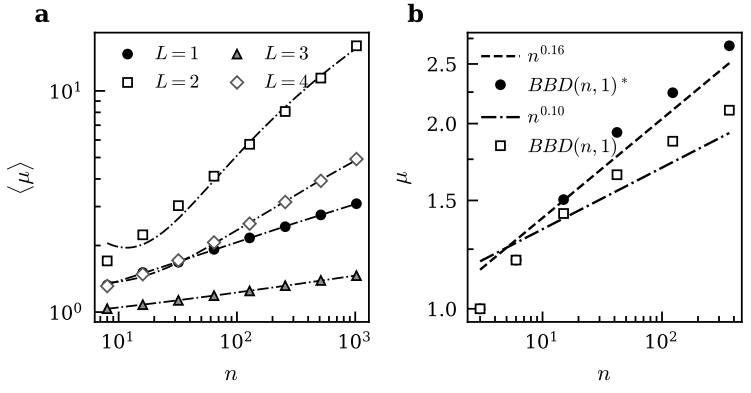



Figure 9.5: **Cycle length and randomness.** (a) The bubble model $BB(n, L)$, which closes loops of length $L$+2. Even $L$ (2 and 4) reaches a higher multiplicity than odd $L$ (1 and 3), as the square-counting predicts — yet every $L$ stays log-quadratic, so cycle geometry alone does not buy the exponential. (b) The deterministic bubble model $BBD(n, 1)$ follows a power law $n^{0.10}$ — found exactly in Section 9.8 — falling *below* its own randomized version $BBD(n, 1)^*$, which grows faster, as $n^{0.16}$ (Eq. (9.22)). Locality without randomness is not enough.

## 9.8 How fast could it possibly grow?

If randomness and locality together drive the multiplicity up, it is fair to ask where the ceiling is. The stochastic rules can only be simulated, but two *deterministic* relatives of the bubble model can be solved exactly, and set against each other they reveal what actually controls the growth. Both replace every link at every step, so both are clockwork versions of the bubble rule; they differ in a single detail. In the first, the subdivided link is *kept*; in the second, it is *removed*. That one choice, it turns out, is the difference between a power law and a stretched exponential.

Keep the link, and you have the deterministic bubble — the pseudofractal web met a moment ago. Start from a triangle and, at

each step, add a new node across every existing link while leaving the old links in place.

**The mathematics behind it: the deterministic bubble grows as a power law** *(this box can be skipped)*

The construction renormalizes: generation $G_{t+1}$ is three copies of $G_t$ glued in pairs at the three corners of the original triangle. Because the two ends of every subdivided link stay adjacent, geodesics inside a copy are undisturbed by the rest of the graph, and the total number of geodesics $S_t = \sum_{i<j} \mu_{ij}$ obeys a closed linear recursion. Its growth ratio converges to

$$\frac{S_{t+1}}{S_t} \longrightarrow \lambda = 10.0494\ldots, \tag{9.33}$$

the largest root of $\lambda^3 - 12\lambda^2 + 20\lambda - 4 = 0$. Each generation triples the node count and so multiplies the number of *pairs* by nine; the average multiplicity $\langle\mu\rangle = S_t/\binom{n_t}{2}$ therefore grows by $\lambda/9$ per generation. Since the size itself grows by a factor of three, this is a power law in $n$,

$$\langle\mu\rangle \sim n^{\alpha}, \qquad \alpha = \frac{\ln(\lambda/9)}{\ln 3} = 0.1004\ldots, \tag{9.34}$$

matched to a relative error of $10^{-6}$ by the twelfth generation. So what looked logarithmic over the reachable sizes (Figure 9.5b) is in fact a slow power law — and slower than the $n^{0.161}$ of the network's own degree-preserving shuffle, confirming from the exact side that the deterministic rule lags its own randomization.

The average is not the whole story. The *largest* multiplicity anywhere in the graph grows faster than the mean: it is exactly the Fibonacci number $\max_{ij} \mu_{ij} = F_{t+2}$, which in terms of the size is $n^{\ln\varphi/\ln 3} = n^{0.438}$, with $\varphi = (1+\sqrt{5})/2$ the golden ratio. Even in this most sluggish of our constructions, the best-connected pair of nodes already accumulates routes at a respectable clip.

Now remove the link instead. Replacing rather than subdividing gives the *diamond lattice* (Migdal, 1975; Kadanoff, 1976). In its general $(b, s)$ form, start with a single link joining two poles $A$ and $B$ and, at each generation, replace *every* link by $b$ parallel paths of $s$ links each. The standard diamond is $b = s = 2$: every link becomes two parallel two-link paths (Figure 9.6a). It is the same lattice on which Chapter 6 watched the Ramsey community number become a

renormalization-group crossing.

**The mathematics behind it: the multiplicity between the poles** *(this box can be skipped)*

The construction is exactly renormalizable, because distinct copies of the previous generation meet only at their corners. Read it backwards — deflation — and generation $G_t$ is $b$ parallel branches, each made of $s$ copies of $G_{t-1}$ in series. Two rules suffice. Along a series, lengths add and multiplicities *multiply*, since a route must make each choice in turn. Across $b$ parallel branches of *equal* length, multiplicities *add*, since each branch offers its own routes and all tie. So the pole-to-pole distance $D_t$ and multiplicity $P_t \equiv \mu_{AB}$ obey

$$D_t = s\, D_{t-1} = s^{\,t}, \qquad P_t = b\, P_{t-1}^{\,s}, \tag{9.35}$$

with $P_0 = 1$. The second is nonlinear, but taking $\log_b$ linearizes it, $\log_b P_t = 1 + s \log_b P_{t-1}$, a geometric recursion whose solution is

$$P_t = b^{\,(s^t-1)/(s-1)} \xrightarrow{\;b=s=2\;} 2^{\,2^t-1} = 2^{\,D_t-1}, \tag{9.36}$$

a *doubly* exponential count. (Equation (9.36) has been checked against direct construction of the lattice for $(b, s)$ equal to $(2, 2)$, $(3, 2)$, $(2, 3)$, $(4, 2)$ and $(3, 3)$.) The reason is transparent: a shortest route must thread $(s^t - 1)/(s - 1)$ successive scales, and at each one it independently picks one of $b$ parallel branches, so the choices multiply.

The poles are a special pair, so the average over *all* pairs needs its own argument — and it is here that the diamond's rigidity pays off again.

**The mathematics behind it: from the poles to the average** *(this box can be skipped)*

The key geometric fact is that every node lies on some pole-to-pole geodesic,

$$d(v, A) + d(v, B) = D_t, \tag{9.37}$$

proved by induction on $t$: within a replaced link the two poles of the sub-copy inherit the property, and any detour around a parallel branch is strictly longer. So a node is characterized by the single

number $d(v, A)$ — the lattice is, in this sense, one-dimensional. Now split the pairs into those internal to one copy of $G_{t-1}$ and those spanning two copies. The total geodesic count $S_t = \sum_{u<v} \mu_{uv}$ then satisfies

$$S_t = 4\, S_{t-1} + \mathrm{Inter}_t, \tag{9.38}$$

the four being the number of copies in the $b = s = 2$ cell, and $\mathrm{Inter}_t$ a convolution of the two copies' pole-path counts, weighted by the factor $P_{t-1}$ that any route pays to cross the shared corner. Carrying the recursion out exactly gives the average $\langle\mu\rangle_t = S_t/\binom{n_t}{2}$ as

$$\langle\mu\rangle_t \;\sim\; \kappa\,\frac{2^{\,2^t}}{4^t} \;\approx\; 2.1\,\frac{P_t}{n_t}, \qquad \kappa \to 1.576, \tag{9.39}$$

where the prefactor $\kappa$ is the fixed point of the corner-transit convolution. So the average merely tracks the pole value divided by the node count: the sum is dominated by near-antipodal pairs, which inherit a geodesic count of order $P_{t-1}^2 \sim P_t$.

Equation (9.39) is expressed in the generation $t$; the scaling with size follows by inverting the node count.

**The mathematics behind it: the stretched exponential** *(this box can be skipped)*

Generation $t$ carries

$$n_t = \tfrac{1}{3}\big(2\cdot 4^t + 4\big) \simeq \tfrac{2}{3}\,4^t, \tag{9.40}$$

so $4^t \simeq \frac{3}{2}n$ and therefore $2^t \simeq \sqrt{3n/2}$. Substituting both into Eq. (9.39), the doubly exponential in $t$ becomes a *stretched exponential* in $n$:

$$\langle\mu\rangle \approx a\, e^{\,b\sqrt{n}}, \qquad b = \sqrt{\tfrac{3}{2}}\,\ln 2 \approx 0.849, \qquad a = \tfrac{2\kappa}{3} \approx 1.05. \tag{9.41}$$

The rate $b$ is exact; $a$ is the amplitude of the leading term, since $\ln\langle\mu\rangle \simeq b\sqrt{n} + \ln a$ and the algebraic factor $1/n$ from Eq. (9.39) is subleading against $\sqrt{n}$. Retaining it, the reduced form $\langle\mu\rangle \simeq a\, e^{\,b\sqrt{n}}/n$ reproduces the exact values to better than 1% from $t = 4$ on.

The numbers are worth seeing, because they are exact rather

than fitted (Figure 9.6b). By the sixth generation the diamond has only 2732 nodes, yet an average pair is joined by some $7 \times 10^{15}$ distinct shortest paths. This is the fastest growth among the constructions we can solve by hand — but it is not, in fact, the fastest in the chapter. Duplication–split grows *exponentially* in the size, Eq. (9.32), and an exponential in $n$ outruns a stretched exponential in $\sqrt{n}$. Perfect, maximally symmetric, deterministic branching is a formidable generator of redundant routes, yet a stochastic rule that copies whole neighborhoods is more formidable still. There is no ceiling here; there is a hierarchy, and copying sits at the top of it.

The two exactly solvable constructions, placed side by side, say exactly what the gap between them requires. Both are deterministic, both self-similar, both replace every link at every step; they differ only in whether the subdivided link survives. Keep it, and the two ends of every bubble stay one hop apart, so distances grow only logarithmically and the multiplicity crawls up the power law of Eq. (9.34). Remove it, and the poles separate as $D_t = s^t$, so a route must make an independent branch choice at every one of a growing number of scales, and those choices compound into the stretched exponential of Eq. (9.41). It is not the closing of a cycle that decides how fast routes multiply, but whether the cycle *separates* the two nodes it joins. A triangle joins adjacent nodes and adds nothing; a square holds its corners two hops apart and doubles their routes; and a rule that drives its endpoints geometrically apart, scale after scale, is what makes the count run away.

## 9.9 Two sides of one coin

Because local rules also create communities, and the number of communities grows along with the network, we can ask how the multiplicity depends on the number of communities directly. The relationship is a clean one (Figure 9.3b and d): linear for every local model tested, and — once again the exception — exponential for duplication–split. This is the empirical correlation of Deng et al. (2026) restated from the inside: more communities go hand in hand with more shortest paths.

The two exactly solvable constructions turn this from a plausible claim into a demonstration. Both carry communities, and — as

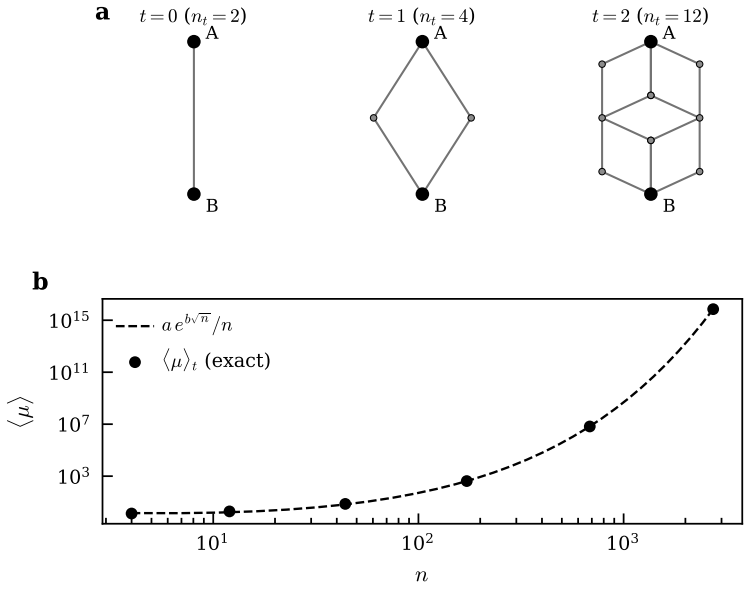



Figure 9.6: **The diamond lattice, solved exactly.** (a) The diamond lattice: every link is replaced, at every generation, by two parallel two-link paths. (b) Its average multiplicity, computed exactly, follows the stretched exponential of Eq. (9.41) across fifteen decades. With 2732 nodes, a typical pair of nodes is already joined by some $7 \times 10^{15}$ equally short routes — the fastest of the deterministic constructions, though still slower than the exponential growth of duplication–split.

Chapter 6 found for each — both carry the *same* number of them, growing as $\langle \kappa \rangle \sim \sqrt{n}$. Their community structure is therefore identical in this respect, while their multiplicities could hardly differ more: one a slow power law in size, the other a stretched exponential. Eliminating the size between multiplicity and community count lays the two laws side by side,

$$\langle \mu \rangle \sim \langle \kappa \rangle^{0.201} \quad \text{(bubble)}, \qquad \langle \mu \rangle \sim a\, e^{\, b' \langle \kappa \rangle} \quad \text{(diamond)}, \quad (9.42)$$

a weak power of the community count in the one case, an exponential in it in the other. Were communities the *cause* of redundant paths, two networks with the same community growth would have to show the same $\langle\mu\rangle$ against $\langle\kappa\rangle$. They flatly do not. The correlation is genuine in both, but its very shape is inherited from the rule that grew the network, not from any traffic between the paths and the communities.

But the point of the chapter is that this partnership is not a case of one causing the other. "Local rules boost shortest path multiplicity" and "communities accompany high shortest path multiplicity" are two true statements about the same networks, and as descriptions they say the same thing. Only one of them, however, names a *mechanism*. Communities are something an algorithm reads off a finished network after the fact; the local rule is the process that actually built that network, node by node, closing the very loops that both carve it into communities and thread it with redundant routes. Community structure and path multiplicity are two sides of a single coin — and the coin is locality.

## 9.10 Real networks

Models are one thing; the networks we started from are another. Three systems can be caught at different stages of their growth, which is what we need if we are to watch $\langle\mu\rangle$ move with $n$ (Figure 9.7). The Internet at the level of autonomous systems, mapped daily over several years (Leskovec and Krevl, 2014). The protein interaction networks of a dozen organisms (Stark et al., 2006), which stand in for successive stages of evolution. And the co-authorship network of the `cond-mat` preprint archive (arXiv.org submitters, 2024), accumulated year by year. In each case we can also compute the excess degree $c_2$ and so plot the mean-field expectation $c_2/e$ alongside the measurement — the random network with the same degrees. The data are noisy and the systems are not stationary, so no strong claim is available; but the trends are instructive.

One measurement choice needs stating, because these networks — unlike the models — are not connected, and the connected fraction itself changes as they grow. Averaging the multiplicity over *all* pairs would then confound two things: the redundancy of routes, which is

what we are after, and the swelling of the giant component, which is not. So we average only over pairs that are actually joined, writing

$$\langle \mu \rangle_c = \frac{\langle \mu \rangle}{\psi}, \tag{9.43}$$

with $\psi$ the fraction of node pairs connected at all — the convention of Deng et al. (2026). The correction is nothing for the Internet, where $\psi = 1$ throughout, but real for the rest: $\psi$ runs from 0.64 to 1 across the protein networks and from 0.007 to 0.89 across the co-authorship snapshots, the smallest values belonging to the earliest and sparsest. Reporting $\langle \mu \rangle_c$ keeps the trends below about routes between reachable nodes, not about how many nodes have become reachable.

In every system the multiplicity rises with size, and in every system it is high: the human protein network reaches $\langle \mu \rangle_c \approx 64$, meaning a typical connected pair of proteins is joined by some sixty-four equally short chains of interaction. The protein networks are also the ones that climb *exponentially* with size, which is the signature of duplication — and gene duplication is, of course, exactly how they are thought to grow (Chapter 4). The Internet and the co-authorship network both climb as power laws, more sedately.

The most interesting feature, though, is which side of the mean-field line each system falls on. The Internet sits *below* its random expectation, and it is *disassortative*, its hubs presiding over peripheries of poorly connected nodes; such a star-like arrangement gives a route no alternatives, since everything must pass through the hub. The co-authorship network sits *above* it, and it is *assortative*, its well-connected authors writing with one another, a clique of hubs being exactly what furnishes many equally short ways across. The protein networks are disassortative and duly fall below the line. It is tempting to read the deviation straight off the correlations — disassortative below, assortative above — but that reading is a coincidence of these three systems, not a law. The exactly solvable constructions settle it: the deterministic bubble and the diamond are *both* disassortative, yet the first falls far below the mean-field line and the second towers enormously above it. The sign of the correlations does not fix the sign of the deviation. What does is the architecture the growth rule builds — something the mean-field

calculation, which knows the network only through $c_2$, cannot yet capture. It is one of the clearer invitations this book leaves open.

## 9.11 Summary

The shortest paths of real networks are richly redundant, and that redundancy travels with their community structure. For a random network the redundancy is no mystery: it is the branching factor, $\langle\mu\rangle \approx c_2/e$, and it grows only as fast as the hubs allow — not at all when $\gamma > 3$, logarithmically at $\gamma = 3$, as a power law below it. Networks built by local rules leave that baseline behind, log-quadratically for most rules and exponentially for duplication, which closes the four-cycles that give opposite corners two shortest routes apiece. Neither cycle geometry nor locality is sufficient by itself: a deterministic rule that closes loops everywhere at once does worse than chance. Two such rules can be solved exactly, and what separates their power law from their stretched exponential is not the closing of a cycle but whether the cycle drives its endpoints apart. Fastest of all, though, is none of the clockwork constructions but the stochastic duplication–split rule, whose exponential growth outruns even the diamond lattice: copying whole neighborhoods is the most efficient generator of redundant routes we have found. Since the same local rules also produce the communities, the observed tie between path multiplicity and communities is best understood not as cause and effect but as two consequences of one underlying local dynamics.

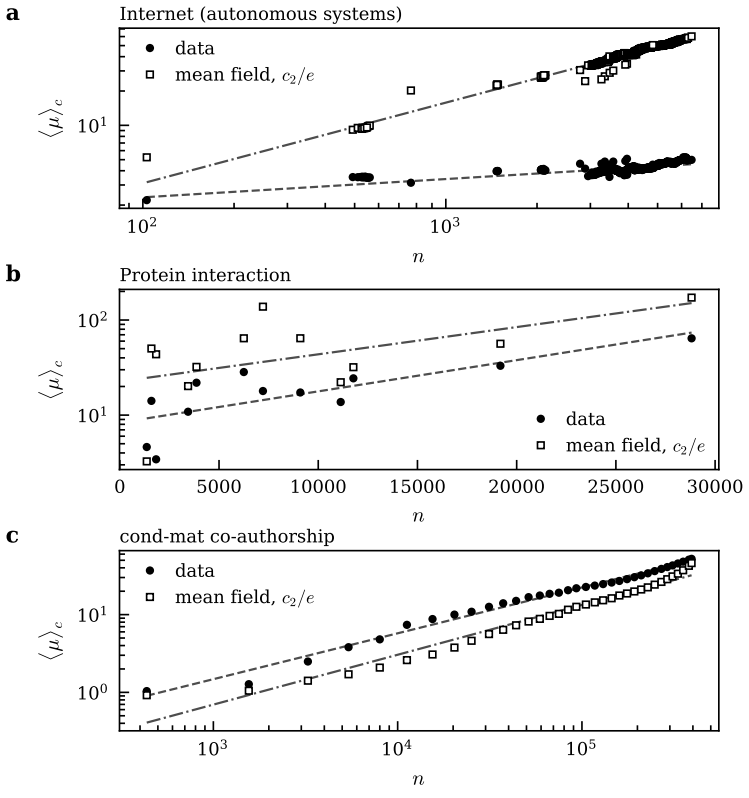



Figure 9.7: **Real networks.** Average multiplicity over connected pairs, $\langle\mu\rangle_c$ (Eq. (9.43)), against size, with the mean-field expectation $c_2/e$ for a random network of the same degrees. (a) The Internet at the autonomous-system level: a power law, falling below the random expectation — the mark of disassortative, star-like wiring. (b) Protein interaction networks of a dozen organisms: exponential growth, the duplication signature, reaching $\langle\mu\rangle_c \approx 64$ for the human network. (c) `cond-mat` co-authorship: a power law lying *above* the random expectation, as assortative mixing among prolific authors provides many equally short routes.

# Chapter 10

# Outlook

## 10.1 One principle, many faces

We have now followed a single idea through six concrete settings, and it is worth gathering the threads before asking what lies beyond them. In every case the network grew by a *local* rule — a newcomer acting only on a node it had reached and that node's immediate neighbors — and in every case the same family of global regularities emerged unbidden.

Searchable networks, such as the citation graph and the World Wide Web, grow by exploration: a newcomer surfs along links and connects to what it finds. Modeling the surfer as the very random walk that defines Google's PageRank, we found that a page's visiting probability rises in a straight line with its in-degree, so that the local act of walking manufactures an effective "rich get richer." From it follow a power-law degree distribution whose exponent is fixed purely by how the network is explored, a clustering hierarchy in which cliquishness falls with degree, and generically disassortative correlations (Chapter 2).

Social networks grow by introduction: a friend introduces a friend, closing a triangle. Formalizing the friend-of-a-friend as a *potential link*, born in proportion to degree, we recovered the same rich-get-richer and the same clustering hierarchy — but now with *assortative* correlations, the well-connected keeping one another's

company (Chapter 3). The contrast with the searchable networks is that chapter's quiet lesson: the sign of the degree correlations is not a free parameter but a readout of whether the rule reaches outward, to the periphery, or inward, within a neighborhood.

Biological networks grow by copying: a gene is duplicated, its protein inheriting all of the ancestor's interactions, and the copies then diverge. Because a node gains a link whenever one of its neighbors is duplicated, copying too is a rich-get-richer engine; self-interactions seed the clustering hierarchy, and coupling divergence to duplication adds a density transition and a multifractal degree distribution born of inheritance, alongside the disassortative mixing measured in real protein networks (Chapter 4). Here the three mechanisms met in one sentence: a rule that attaches to a *neighbor* of a randomly chosen node attaches in proportion to degree, because a well-connected node simply belongs to more neighborhoods. Preferential attachment, the clustering hierarchy, and the degree correlations are all the generic harvest of locality.

The same copying, carried into project schedules, refines each activity either by duplicating it into parallel copies or by splitting it into specialized sequential parts. The rule predicts identical power laws for an activity's predecessors and successors, a critical path that vanishes as a fraction of large projects, and a fractal rather than small-world geometry — all borne out in seventy-seven real construction projects — and it relocates the risk of delay from the celebrated critical path to a percolation threshold set by the whole network's average degree (Chapter 5).

Finally, locality proved to shape structure above the level of the individual node. The same rules that set the degrees also segregate the network into communities — even when every node is identical — a fact we made precise through the Ramsey community number, the size beyond which communities are all but certain (Chapter 6). And not only whether communities appear, but how many: across close to a hundred real networks the number of communities was found to grow as a power law of size, $B \propto n^{\beta}$ with $\beta$ between one half and two thirds — super-fractal, and reproduced by the same local rules. Locality also threads the network with redundant shortest paths, multiplying the routes between nodes far faster than chance and in lockstep with those very communities (Chapter 9).

And with that, the book comes full circle. We set out asking where the global regularities of real networks come from — their power-law degrees, their small-world distances, their clustering hierarchy, their degree correlations — and answered, one mechanism at a time, that none of them need be imposed from above: each emerges from a way of growing in which no node ever uses more than local knowledge. A node that surfs to a neighbor, befriends a friend, is copied from an ancestor, or refines a task asks nothing of the network as a whole — and yet the networks these humble acts build carry, in the aggregate, the full and unmistakable signature of real complex systems.

## 10.2 What remains to be done

If the thesis of this book is right, it opens more questions than it closes.

Several are concrete. The exponential growth of shortest path multiplicity under the duplication–split rule — so much faster than the log-quadratic growth of every other rule we studied — still wants a full explanation; the square-counting argument shows why copying outruns triadic closure, but not why it runs away exponentially. The exactly solvable constructions have sharpened the question rather than closed it. They show that what governs the speed is not the closing of a cycle but whether the cycle drives its endpoints apart: retaining the subdivided link gives a power law, removing it a stretched exponential (Chapter 9). And they show that even the fastest of them, the diamond lattice with its stretched exponential in $\sqrt{n}$, is beaten by the stochastic copying rule, whose growth is exponential in $n$ outright. So the open question is pointed: why does duplicating whole neighborhoods outrun even maximally symmetric deterministic branching?

A second concrete gap sits beside it. The mean-field theory of the multiplicity knows the network only through its excess degree $c_2$, and that is demonstrably not enough: real networks fall on either side of the $c_2/e$ line, the co-authorship graph above it and the Internet below. It is tempting to pin the split on the degree correlations, but the solvable constructions forbid that shortcut — the deterministic bubble and the diamond are both disassortative, yet one sits far

below the line and the other far above. What sets the deviation is the architecture the rule builds, not the sign of its correlations. A theory that predicts that deviation from the rule itself would close the gap between the calculation and the data, and would say something the models cannot yet say about which real systems are route-rich and which are not.

The Ramsey community number has moved further still, though not in the direction one might have hoped. That it depends on the method used to detect the communities was always plain. Now that it can be computed exactly, we can say how far that dependence goes: on one and the same web, under one and the same partition, a plain block model puts $r_\kappa$ at 1095 and a degree-corrected one at 42, and the two disagree about which cut is best (Chapter 6). The dependence is not a rounding error to be argued away; it is a factor of twenty-five, and it means a bare Ramsey number quoted without its detection rule is not a property of the network at all. Yet the same calculations hand us the beginnings of a repair. Underneath the method-dependent threshold there is a method-independent quantity: the evidence density flows to $\ln K$ per link, the entropy of resolving which of $K$ communities a link belongs to, and that value knows nothing of the lattice, the degrees, or the priors. A definition of emergence built on the invariant rather than on the crossing — on the rate at which evidence accumulates rather than on the size at which it clears an arbitrary bar — would put the whole idea on firmer ground.

One question spans both chapters at once, and it may be the most inviting of all. The ring — the barest case we can solve, a lattice with no growth and no randomness in it — turns out to be split into communities exactly when its links outnumber its nodes, which is to say exactly when it carries an extensive number of independent cycles. And cycles are also what multiply its shortest paths. Whether that accounting is general, or an accident of the ring's simplicity — whether the surplus of links over nodes is the common currency of both communities and redundant routes — would fold the last two chapters into a single statement. The book's thesis makes the question natural; it does not answer it.

Two smaller loose ends deserve naming, since both have the flavor of a clue rather than a nuisance. The number of communities

that best describes a self-similar network grows as $\sqrt{n}$ — proved exactly for the solvable lattices, where the optimum sits at the geometric midpoint of the network's own hierarchy, and the same $\sqrt{n}$ governs the shortest paths there. Real networks, though, divide *more* finely: their community count grows as $n^{\beta}$ with $\beta$ measured between one half and two thirds, above the self-similar value. What carries a real network past the fractal $\sqrt{n}$ — what extra structure, absent from the self-similar models, its growth builds in — is a concrete open question the exponent now makes measurable. And the Ramsey number's climb with cycle length carries a persistent even–odd alternation, odd cycles bringing communities on sooner than the even cycles around them. It is too regular to be noise and has no explanation.

Even the self-organized critical state of the exhaustive searcher, where a scale-free network appears across a whole range of the control parameter rather than at one fine-tuned value, deserves to be connected more tightly to the wider physics of criticality.

Others are programmatic, and the largest of them is the price we paid for solving anything exactly at all. Every closed form in the last two chapters — the ring's evidence, the diamond's renormalization group, the pseudofractal's counts — lives on a *deterministic* lattice, a fixed construction rather than a grown network, with the candidate partition handed to the calculation rather than found by an algorithm. That is what made the algebra possible, and it is also the catch: those results bound and illuminate the simulated ones, but they do not reproduce them. Whether the renormalization-group map survives off the lattice — exactly, or on average, for networks grown at random by a local rule — sets how far this reading of emergence extends. It is a demanding question, because on disordered networks detectability is itself a genuine phase transition, and the threshold we have been computing would become the edge of a phase rather than the crossing of a bar. The reward would be a theory of emergence for the networks we actually care about, rather than for their crystalline cousins.

Throughout, we read each local rule *forward*, from mechanism to statistics; the empirical chapters hint at the reverse problem — reading the rule *backward*, inferring from a single observed network which local moves grew it, and with what parameters, as we did when

fitting a duplication index to project schedules. A general inverse theory, turning measured correlations, clustering hierarchies and community structure into an estimate of the underlying rule, would make these models genuinely diagnostic. And real networks are surely not grown by one rule in isolation: a social graph is part introduction and part search, a cellular network part duplication and part fresh interaction. How competing local moves combine — whether their signatures simply add, or interfere to produce something neither would alone — is largely open.

The setting, too, can be widened. The networks of this book are mostly unweighted, undirected and static, whereas real ones carry weights, directions, timestamps, and several kinds of link at once. Whether the locality principle survives into weighted, temporal and multilayer networks — and what new regularities it might generate there — is a natural frontier. So is the coupling of growth to *function*: the percolation of delays through a project schedule was a first glimpse of a dynamics running on a network that local rules had built, and the interplay between how a network grows and what it then does promises more than either studied alone.

None of these questions threatens the central claim; each extends it. Local rules are the driving mechanism; everything else follows.

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